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81st SESSION OF UNITED NATIONS GENERAL ASSEMBLY

After Trump’s ‘annihilation’ threat, Pezeshkian says Iran won’t surrender

Duelling speeches come amid first shuttle talks between US and Iran

Reuters
Dubai, United Nations, September 23

IRAN AND the United States remain far apart on how to end their war but diplomacy must continue, a senior Iranian official told *Reuters* Wednesday, after Iran’s president told the UN General Assembly Tehran would never surrender to US pressure. Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian, in his speech in New York, condemned what he called “signs of a bullying mentality” from US President Donald Trump, who had used the same forum on Tuesday to threaten to “annihilate” Iran.

The duelling speeches at the annual UN gathering bookended the first shuttle talks between the US and Iran for months, though they appeared to have yielded no concessions in the public stance of either side

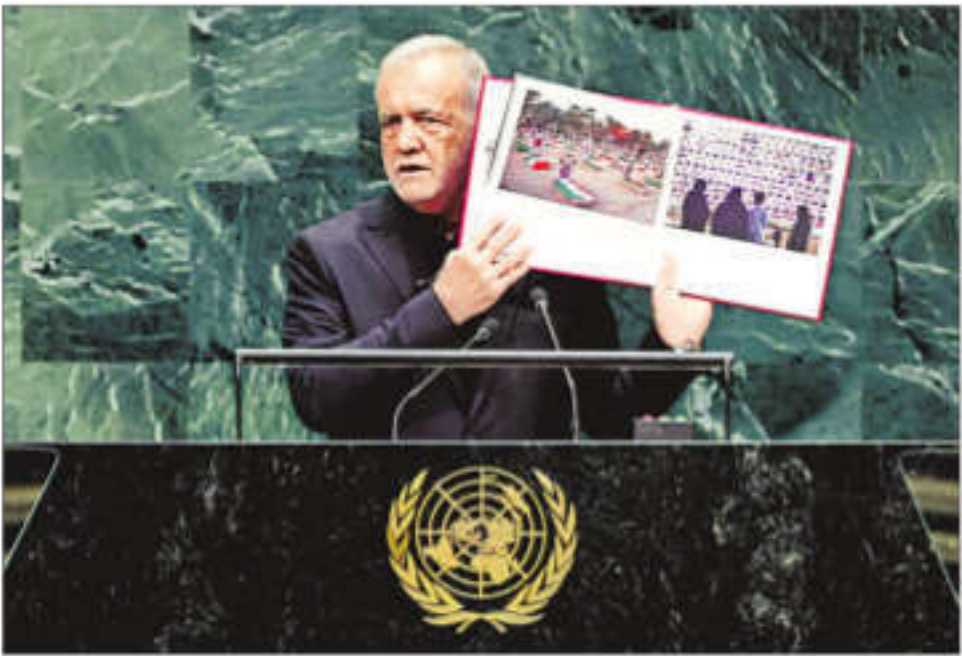
towards ending the war.

The senior Iranian official, speaking on condition of anonymity, said Tehran was reviewing Washington’s response to its peace proposals, which prioritise lifting a US naval blockade on Iranian ports and reopening the Strait of Hormuz.

“There are still many differences between the Iranian and US positions, but diplomacy is continuing,” the official said.

US Secretary of State Marco Rubio told reporters on Wednesday that a deal with Iran would involve hard work over a period of time, adding that Trump also had military options.

The US has also said it will impose so-called secondary sanctions against any country that allows Iranian flights after Wednesday. Mohsen Rezaei, secretary of Iran’s Supreme National Security Council, told state TV Iran would ensure



Iran’s President Masoud Pezeshkian holds up photographs during his speech at the UNGA in New York on Wednesday. AP

neighbouring countries’ airports could not function if they stop Iranian flights.

In his address to the 193-member General Assembly, Pezeshkian homed in on the US blockade of Iranian ports and on the Strait, conduit for a fifth of global oil and liquefied natural gas shipments before the war.

“It cannot be the case that everyone benefits from the Strait

of Hormuz while we are denied access to shipping through this waterway. The permanent deployment of hostile fleets and the expansion of the war will not lead to peace,” he said. “The Iranian people will not bow to pressure,” he added.

Iran wants to exert control over the strait and collect fees from ships that use it. Washington rejects this and says the strait

must remain fully open to international shipping.

Trump on Tuesday argued that he had prevented Tehran from obtaining a nuclear weapon and could “annihilate the Islamic Republic” if no deal is reached to end the conflict.

Pezeshkian on Wednesday reiterated Iran’s line that it is not seeking nuclear weapons.

Iranian and US officials held their first known indirect talks on Tuesday since a ceasefire collapsed in July, with Iran’s Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi and US envoys Steve Witkoff and Jared Kushner communicating through mediators.

Iranian Foreign Ministry spokesperson Esmail Baghaei said Tehran had conveyed conditions during a two-hour exchange of messages with Washington via Qatari mediator. It included an end to war, a halt to US “acts of aggression” and release of frozen Iranian assets.

The diplomatic contact in New York caused a backlash in Iranian media associated with hardliners.

Golan will remain Syrian land, says Al-Sharaa as he hits out at Israel



President Ahmed al-Sharaa at the 81st session of the UNGA in New York

Associated Press
United Nations, September 23

SYRIA’S INTERIM president harshly criticised Israel’s occupation of southern Syria and said the Golan Heights is an inseparable part of his country.

In a speech to the UN General Assembly, Ahmad al-Sharaa said that Israel has carried out more than 500 air and artillery strikes on the country since he took power nearly two years ago.

Israel has also carried out 1,200 land incursions and detained nearly 300 people, Al-Sharaa said.

Al-Sharaa also condemned Israel’s control over the Golan Heights, which it captured from Syria in the 1967 Mideast war and annexed in 1981.

The United Nations and most of the international community consider the occupied territory Syrian land and do not recognize Israel’s annexation.

“No attempts at imposing a fait accompli can undermine the legitimacy of our state, the sovereignty of our law, or the force of international law,” al-Sharaa said. “The Golan will remain a Syrian land.”

Israel has occupied a portion of southern Syria since Assad was toppled, calling it a defensive move to prevent potential attacks on its territory.



United States Secretary of State Marco Rubio (right) with Russian Foreign Minister Sergey Lavrov in New York on Wednesday. REUTERS

Rubio: Moscow, Kyiv have voiced interest in ‘limited ceasefire’

Reuters
United Nations, September 23

UKRAINE AND Russia have both voiced an interest in a limited ceasefire involving grain and energy-related targets, US Secretary of State Marco Rubio said on Wednesday after meeting Russian Foreign Minister Sergei Lavrov in New York.

“I think both sides have expressed an interest in some limited ceasefire that involve grain and energy. Obviously, you know, that won’t be easy either,” Rubio told reporters.

Russia has given no public indication it is ready to agree a maritime or energy truce with Ukraine and it was not clear if

Rubio was suggesting there had been movement on the Russian side after his talks with Lavrov.

Rubio noted it was a particular challenge that energy strikes were at the core of both countries’ tactical priorities in

their war, which is now in its fifth year.

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy, who was expected to address the General Assembly later on Wednesday, met US President Donald Trump on Tuesday and said they had discussed a ceasefire on energy-related targets.

The Ukrainian president told leaders at United Nations earlier that Kyiv was ready for a maritime truce in the Black Sea based on proposals such as by Egypt, India and Turkey and said it was now up to Russia to respond.

Ahead of the Lavrov-Rubio meeting, the Kremlin said there were no grounds for wider Ukraine peace talks.

“For now, there are no prerequisites for moving on to a peaceful negotiating track, although we, as the Russian side, remain open to peace talks,” Kremlin spokesman Dmitry Peskov told reporters.

Trump plans grand spectacle for potentially tense talks with Xi

Reuters
Washington, September 23

US PRESIDENT Donald Trump welcomes Chinese President Xi Jinping to Washington on Wednesday for a three-day visit where the superpowers’ tensions over trade, technology and Tehran will play out against a backdrop of pomp and ceremony.

For the Chinese leader’s first trip to the US in nearly three years, Trump will greet Xi and his wife on the tarmac when

they arrive Wednesday evening at the Maryland military base that hosts Air Force One.

The fanfare was due to include a state dinner with tech luminaries, a White House military ceremony including jet flyovers and a visit to the National Archives where the original Declaration of Independence and Constitution are housed.

Despite their deep disagreements, both sides pressed ahead with the summit, which analysts said seeks to project stability between the world’s



White House personnel rehearse for the arrival ceremony of Chinese President Xi Jinping. AP

biggest factory and its biggest consumer.

Expectations for a break-

through during Xi’s visit were slim. The countries’ 11-month trade truce sunsets in November, but the two sides are at odds on issues ranging from Taiwan to narcotics and rare-earth minerals.

People familiar with the plans said Xi was likely to forcefully raise Beijing’s claim to Taiwan, a topic Washington would prefer to avoid, while Trump was likely to maintain firm US export controls despite Xi’s objections.

But talks set for Thursday could nonetheless yield deals to

lower tariffs in specific sectors, cooperate on drug trafficking and expand military-to-military dialogue.

Trump is expected to seek the release of some Americans and others detained in China, according to the people. The two countries could also agree to talk more on AI, where they are in fierce competition but mindful of growing dangers.

The meeting comes at a difficult moment for Trump, who faces falling approval numbers as public discontent with his

war on Iran grows. Xi, while also facing challenges at home, arrives in a seemingly stronger position, with his country’s trade engine roaring.

The leaders themselves may not feel they need to compromise, analysts said.

“The president very much believes that over time the US economy is going to grow, the US will get stronger,” said Edward Kagan, a former White House official now with Washington’s Center for Strategic and International Studies.

WHO chief: Matter of time before US returns to world health agency

Anuradha Mascarenhas
Boston, September 23

WORLD HEALTH Organization (WHO) Director General Tedros Adhanom Ghebreyesus said he hopes the United States will rejoin the global health agency and disclosed that he has been in talks with US Health and Human Services Secretary Robert F Kennedy Jr.

“The US leadership is very important and I want to assure you that we have continued to communicate from outside. It is a matter of time until the US joins the WHO,” Dr Ghebreyesus told reporters at a Health Coverage Fellowship programme conducted by the Centre for Health Communication at the Harvard T H Chan School of Public Health in Boston.

The US formally notified the WHO of its withdrawal in January 2026, citing concerns over the agency’s handling of the COVID-19 pandemic. The move is significant as US has historically been WHO’s largest donor, providing both assessed contributions and voluntary funding. During the 2022-23 biennium, the US contributed \$1.284 billion, according to WHO.

US funding has supported programmes ranging from emergency response and polio eradication to HIV, tuberculosis, immunisation, maternal and child health and other public health initiatives. WHO has said the loss of US support has created major funding gaps, forcing the agency to reprioritise programmes and contain costs.

The importance of the US,



Tedros Adhanom Ghebreyesus

however, extends beyond money. Dr Ghebreyesus pointed to the expertise and global reach of institutions such as the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention and the National Institutes of Health. “No other organisation can replace what WHO does,” its chief said, pointing to its role in coordinating responses to major health crises such as Ebola. “We prefer to play a positive role because US leadership is important,” he said.

Speaking ahead of the second United Nations General Assembly high-level meeting on “Pandemic Prevention, Preparedness and Response” on September 25, Dr Ghebreyesus said the world must not lose sight of the lessons of COVID-19, when health systems were overwhelmed and inequalities were exposed. “Of course, we can never say that the world is prepared enough for the next pandemic,” he said, while adding that global health security has nevertheless been strengthened since COVID-19. He cautioned against “politicising” or “weaponising” pandemics.

Harvey Weinstein sentenced to 15 years in prison for 2006 sexual assault in New York

Associated Press
New York, September 23

HARVEY WEINSTEIN, the disgraced movie mogul, was sentenced in Manhattan to 15 years in prison Wednesday for a felony sex crime in another #MeToo reckoning.

Weinstein’s sentencing for sexually assaulting one-time TV production assistant Miriam Haley followed a legal odyssey spanning more than six years. His 2020 conviction was overturned by New York’s highest court, citing testimony from other women whose allegations weren’t part of the case. A second jury found Weinstein guilty again at a retrial last year.

Once among the most



Harvey Weinstein during his sentencing at the Manhattan Supreme Court, Wednesday. AP

powerful figures in the entertainment industry, Weinstein was an Oscar-winning producer whose hits included *Shakespeare in Love*, *Pulp Fiction* and *Chocolat*. But his downfall came quickly after sexual assault alle-

gations in 2017 set off the #MeToo movement.

Weinstein, 74, is expected to appeal. He is now likely to remain behind bars until at least his late 80s. He has denied raping or sexually assaulting anyone. Seated in a wheelchair, he was quickly wheeled out of the courtroom after the sentencing, while some of his accusers hugged and brushed away tears.

Weinstein faced up to 25 years in prison for sexually assaulting Haley at his Manhattan apartment in 2006. He has already served more than six years as his case has cycled again and again through the criminal justice system. Haley gave her account of the assault at two trials, and addressed the court just be-

fore Weinstein was sentenced.

“Having been sexually assaulted by Harvey Weinstein has had a devastating effect on my life and sense of security that may never go away. Making the decision to speak up will have me looking over my shoulder for years to come,” Haley said. “It’s a life sentence for me.”

“I’ve been further traumatized in exercising my right to hold him accountable. All of this traces back to his actions,” she said, adding she thought about ending her pursuit of justice.

Minutes later, Weinstein apologized in court to those he may have hurt. “I do have remorse for Miriam Haley’s pain, but I have to reiterate my innocence,” he told the judge

• BRIEFLY

ITALY

Colosseum closes for one day after worker plunges to his death



People outside the Colosseum which was closed for a day. REUTERS

ROME’S COLOSSEUM, Italy’s most-visited monument, was closed to the public suddenly on Wednesday to mourn a worker who fell to his death overnight. The 22-year-old man, Andrea Moretti, specialised in working at altitude on ropes. He had been installing cabling for the project that was expected to be completed next month and died inside Colosseum, the archaeological site’s press office said. Premier Giorgia Meloni said the government was deeply shocked and saddened by the death and called for the cause to be determined as quickly as possible. AP

SOUTH AFRICA

Pregnant woman among 11 killed in mass shooting

THREE GUNMEN barged into a small house in an impoverished neighborhood in South Africa and opened fire on a group enjoying a party inside, killing at least 11 people including a pregnant woman, police and local authorities said Wednesday. The motive for the shooting wasn’t known, but some of the shooting victims were known to authorities as part of probes into criminal activity. Police said they were searching for three men but no arrests had been made. AP

GAZA STRIP

Israeli strikes kill 4, target Hamas finance chief

ISRAELI AIRSTRIKES killed at least four Palestinians in Gaza Strip Wednesday, health officials said, and Israel said one of the attacks targeted a Hamas finance chief. Medics said two of the Palestinians, Osama Abu Khater and Mohammad Abu Elwan when an Israeli airstrike hit a vehicle in western Khan Younis. Netanyahu and Defence Minister Israel Katz, in a statement, said Mohammad Abu Elwan was a senior Hamas finance official. REUTERS

• WITH ABOUT 12,000 PEOPLE, THE NATION BECAME INDEPENDENT IN 1968 AFTER LONGTIME COLONIAL RULE UNDER THE UK, NEW ZEALAND, AUSTRALIA AND GERMANY

‘Say our name, Naoero’: A nation renamed stands up at the UN

Associated Press
New York, September 23

HIS VOICE forceful and proud, he rose in front of the world’s largest gathering of leaders on behalf of his nation and announced that he had something important to say.

The tiny South Pacific island nation of Nauru, its president said, had altered its name - and reclaimed its heritage in the process.

“I have travelled far,” David Adeang said Tuesday at the United Nations. What was known to the world for many years as Nauru, Adeang said, was returning to the name and pronunciation of its past: Naoero.



President of Naoero David Ranibok Adeang at the 81st session of UNGA on Tuesday. AP

“There are moments in the life of a nation when its people are called to remember who they have always been,” Adeang said in his speech at the UN General Assembly in New York. “This is such a moment for us.”

Though the names are similar and, in essence, the same word, the shift in spelling and



pronunciation represents the nation’s effort to recast - rebrand, even - itself for its own people as much as for the outside world.

He called it not a change but an effort to “affirm a truth”.

“For many years, the world

has known our country as Nauru. Nauru is how our name sounded to those who found it hard to say, and the world kept it,” Adeang said. “But it is not the name our people used among themselves.”

The nation, an eight-

square-mile island with about 12,000 people, became independent in 1968 after longtime colonial rule under the United Kingdom, New Zealand, Australia and Germany.

It announced the renaming in August after signalling its intent in February.

The country’s international code is changing from NRU to NRO and its people will be known as dei-Naoero instead of Nauruan. Commonly known abroad by the pronunciation of Now-roo, the new name is spoken as Now-ero.

A name, obviously, is a pivotal and intimate expression of a nation’s identity on any stage, domestic or international.

Adeang’s remarks Tuesday reflected this as he carefully pronounced the name to differentiate it from its former pronunciation.

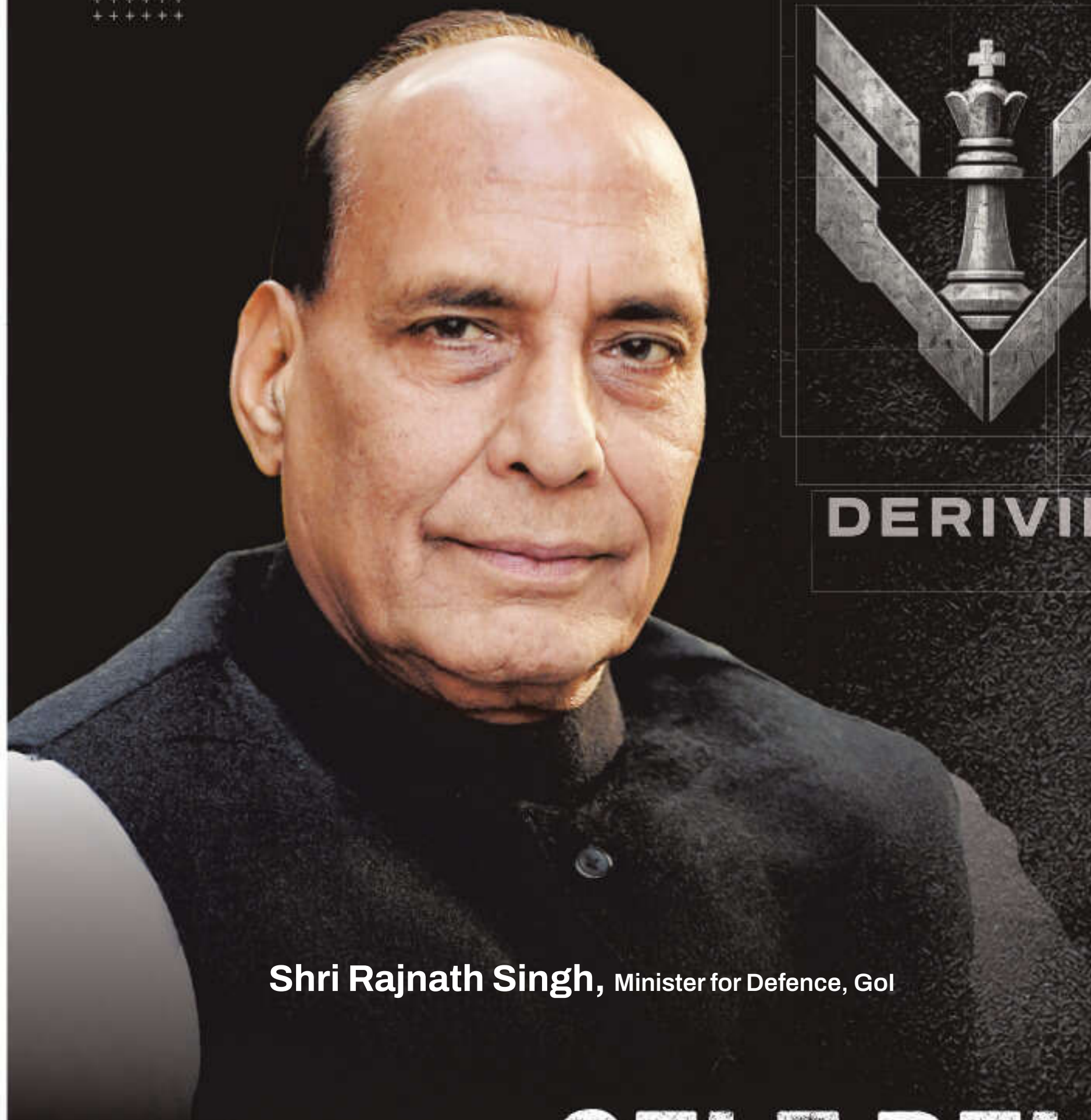
“We do not make this choice to erase our past. We make it because we honor it,” he said.

“That name carries the memory of our ancestors, our language, and our identity. It has been there all along. Never lost, never absent. Today, we restore Naoero.”

And then, after completing his address about the issues that face his people - rising seas, economics, respect on the global stage - he concluded his address with three words: “Say our name.”



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Shri Rajnath Singh, Minister for Defence, GoI

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Governor of Bihar



General NS Raja Subramani, PVSM, AVSM, SM and VSM
Chief of Defence Staff



Admiral Krishna Swaminathan, PVSM, AVSM, VSM
Chief of the Naval Staff, Indian Navy



Shri Rajesh Kumar Singh
Defence Secretary, GoI



Sanjay Jaju
IAS, Chief Secretary, Govt. of Telangana



Dipti Mohil Chawla
Additional Secretary, Ministry of Defence



Denis Alipov
Russian Ambassador to the Republic of India



Dr Jasper Wiecek
Ambassador of the Federal Republic of Germany to India and Bhutan



Rasmus Abildgaard Kristensen
Ambassador of Denmark to the Republic of India



Lt Gen. Puneet Ahuja, AVSM, SM, VSM
Director General Strategic Planning, IHQ, MoD



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Additional Director General & Advisor (Cyber Security), DRDO, Ministry of Defence, GoI



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LEGAL

EC appointment: Why SC placed matter before CJI



AMAAL SHEIKH

A TWO-JUDGE bench of the Supreme Court on Wednesday referred petitions challenging the 2023 law on the appointment of the Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) and other Election Commissioners (ECs) — which excludes the Chief Justice of India (CJI) from the process — to the CJI to consider forming a Constitution Bench (which has a minimum of five judges).

What the joint order said

While Justices Dipankar Datta and Satish Chandra Sharma were split on referring the matter to a larger bench, they agreed that it should be placed before the CJI. They said sending the issue first to a three-judge bench would be of “little worth” and would only delay a final decision on the important Constitutional questions raised by the case.

The judges flagged the long delays in deciding Constitutional references. They noted that the Anoop Baranwal case (2023) took eight years to reach a final judgment and cited other references that remained pending for years. Callings such delays “a source of institutional embarrassment”, they urged the CJI to consider setting up a permanent five-judge bench for Constitutional cases.

The ‘Anoop Baranwal’ case

The challenge to the Chief Election Commissioner and Other Election Commissioners (Appointment, Conditions of Service and Term of Office) Act, 2023 traces its origins to the Supreme Court’s judgment in *Anoop Baranwal v. Union of India* in March 2023. In that ruling, a Constitution Bench had noted that Parliament had not enacted a law governing appointments to the Election Commission despite Article 324 of the Constitution contemplating one. It laid down an interim mechanism under which appointments would be made by a committee comprising the Prime Minister, the Leader of Opposition in Lok Sabha and the Chief Justice of India — until Parliament enacts a law.

The bench had underlined the importance of an independent Election Commission and observed that those entrusted with conducting elections must be insulated from executive influence.

THE 2023 LAW AND THE CHALLENGE IN TOP COURT: A TIMELINE

1950: Article 324(2) of the Constitution is framed. It provides that the Chief Election Commissioner and other Election Commissioners are appointed by the President, subject to any law Parliament may make on the matter.



SEPTEMBER 2026:

A two-judge SC bench delivers a split verdict on petitions challenging the 2023 Act. While Justice Dipankar Datta holds that the challenge could be decided on existing Constitutional principles, Justice Satish Chandra Sharma says it raises substantial and novel Constitutional questions. Both judges issued a joint order referring the matter to the CJI to constitute a Constitution Bench to avoid further procedural delay.

1950-2023: For 73 years, Parliament does not enact any new law on this. Appointments to the Election Commission (EC) are made under the executive framework.

2015: A writ petition is filed under Article 32, challenging the absence of a law governing appointments to the EC.

2018: A two-judge bench refers the matter to a Constitution Bench.

MARCH 2023: Eight years on, a five-judge Constitution Bench delivers its judgment in the ‘Anoop Baranwal’ case, holding that appointments to the EC should be made by a committee comprising the Prime Minister, the Leader of the Opposition and the Chief Justice of India until Parliament enacts a law.

Split verdict

Justice Datta said the petitions could be decided by the present bench. He said the top court had already settled the governing Constitutional principle in *Anoop Baranwal*.

Justice Sharma said a Constitution Bench should hear the case as the SC is examining the Constitutional validity of the 2023 Act for the first time.

ister nominated by the PM and the Leader of Opposition, he observed that a minister bound by collective responsibility “cannot be expected to defy his own nominator”.

Thus, the presence of the Leader of Opposition in the Selection Committee becomes “largely ornamental”, he said. He also emphasised the perception test — “it is not enough for the EC to be independent, it must also appear to be independent”. On the petitioners’ argument that the law gives the executive overwhelming influence over appointments, he said it “does appear to have substance”, while stating that these were only *prima facie* observations.

Justice Datta also rejected the government’s comparison between the EC selection process and the collegium system for judicial appointments. He said judicial appointments involve the executive at multiple stages and described the popular notion that “judges appoint judges” as a “myth”. He raised concerns about the selective implementation of Collegium recommendations and said the absence of a neutral member in the Collegium could not justify the absence of a neutral member in the EC appointment process. He described the comparison drawn by the government as “disingenuous, evasive and disquieting”.

Constitution Bench issue: What Justice Sharma said

Justice Sharma disagreed with Justice

CLIMATE

In parched Maharashtra, why drought can’t be declared yet

Shubhangi Khapre

Mumbai, September 23

CALLSTO declare a drought are rising in Maharashtra, with the El Niño-driven rain deficit hitting the state’s agriculture-dependent economy hard. Water scarcity has compounded the crisis, setting back the kharif season and clouding prospects for rabi. While Opposition leaders, including Sharad Pawar, have asked that a drought be declared, Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis has said the government is taking “all steps necessary” to deal with the “alarming” situation.

Why has drought not been declared officially?

Under the National Disaster Response Fund (NDRF) rules, drought declaration for kharif (the monsoon cropping season, which runs from June to October) requires an assessment that can begin from October 5, once the monsoon starts to withdraw. For rabi, (the winter cropping season from October to April), assessment can be held in March 2027.

There is no single definition of drought accepted across India. States have the authority to declare a drought based on local conditions. But the state government’s report should conform to parameters specified under NDRF norms, and disaster relief funds can be unlocked by the Centre.

Maharashtra has decided to submit a proposal to the Centre for financial assistance after October 5.

The state government has begun surveys and *panchanamas* to assess crop loss, so that the administration can quantify losses in terms of both food production and finances. Once this report is submitted, before releasing relief funds, a central team will visit the affected regions to make its own assessment.

Under NDRF rules, drought declaration is based on crop loss, the moisture adequacy index (used to assess soil health), and rainfall deficit, along with decline in food production and labour migration in search of work. Sowing must fall below 50% of total cultivable kharif/rabi area, drinking water shortage must be severe, groundwater tables

State, Centre roles

There is no single definition of drought accepted across India. States have the authority to declare a drought based on local conditions.

But the state government’s report should conform to parameters specified under NDRF norms, and disaster relief funds can be unlocked by the Centre.

must be shrinking, there must be fodder shortage, and rainfall deficit must be up to 70%. Across Maharashtra, kharif sowing was delayed this season due to erratic rain — instead of June 10, sowing began only on July 15. Post-sowing rain failure then stunted flowering and fruiting. The worst-hit crops are soybean and cotton, the mainstay for small and marginal farmers in Marathwada and Vidarbha. The dry spell has also stunted sugarcane growth in Marathwada and parts of western Maharashtra.

During the monsoon session in July, the CM announced a Rs 40,385-crore farm loan waiver, with an additional Rs 50,000 incentive for those who repaid loans regularly.

What is the water situation?

A major concern is drinking water scarcity. Data up to September 20 shows Maharashtra’s 138 major dams at 85% capacity and 264 medium dams at 65% — down from 96% and 77%, respectively, at the same time last year. The state’s 2,630 small and micro dams are worse off, at just 43%, compared with 57% a year ago.

Regionwise, Marathwada, with the most number of dams at 929, has 46% water as compared with 81% last year. It is followed by Amravati division at 64%, Nagpur division at 72%, Pune at 88%, Nashik at 83% and Konkan at 76%.

What is the status of rainfall in Maharashtra?

According to the India Meteorological Department (IMD), 31 of 36 districts in Maharashtra are rain-deficient, with 20 of these facing a deficit of 25% to 58%. Beyond the deficit, shifting rain patterns have added to the damage: In more than 100 of the state’s 355 drought-hit talukas, gaps between rain spells have stretched to 40-60 days. As a result, the main kharif crop, sown across 147 lakh hectares, has withered.

In a departure from past patterns, where rain did fall, it was short and intense — damaging soil health and causing erosion in some areas. Maharashtra’s agriculture is largely rain-fed; its irrigation potential, at under 20%, is much lower than in states like Uttar Pradesh and Bihar.

POLITICS

4 states out of Uttar Pradesh? Politics behind demand to split most populous state

Vikas Pathak

New Delhi, September 23

UTTAR PRADESH minister and Suheldev Bhartiya Samaj Party leader Om Prakash Rajbhar has claimed the state will be divided into four, and that the Purvanchal region will get a ‘Rajbhar Chief Minister’. At a public meeting Sunday, Rajbhar claimed that Prime Minister Narendra Modi told him that the division could happen after the ongoing caste census.

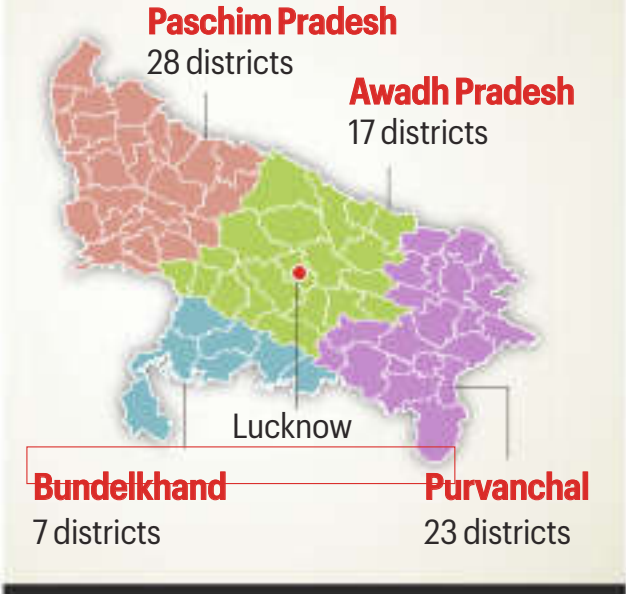
Uttar Pradesh BJP sources brushed it off as pre-poll posturing. “He perhaps wants to energise his cadre by making them believe that he can be Chief Minister and they can also get some posts,” said a state BJP insider who did not wish to be named.

But such a demand is not new. During her tenure as chief minister from 2007 to 2012, Mayawati created ripples by backing a division of the state.

How is a state divided?

This is what Article 3 of the Constitution states: “Parliament may by law... form a new State by separation of territory from

The 2011 proposal for dividing UP



ordinary legislation even without the consent of the state’s Assembly.

The four new states created since 2000, Uttarakhand, Jharkhand, Chhattisgarh, and Telangana, all saw strong people’s movements demanding a separate state. That is not the case in Uttar Pradesh. While

the demand for Bundelkhand has been raised from time to time, even that has cooled down in the past few years.

Why was there a demand for division of Uttar Pradesh?

In November 2011, the Mayawati government moved and passed a resolution in the Assembly proposing to divide the state into Purvanchal, Bundelkhand, Awadh Pradesh and Paschim Pradesh (*see map*). The state government argued that Uttar Pradesh’s vast size made administration and development difficult and that smaller states could lead to better governance.

The resolution was sent to the Centre but was not pursued further by the Samajwadi Party (SP) government that came to power in 2012.

At Mayawati’s peak, such a split would have favoured her. All four regions of the state have a sizable Dalit population, between 16% and 28%. The Scheduled Caste population in all of Uttar Pradesh is around 21%. Her Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) could, therefore, have emerged as a force in four states, establishing itself as a national party

in the eyes of voters.

What further worked for Mayawati in 2011 was that the Yadav population in Uttar Pradesh — the core of then arch-rival SP — was not evenly distributed in terms of its political heft. The SP had two major belts — the Etah-Mainpuri-Etawah-Firozabad belt in the west, and the Yadav belt in eastern Uttar Pradesh around Jaunpur, Azamgarh, Ghazipur and Mau. The move could have split the SP’s Yadav belts and pushed Muslims into voting for the BSP. However, the BSP declined over time and the proposal died before any of this could happen.

Ajit Singh of the Rashtriya Lok Dal (RLD) had also demanded a ‘Harit Pradesh’ in western Uttar Pradesh. The reason: his party’s Jat support base dominates the region; their numbers aren’t high outside western Uttar Pradesh.

What about Rajbhar’s claim?

While for the reasons mentioned above, the SP would not want UP to be divided, any such idea would not work for Yogi Adityanath as well. Right now, apart from his Hindutva image, what raises Adityanath’s

national stature is that he has been Chief Minister of India’s most populous state. For that advantage to continue to accrue to him, UP must remain a single state.

For the BJP, too, the fact that it has won Uttar Pradesh consistently — with a dip in the 2024 Lok Sabha polls — has added to its political heft over the years. Because of its size, its centrality to many Hindu cultural symbols and holy sites, and its being the core of the ‘Hindi heartland’, UP has had tremendous political heft in India, even if it has been economically a largely underdeveloped state.

It is often said that the road to Delhi passes through Lucknow. Indeed, absolute majorities of any party — be it the BJP or the Congress before it — at the Centre have always come on the back of strong performances in Uttar Pradesh. No party has ever won a Lok Sabha majority in India on its own after a poor showing in UP, though there have been instances of coalition governments coming to power after a modest showing in the state. Rajbhar’s claim, therefore, is not one that the BJP, or even the SP, would want to back.



Business as Usual

By EP UNNNY



THE EDITORIAL PAGE P 10

I VOTED FOR THREE DECADES. WHY IS MY S.I.R INCOMPLETE? COMMISSION HAS NO ANSWER
BY SURJIT S BHALLA

THIS ISN'T ABOUT WHO WINS, BUT ABOUT THE CITIZEN'S RIGHT TO HER VOTE
BY MANOJ KUMAR JHA

2 ECs STAND UP TO ASK; CEC MUST ANSWER. SC MUST NOT TURN AWAY

THE IDEAS PAGE P 11

CHIEF ELECTION COMMISSIONER IS NOT THE ELECTION COMMISSION OF INDIA
BY SY QURAISHI

AFTER THE INDIAN EXPRESS INVESTIGATION ON 14 OBJECTIONS RAISED BY TWO ECs

CEC must go, SC should act: Opp chorus after EC divide out in open

Demands for court-monitored probe, SIR pause, fresh polls; CJP announces stir; Opp distances CEC from Commission

Manoj C G & Asad Rehman
New Delhi, September 23

WITH EVERY BJP victory, Opposition parties have been increasingly critical of the Election Commission of India (ECI) alleging infirmities in the electoral process — from “faulty” rolls, SIR “intimidation” to “selective” application of the Model Code of Conduct.

The revelations in the investigation published by *The Indian Express* Wednesday of the divide within reshaped that criticism in two significant ways.

For the first time, Opposition parties decoupled the full Commission from Chief Elec-



Vote chori a crime... direct attack on Constitution... BJP, RSS and EC who organised it have committed an act of treason. Justice will be served.”
RAHUL GANDHI, CONGRESS

“EC exposed... Who is playing with a constitutional body to remain in power? This means govts formed during this period were unconstitutional.”
AKHILESH YADAV, SP



CEC should be arrested.... There will be pan-India protests until Gyanesh Kumar remains CEC... Hold fresh elections with pre-SIR voter lists.”
MAMATA BANERJEE, TRINAMOL CONGRESS

“Corrective action needs to be taken. Otherwise, if people lose faith in elections, what remains of a democracy? Election is the very foundation of a democracy.”
OMAR ABDULLAH, NC



tion Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar, and shifted their attack from the ECI in general to the CEC specifically.

Kumar “must go”, and “he has no right to continue in office”, was their refrain. In tandem, given the nature of the

Constitutional authority, the Opposition said that the Supreme Court — already looking into aspects of the deeply contested SIR — should step in and scrutinise the decisions of the ECI.

The Indian Express reported that two of the ECI’s three Com-

missioners, Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi, had objected, on the record, at least 14 times in 10 months on a range of issues: decisions taken without their knowledge; changes to Form 6 for new voters; deletion and restoration

of voters in the SIR process; glaring gaps in processes that included centralisation of the voter database and its custody. On Wednesday, the

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

MORE REPORTS, PAGE 6

EC NOTE SIGNED BY DEPUTY DIRECTOR

‘Differing views’ part of ‘decision-making’, says EC, does not address concerns two ECs red-flagged

Unanimous process, says poll panel; no mention of why ECs went to Cabinet Secy



The Indian Express investigation published on September 23

Ritika Chopra
New Delhi, September 23

RESPONDING to *The Indian Express* investigation Wednesday that two of its three Commissioners had objected on record at least 14 times in 10 months to decisions taken without their knowledge and glaring gaps in processes, the Election Commission of India (ECI) Wednesday acknowledged these notes but described them as part of the panel’s “decision-making process”. However, it did not respond to any of the concerns raised by the two Commissioners, nor did it state whether or how these concerns had been addressed.

“Differing views and observations are a normal part of deliberation in any institution,” the Commission said in a press note signed by Deputy Director P Pawan. “They are a part of the decision-making process before a final decision is taken.”

The “written notes, observations, technical suggestions and internal checks-and-balances” by its members, it said, were “standard, ongoing practices”, and “the suggestions given by the Commissioners were for further improving the electoral processes”.

In recent months, the note said, the Commission “has taken numerous decisions, issued instructions, introduced around 40 new initiatives and undertaken many electoral reforms including the conduct of Electoral roll revision (including SIR) across the country. All these decisions are an outcome of the unanimous decisions of the full Commission in the past one year.”

It said that highlighting “certain specific internal notes/observations spread over the period of 10 months while overlooking the much larger body of approvals, decisions,

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

E. Why SC referred matter to CJI EXPLAINED

INDEPENDENT ECI NOT ENOUGH, IT MUST ALSO APPEAR TO BE SO: SC JUDGE PAGE 6

‘Still awaited... urgently required’: Goa staff sent 8 emails in 7 days, but EC shut out valid voters

For a Goan, being off the roll costs more than a vote: Dialysis to transplants, state health support scheme open only to voters

Ritika Chopra
Panaji, September 23

NINETY-SEVEN voters may not matter in the world’s largest democracy of over 900 million voters but this story from Goa has national significance.

On Wednesday, *The Indian Express* reported that two Election Commissioners in the three-member Election Commission of India objected on record 14 times in 10 months to

steps taken by the ECI under Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar — from keeping them in the dark to adding new voters and deleting names.

What the two Election Commissioners, Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi, primarily warned against — the centralisation of ECINet and cutting out state ground-level officials — has played out in Goa, and its trail is recorded.

On February 17, four days

before Goa was due to publish its final electoral roll under the Special Intensive Revision (SIR), the state’s Chief Electoral Officer wrote to the ECI in Delhi. This was his eighth time in seven days. Attached was a list of 97 voters whom Goa’s own Electoral Registration Officers (EROs) had heard, examined and found eligible under a process laid down by the Supreme Court.

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

BJP: Smear campaign by Opp, dissent within EC sign of vibrant democracy

Patra targets Congress over past appointment of ECs, their role in party later

Jatin Anand
New Delhi, September 23

DESCRIBING THE Opposition attack on the BJP and demands for the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar as a “smear campaign” aimed at “undermining the institutions of the country”, the BJP Wednesday said dissent within the Election Commission were “signs of a vibrant



BJP spokesperson Sambit Patra

democracy”.

Addressing a press conference after *The Indian Express* reported that Election Commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi had objected on record, at least 14 times in 10 months, to SIR-related decisions taken without their knowledge and glaring gaps in processes, BJP national spokesperson Sambit Patra said dissent among Election Commissioners

MEETING ON SIDELINES OF UNGA SESSION IN NEW YORK

In talks with Rubio, Jaishankar flags India concerns over Russia sanctions

Divya A
New Delhi, September 23

IN THE first official discussion between Delhi and Washington after President Donald Trump signed the Russia sanctions Bill empowering the US to levy tariffs up to 100 per cent on Moscow’s energy buyers, External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar conveyed India’s economic and strategic concerns to Secretary of State Marco Rubio.

The bilateral meeting Wednesday took place on the

External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar with US Secretary of State Marco Rubio in New York, Wednesday. PTI: INDIAN SEAFARER KILLED IN ATTACK ON CARRIER OFF OMAN COAST, PAGE 8



Accused held in Delhi gangrape was police informer earlier: Probe

Mahender Singh Manral
New Delhi, September 23

THE INVESTIGATION into the alleged gangrape of a 17-year-old at Aastha Kunj Park, in Southeast Delhi, has found that one of the three accused earlier worked as a police informer in the same district.

This prior association helped police identify and trace the accused within a few hours of the incident being reported, sources told *The Indian Express*. While the girl was allegedly raped on Monday night, all

INSIDE PAGE 3

‘FEW PCR VANS, DARK ROADS’: LSR STUDENTS FLAG GAPS IN SAFETY

three accused were arrested by Tuesday morning.

According to sources, police personnel identified Asif (34), a vegetable vendor and a former police informer, from the girl’s description. “The police personnel shared Asif’s details

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

• UMADevi, 40, IS IN PSYCHIATRIC CARE AFTER ALLEGEDLY DROWNING HER 4-MONTH-OLD TWIN DAUGHTERS; FAMILY RECOUNTS HER ‘STRUGGLES’ AFTER THEIR BIRTH AND THEIR ATTEMPTS TO PROVIDE HELP

When a mother ‘can’t cope’: Behind Bengaluru woman who ‘killed’ newborn twins

Atiya Firdos
Bengaluru, September 23

THE TRIAL of Lindsay Clancy, the mother accused of killing her three small children in Massachusetts, US, has caught world attention as “America’s saddest murder trial”, and prompted a debate on the mental condition her lawyers say she was suffering from — postpartum psychosis.

It’s not a condition that Ramelingappa SH, 50, a real estate dealer based in Talaghattapura in Bengaluru, had heard of. But, he says, he could see his wife Umadevi, 40, was “struggling”.

The symptoms had lasted at least two-and-a-half months, beginning six weeks after Umadevi delivered their twin daughters. Their birth, on May 5, came after a long wait for the couple and one round of failed IVF. On September 1, Umadevi allegedly drowned the four-month-olds, and was stopped on time as she was trying to kill herself.

Ramelingappa says that while Umadevi appeared to be coping after the birth of the twins, changes in her behaviour were evident after a while. She began sleeping and eating poorly, became withdrawn and repeatedly told her

husband and mother-in-law that she was “frightened” of the babies and did not feel capable of caring for them.

At times, she said she wanted to send the children to an ashram or go there herself, he says.

Geetha Desai, Professor of Psychiatry at NIMHANS and professor in-charge of its Mother-Baby Unit, says these are symptoms typical of postpartum mental illness.

“Women with postpartum depression may experience persistent sadness, anxiety, exhaustion, loss of appetite and difficulty sleeping. Some may also develop a deep sense of inadequacy and feel that they are

• MORE THAN 1 IN 5 AFFECTED

STUDIES PUT the prevalence of postpartum depression at around 22% of new mothers, or more than one in five

POSTPARTUM PSYCHOSIS, a much-rarer condition, may afflict one to two women per 1,000 deliveries, says an expert

A 2018 study of women with postpartum severe mental illness at NIMHANS found 44% of them saw a delay in getting psychiatric care



Umadevi is undergoing treatment at NIMHANS

not capable of caring for their baby,” Desai adds.

Umadevi, who had come to NIMHANS earlier too for treatment, is back at the institute after the death of the twins.

While the Bengaluru Police has registered a case in connection with the deaths and Umadevi’s attempt to take her own life, she is under psychiatric care and her medical condition is being assessed before further course is decided.

Could the deaths have been averted?

Sources familiar with Umadevi’s case say the tragedy could have been prevented had she got medical help on time.

Ramelingappa says they tried, as best as they knew. He and his mother took over the bulk of the care of the twins as Umadevi battled symptoms, and consulted a psychiatrist in Bengaluru. Umadevi met the psychiatrist, but there was no improvement. So, on August 8, the family took her to NIMHANS.

Ramelingappa says the 40-year-old was assessed for postpartum depression, prescribed medication, and advised inpatient psychiatric treatment. But Umadevi refused admission.

“She had seen patients being physically restrained and was afraid the same would happen to her. Her condition

also kept fluctuating. On some days she appeared normal, while on other days she was withdrawn, anxious and struggled to eat or sleep,” Ramelingappa says, describing the ups and downs which also lie at the heart of the Clancy case. The family and ex-husband of Clancy — who is paralysed from waist down after throwing herself out of a window after allegedly killing her children — have sued her doctors for “medical malpractice”, saying they missed the extent of her troubles.

The day of the incident, Ramelingappa was at home till about 12.20 pm, when he had to

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 9

[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

CEC must go: Opp

Congress, Aam Aadmi Party (AAP), Mamata Banerjee's Trinamool Congress (TMC), the Samajwadi Party were among those who addressed press conferences on the ECI's conduct.

These press conferences were in some ways coordinated – sources said the leaders of the Opposition parties exchanged notes throughout the day, keen to devise a strategy to keep the heat on.

The Opposition parties put forward three key demands: the removal of CEC Kumar, an impartial investigation supervised by the top court into the working of the ECI, and halting of the SIR exercise.

“We demand Gyanesh Kumar's immediate removal and a Supreme Court-monitored impartial investigation to expose the rot that has destroyed the ECI's credibility,” Congress leader K C Venugopal said.

His senior party colleague P Chidambaram said “all decisions of the EC in recent years should be reviewed by a Parliamentary Committee.”

In Lucknow, SP leader Akhilesh Yadav asked the Supreme Court to take suo motu cognizance of the matter.

And in Kolkata, the TMC's

Abhishek Banerjee said the CEC must be removed immediately and a court-monitored investigation must be ordered.

“When grave questions affecting the democratic process are repeatedly raised and yet remain unheard, it inevitably raises questions about institutional impartiality. The Supreme Court cannot look away. The buck stops there. Will the CJI-led Bench act?” Banerjee said.

In Chennai, DMK chief M K Stalin demanded that “a fair and thorough investigation” should be carried out into “everything that has transpired within the Election Commission”, and “that those responsible should be held accountable”.

In June this year, 23 Opposition parties had written to Chief Justice of India (CJI) Justice Surya Kant that they believed “democracy is in jeopardy” because of the manipulation of elections and partisan conduct by the ECI.

CEC Kumar’s “brazenly biased conduct”, and his “open, unabashed support of the BJP during the course of and in the outcome of electoral processes”, was a matter of grave concern, the Opposition said in their letter

to the CJI.

Earlier in March, as many as 63 members of Rajya Sabha and 130 of Lok Sabha had moved a motion seeking Kumar's removal. The motion was rejected by the chairs of both Houses on April 6.

On April 24, the Opposition moved a fresh notice in Rajya Sabha seeking the removal of Kumar for “acting in a partisan manner”. The notice remains pending before the Chairman.

The parliamentary process for the removal of the CEC is akin to the impeachment of a judge of a constitutional court – it is lengthy and depends on the numerical strength of parties in the House.

But the revelations in The Indian Express have given the Opposition the opportunity to launch a political campaign.

Leader of Opposition in Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi, who has repeatedly alleged “vote theft by the BJP” and “collusion by the EC”, is likely to address a press conference on Thursday.

“Vote chori is a crime against the Indian people and a direct attack on our Constitution. The BJP, RSS and EC who organised it have committed an act of treason. Justice will be served,” he said.

Congress leader and Lok Sabha MP Priyanka Gandhi Vadra also said that if the CEC

was aware of elections being rigged and had allowed it to happen, it was “treachery” and “an act of treason”.

In Kolkata, Mamata Banerjee said fresh Assembly elections should be held in West Bengal with the pre-SIR voter list, claiming that the BJP and the ECI had “looted” the polls held earlier this year.

In Patna, RJD leader Tejashwi Yadav claimed that Assembly elections in both Bihar and West Bengal had been rigged, and should be held afresh.

Akhilesh Yadav said governments formed during the period when the ECI was “not functioning impartially” were “unconstitutional”.

While all Opposition parties sought the removal of Gyanesh Kumar, AAP chief Arvind Kejriwal, Mamata Banerjee, and Shiv Sena (UBT) leader Uddhav Thackeray also demanded the CEC's arrest.

“There will be protests across India until such time as Gyanesh Kumar remains CEC. He must be immediately arrested and put behind bars. The chair of the CEC is not for a person like him. This is another battle for freedom, this time from the compromised CEC, and the BJP that has destroyed India,” Mamata said.

CEC Kumar should be suspended immediately, Rajya

Sabha MP and former Union Minister Kapil Sibal said called for an FIR. “If the decisions are not taken by the majority of the Election Commission, then it's not a decision of the Commission. So, therefore, all decisions taken by the Commission so far without reference to the majority of the Commission must be declared null and void,” he said.

Thackeray said “Gyanesh Kumar should be immediately sacked and jailed”, and thanked Sandhu and Joshi for putting their objections on the record, which he said “exposed” Kumar before the country.

He also called for the cancellation of the “wrong decisions” taken by the poll panel, and demanded a probe into its functioning.

Kejriwal demanded Kumar's immediate arrest and prosecution for treason, and said all elections held over the past few years should be cancelled and conducted afresh.

The Cockroach Janta Party, the main trigger behind the Jantar Mantar protests in the capital in July, sought to throw its weight behind the campaign to seek accountability in the ECI. Founder Abhijeet Dipke said that the BJP's key team had cancelled their scheduled programs to head to the capital since taking on the CEC was “totally worth the hustle...”

‘Differing views’

instructions and initiatives give only one part of the picture”.

It added that “not only the three Commissioners, but every officer of the Commission is fully authorized to give his suggestions to the Commission for improving the electoral system.”

However, the statement did not say who approved the controversial change to Form 6, why was no action taken even after the Commissioners had warned that it was “illegal. Or, who authorised the lakhs of appeals filed on behalf of the ECI against restored voters in West Bengal, why the two Commissioners’ proposal for an audit of ECINet went unanswered, or why the full Commission did not meet between May and August.

Incidentally, it did not respond to the questionnaire sent by *The Indian Express* on September 21.

On the electoral-roll software, the Commission said its digital platforms “operate under strict data security protocols to prevent unauthorized tampering” and that Electoral Registration Officers and District Election Officers “function as per statutory powers for registration and deletion under law”.

Election Commissioner Sukhbir Singh Sandhu's August 14 note, however, recorded that officers were reporting they “don't have proper and com-

plete access to the ERONet portal,” and that the Director General of IT “doesn't have any legal authority to restrict” them.

The Commission's assertion that decisions were unanimous leaves unanswered how the objections recorded by the two Commissioners fit into that process.

One example is Form 6. On May 16, Election Commissioner Vivek Joshi recorded on file that the form “cannot be altered without making amendments in the Registration of Electors Rules, 1960” and advised sending the proposal to the Government. Sandhu concurred on May 19.

In July, the SIR declaration appeared on the online form anyway. Sandhu learnt of it from *The Indian Express*'s July 12 report. On August 13, he wrote that the change had been made “in spite of these very clear views expressed by two Election Commissioners,” called it “unauthorised/illegal” and directed that it “must be removed immediately”. As of Tuesday, the question remained on the form.

A second example is the work-allocation order of July 28. It was issued within hours of a Senior Deputy Election Commissioner being given temporary charge of the Administration Division and changed, in the two Commissioners' words, the allocation “especially with

regard to IT/ICT”.

Joshi wrote that it was issued “without discussing or informing the revised allocation of work with the Commission or the undersigned”. When he asked for the file, he wrote, “it was not provided”.

On July 29, both Commissioners wrote separately to the Cabinet Secretary, calling the order a “clear violation of Section 18(1) and 18(2)” of the 2023 Act and seeking action against the officer. On July 30, they jointly set aside the new allocation.

The Commission's press note does not mention the order, the two letters to the Cabinet Secretary or the subsequent reversal.

The *Express* investigation, published Tuesday, was based on internal notes and letters from October 2025 to August 2026 in which Election Commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi recorded that a statutory voter registration form was changed every against their written advice, that control of the electoral roll software had been centralised in the Commission's IT division over their objections, that lakhs of appeals had been filed in West Bengal without their knowledge of who authorised them, and that a work-allocation order had been issued without the Commission's approval, prompting both to write to the Cabinet Secretary. Their most serious notes were copied to Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar.

Gangrape

with senior officers and informed them that he had earlier been caught by local police on allegations of eve-teasing. However, since no complaint was filed, he was released,” said a source.

When contacted, DCP (South-East district) Vineet Kumar said: “The police staff have details of all local ruffians, and Asif's details were also available with them.”

The girl, and the 17-year-old boy who was with her at the time of the incident, had told police that the accused posed as police personnel and even used “police terminology” when “questioning” them.

After identifying Asif, police found that his phone was switched off. With the help of technical surveillance and local intelligence, they established his location at a DDA park and apprehended him early on Tuesday morning, said sources. Asif was shot in the leg during an alleged encounter; police said he opened fire at them.

“During questioning, Asif told police that on the day of the incident, he had gone to the park after dropping his daughter. Police are trying to find out if there are others who may have been assaulted or harassed by him,” said sources.

Following Asif's arrest, the other two accused, Hemant, a lawyer, and his brother, Mukesh,

a B.Sc. student, were also arrested.

Sources said investigators are also looking into whether Asif misused his past proximity to police personnel to evade suspicion in the area. Police, however, maintained that his earlier role as an informer did not give him any protection. “Anyone found to be involved will face action as per law,” an officer said.

According to sources, the incident occurred around 7.30 pm on Monday, when the three accused confronted the 17-year-olds at the park. They allegedly posed as police personnel and said they had recorded a video of them, said sources.

“Hemant, a practising lawyer who is preparing for the judiciary examination, threatened to book the girl's friend in a POCSO case. Hemant and Mukesh then took the boy to a nearby location while Asif allegedly raped the girl,” said sources, adding that the other two accused also allegedly raped the girl later.

“After the assault, they threatened the girl and her friend with dire consequences and told them that a police vehicle was coming to the area. They told them to leave the spot,” said sources.

After exiting the park, the girl and her friend boarded an auto-rickshaw and made a call to the police control room. Police reached them soon after. Sources said the girl was scared, but she was counselled and encouraged to report the matter.

BJP: Smear campaign

The 14 correspondences among the Election Commissioners, he said, was a sign of a “healthy democracy” where issues were discussed, notes recorded, and ultimately, a decision taken. “This is democracy in its entirety, where deliberations are taking place.”

Quoting from the Election Commission's press release issued in response to The Indian Express report, Patra said the EC had made it clear that after all official “democratic” deliberations, the SIR was “ultimately carried out with consensus”.

“In other words, all three Commissioners were in agreement on SIR. There was no difference of opinion, disagreement or divergence of views of any kind,” he said, adding, “By functioning in a democratic manner, constitutional institutions are safeguarding democracy.”

On the Opposition's allegations of “vote chori”, the BJP spokesperson said that poll figures from 2014 to the present have already been shared in past press conferences. “Now, figures from the recent Bengal polls will also be presented,” he said.

He attacked the Opposition claim that it lost in Bengal because voter names were deleted from the electoral rolls during the SIR process. “Another Indian Express article that examined 20 Assembly constituencies in West Bengal that witnessed the highest voter deletions shows that TMC won the most seats here – 13. The

Congress won one seat and the BJP only six,” he said.

On the Opposition allegation that Gyanesh Kumar's appointment as CEC had been “advantageous” to the BJP, Patra said the party had been winning elections by big margins long before Kumar took charge on February 19, 2025.

On the Congress allegation that attempts were being made to protect Gyanesh Kumar, Patra said, “We are not trying to save anybody. We are trying to save democracy. We are trying to demolish the smear campaign against constitutional bodies.” He also gave instances of the BJP forming several governments at the state level between 2014 and Kumar's appointment as CEC, and took on the Congress over alleged irregularities in relation to the Election Commission during its tenure.

“Irregularities and scams originated from the Congress itself... KVK Sundaram served as Election Commissioner from 1958 to 1967. He was made Chairman of the Law Commission and was awarded the Padma Vibhushan. Nagendra Singh served as Election Commissioner from 1972 to 1973 and was awarded the Padma Vibhushan,” Patra said.

“R K Trivedi served as Election Commissioner from 1982 to 1985. He was awarded the Padma Bhushan and was also appointed Governor... T N Seshan served as Election Commissioner and CEC from 1990 to 1996... he contested an election

on behalf of the Congress... Seshan had used terms such as ‘donkeys’ and ‘rascals’ to describe fellow commissioners appointed alongside him,” he said.

Patra also cited the examples of M S Gill who served as Election Commissioner and CEC from 1996 to 2001 and later became a Congress Rajya Sabha member and a Minister; J M Lyngdoh who served as CEC from 2001 to 2004; and Navin Chawla. “What position did Sonia Gandhi hold when she appointed Navin Chawla as an Election Commissioner? This was in 2005. In 2009, the then CEC N Gopalaswami wrote a letter to the then President Pratibha Patil stating that Navin Chawla should be removed from the post,” he said, adding that Chawla was, however, elevated as CEC.

“Overall, it must be decided whether democracy is reflected when three officials exchange correspondence, share their respective views and concerns, and ultimately arrive at a conclusion through consensus, or whether democracy consists of writing letters in the same language and then arriving at the same conclusion. There could be no better time for democracy than the present,” Patra said.

He pointed out that the Supreme Court, on May 27, 2026, directly upheld the legal validity of the SIR. “But if there is no trust in the Supreme Court, no trust in the Election Commission, and no trust in EVMs, then one must place trust in the people. It is the people who cast their votes, and it is the people who decide whether a party wins or loses,” he said.

NSA

heard on merits, the operation of the impugned judgment, particularly para Nos. 27 to 33 shall remain stayed.” These paragraphs relate to the strictures against Roopam and the direction for the Rs 5-lakh compensation payment from her salary.

Earlier in the day, Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, appearing for Roopam, told the bench that the High Court passed strictures without hearing Roopam.

“Without notice to the DM, Noida, some strictures are passed and a cost of Rs 5 lakh is imposed,” he said. “Even on

merits, the role of DM is completely different. This, in my respectful submission, was not called for.”

“It is one thing to quash the order of detention, quite another to castigate the officer who has passed the order,” Mehta said, adding that “there are several layers before the DM forms an opinion. There are several administrative, hierarchical layers.”

Roughly 10 minutes into the submissions in the courtroom, the video was muted.

Appearing for the Uttar Pradesh government, Senior Advocate Mukul Rohatgi said the High Court order was “completely uncalled for”.

On the detention of Chaudhary under NSA, he said, “The

HC should have independently assessed this order which is of May 12. It was to maintain public order, not law and order.”

Senior Advocate Colin Gonsalves, who appeared for Chaudhary, said one of the conditions for her detention was that she instigated the mob, but that was not true as she was in police custody even before the violence erupted.

He said the High Court had asked the state multiple times to produce Chaudhary's alleged inflammatory speech but it did not. “Not one microgram of evidence, but 99 per cent flamboyant narrative was given,” he said. The bench said the High Court only had to see if the procedure was followed and not go into the merits.

Jaishankar

sidelines of the United Nations General Assembly (UNGA) session in New York. Rubio will be travelling to India next month.

“Good to meet @SecRubio of the US #UNHighLevelWeek. Reiterated India's interests and concerns with regard to SRIA (Lindsey O Graham Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act). Also discussed the Gulf and Ukraine situations,” Jaishankar said in a post on X after the meeting. He is leading the Indian delegation for the 81st session of the UNGA.

Rubio, in his post, said: “Together, we are building on the US-India strategic partnership

and coordinating on key regional priorities and upcoming multilateral efforts.”

Trump signed into law the SRIA last week, giving himself the authority to impose tariffs of up to 100% on countries that continue to buy Russian oil and gas. India and China are among the major purchasers of Russian crude. India has said that it “remains firmly committed to ensuring energy security for its 1.4 billion people” and warned of “potential implications” for “the bilateral relationship” with the US.

The US move comes at a time when Delhi and Washington are trying to firm up a bilateral trade deal after months of negotiations.

(PTI adds: Speaking about SRIA, US State Department Spokesperson Thomas Pigott said that “in terms of sanctions on Russia, that's still going through the legislative process” and added that he would not comment on legislation until it's been finalised. He said that when it comes to the war in Ukraine, the US wants durable peace between the parties.

“We've also been clear that we think that countries that are supporting that effort need to think about that and say, ‘are we actually making the situation worse?’” Pigott said. Talking about India-US ties, Pigott said, “It's obviously a very important relationship, that takes a huge amount of importance.”)

Satheesan's chopper rides kick up row, faces flak from Opposition

Thiruvananthapuram: Four months into office, Kerala CM V D Satheesan appears to be confronting uncomfortable Opposition questions on propriety, transparency and conflict of interest – mostly over sponsored chopper rides for his official and personal trips. This week, Satheesan's decision to take a chartered aircraft to Nilambur in North Kerala's Malappuram district to assess the flash floods has come under intense Opposition scrutiny.

On Monday, Satheesan took a private aircraft to Nilambur, a region which falls within the

Wayanad LS seat represented by Priyanka Gandhi. Since then, Opposition parties CPI (M) and BJP have demanded that Satheesan disclose the names of the sponsors. “I'm in charge of disaster management,” he said. “I had gone to Malappuram by a helicopter arranged by a private person. He is a Keralite, and what's wrong with the arrangement? Why should I reveal their name and drag them into controversy? They are not going to seek any favours from the government, and we are not going to give them any favours.”

Goa

The earlier decisions to strike them off “have to be reversed,” the email said. But the EROs could not reverse those decisions through the software (ECINet). Reason: the permission to do so was controlled from Delhi.

The next day, the Commission's own Deputy Election Commissioner wrote to the Director General of IT, Seema Khanna, “IT system cannot block necessary action as per the directions of SC. Please facilitate the desired action to publish... as per the decision taken by EROs/AEROs and conveyed to you in these emails.”

On February 21, the final roll was published. *The Indian Express* checked all 97 names against it. Until September 20, all 97 are still missing.

When asked why several voters remained missing from the final SIR roll despite being found eligible, Goa Chief Electoral Officer Sanjay Goel told *The Indian Express*, “We apprised the ECI about the cases to be included wherein voters were flagged for logical discrepancies.” He added, “The call (to not include) was theirs. But there has to be some mechanism (in ECINet) to re-include voters at the ERO level.”

Proof of the pudding

The 97 are a case study in what the two Election Commissioners have spent the past year warning about.

By law, the electoral roll of each Assembly constituency is

prepared by its ERO, usually the sub-divisional magistrate, who hears every claim and objection and decides every name. Since January, every electoral roll in the country has sat on ECINet, the platform the Commission launched to bring its systems together, and its roll-management module, ERONet. What an ERO can do on it is decided by permissions set in the Commission's IT division in Delhi.

An investigation by *The Indian Express* into the working of the Commission over the past year has found that Election Commissioners Sandhu and Joshi recorded, in notes from November to August, that the centralised control of the software was taking the roll out of the EROs' hands, where the law puts it. Joshi wrote in May of “the gradual centralisation” of the electoral roll database.

Sandhu wrote in August that EROs, DEOs and CEOs “don't have proper and complete access to the ERONet portal”, and that “DG(IT) doesn't have any legal authority to restrict proper and complete access and freedom to operate, as given by law, to the statutory authorities”.

When ERO's decision doesn't count

The Commission's answer to every allegation of a rigged roll has been that no one person can touch it: thousands of EROs prepare it, constituency by constituency. Goa shows what happens when that stops being true.

In Goa, the ERO heard the voter, saw the document and decided in their favour, and it made

no difference, because the system that records the roll answers to a division in Delhi, and the division did not act even when the Commission's own Deputy Election Commissioner told it to.

The Indian Express sent a questionnaire to Seema Khanna, who heads the division as EC's DG IT, asking why the rollback facility was not enabled for Goa before the final roll. There was no response.

What the SC ordered, and what Goa did

A “logical discrepancy” is not a finding that someone is not a voter. It is a mismatch the Commission's software throws up when it tries to link an elector to a parent or grandparent on the roll from the last SIR, such as a parent's name that doesn't match, an age gap between parent and child of under 15 or over 50 years, an age that doesn't progress correctly between the old roll and the new, or a case where the elector submitted no document, or only Aadhaar.

On January 29, in the SIR batch of petitions, a Supreme Court bench of Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and Justice Joydalya Bagchi ordered that the names of those flagged for logical discrepancies be displayed at gram panchayat bhavans, public places, taluka and sub-division offices and urban ward offices, with “the brief reason of discrepancy” – and that those affected be allowed ten days to submit documents or objections and be heard.

The order was about Tamil Nadu, but the court said it expected the Commission to “en-

sure compliance with these procedural directions in all the States wherever the SIR process is ongoing”. On January 31, the Commission issued a letter to implement it. Goa did. The lists went up. According to the CEO's emails, 649 electors came forward with documents or objections. EROs and Assistant EROs examined them. In 97 cases they concluded that the elector had, in the CEO's words, “become eligible to be included in the final Electoral Roll”, and that the earlier decision “has to be reversed”.

Seven days, eight pleas, no answer

The problem was that the decision to flag them had already been entered on ECINet, and the system had no rollback option that would let the EROs reverse it. Requests for the same had been coming from the field since January 22.

On February 11, Goa Electronics Limited, the state agency that supports the CEO's office on the software, wrote to the CEO and to Tata Consultancy Services (TCS), the Commission's vendor, that “the required rollback/reversion functionality, including the document re-upload option, has still not been provided in the system”, despite “multiple emails” from DEOs, EROs and AEROs and the matter having been “communicated to the concerned officials of ECI and TCS”. It maintained a spreadsheet of every request.

The CEO forwarded it to Delhi the same day, to the Senior Deputy Election Commissioner in charge of Goa, Gyanesh Bharti, with Khanna copied.

Every email that followed went the same way. No reply is on record, and none was acted on.

FEBRUARY 13: “response to any of the emails and letters sent from officer of the Chief Electoral Officer, Goa... is still awaited.” Of the electors who had come forward after the (logical discrepancy) lists went up, “there are 97 cases, in which the roll back option is required, as the decision taken earlier has to be reversed in view of documents/objections received from the concerned electors”.

FEBRUARY 14 (2 emails, at 12.52pm and 6.11pm): “It is once again requested to kindly make available the provision for Roll back/revert back along with the document re-upload facility at the earliest.”

FEBRUARY 14 (by letter): Goel wrote formally to Senior DEC Gyanesh Bharti (in charge of Goa) copying Khanna: “no response has been received” to the emails of the previous two days.

FEBRUARY 15: “The Roll back option is urgently required... The matter is most urgent and requires immediate necessary action to be taken by the concerned ERO/AERO officers to facilitate timely compliance of the Hon'ble Supreme Court's Order...”

FEBRUARY 16: “response to any of the emails and letters sent from officer of the Chief Electoral Officer, Goa, with respect to the above cited subject is still awaited.”

FEBRUARY 17: The list of 97 logical discrepancy cases, “in which the decisions taken by the ERO/AERO earlier... have to be

reversed as the concerned electors have become eligible to be included in the final Electoral Roll... it is requested that necessary action may be taken to include these electors in the Final Electoral Roll of SIR 2026.”

FEBRUARY 18: Sanjay Kumar, the Deputy Election Commissioner who holds the electoral roll charge in Delhi, to Khanna: “EROs/AEROs have powers u/s 21/21A to take corrective action. In any case, IT system cannot block necessary action as per the directions of SC. Please facilitate the desired action to publish ER as per the decision taken by EROs/AEROs and conveyed to you in these emails.”

FEBRUARY 21: The final roll was published. The 97 were not on it.

Who are the 97, why it's a big deal for them

Sixty-five of the 97 are from Taleigao, the seat that was held by the BJP's Jennifer Monserate, who passed away in July this year. The rest are from St Cruz, Cumbarjua, Priol, Margao, Benaulim and Velim assembly seats. For a Goan, being off the roll costs more than a vote. Several state schemes use the electoral roll to establish eligibility. The Goa Mediclaim Scheme, which funds super-specialty treatment not available in government hospitals (dialysis, angioplasty, open-heart surgery, transplants, chemotherapy, cochlear implants) is open only to voters of the state. When the names did not go in, the electoral officers on the ground told these voters to apply afresh on Form 6, the form for new voters.



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17-YEAR-OLD SEXUALLY ASSAULTED AT SOUTH DELHI'S ASTHA KUNJ PARK

Anger on streets after teen's gangrape



Student holds a placard on Wednesday. TASHI TOBGYAL

'Nothing changed since Dec 16, 2012': DU students protest over women's safety

Sophiya Mathew
New Delhi, September 23

RENEWED ALARM over concerns related to women's safety in the Capital — after a 17-year-old girl was allegedly gangraped in a South Delhi park earlier this week — brought around 200 students from colleges of Delhi University (DU) out on streets on Wednesday. For some, the incident has been a reminder of December 16, 2012 gangrape. Even after more than a decade, the situation remains the same, they said.

The protest started near the Lady Shri Ram college for Women, which is in proximity to the site of the incident, and demonstrators also included students from other colleges, including Miranda House and Gargi College, as well as those from Dr BR Ambedkar University and some DU faculty members.

"Down with the patriarchy": this was among the slogans that rented the air as the march moved towards a police 'Pink booth'. "This is not an LSR issue... We are our own voice. It's not the first time that it is happening and men have the audacity to blame women for stepping out at night and only know how to police women," said one of the organisers, her face covered with a yellow scarf.

Ananya, a first-year student at LSR, said she often feels unsafe when she leaves college late after theatre practice. "Men near this booth stand and make obscene gestures when they see women," she alleged. "The issues are not new. Even in our time women's safety was a key concern. Now the situation has worsened," she said.

She also recalled incidents around Holi, saying men would throw water balloons into women's colleges or hostels. In 2018, students from colleges, including LSR and Jesus and Mary College, protested after balloons allegedly containing semen and urine were thrown at women

ahead of Holi.

Wednesday's march moved along the Ring Road, past neighbouring institutions including the Rajkumari Amrit Kaur College of Nursing (RAKCON). First-year B.Sc Nursing students residing in the RAKCON hostel in Lajpat Nagarsaid they had been instructed by teachers to move in groups when stepping outside the campus. "It's our first year. The teachers have clearly warned us that whenever we need to step out, we must move in groups even for small errands," said Ngawang Gatso, a first-year B.Sc Nursing student from Utarakhand.

Tenzing Pamo, also a first-year student, said, "Stepping out is unavoidable. We definitely feel safer when we step outside together."

Their batchmate Yangzom, a first-year B.Sc Nursing student from Tibet, said, "It has barely been a day since we arrived, and the very first instruction we received was about stepping out cautiously. With everything happening in the area, our seniors and faculty emphasised that no one should walk around alone outside the gates." Walking with the protesters was Yakshna Sharma, a 2025 graduate of DU's Campus Law Centre and now an advocate practising at the Delhi High Court.

"If the most upscale localities, near Kalkaji and LSR, cannot keep women safe, where in this city are we supposed to feel secure?"

For Sharma, this incident had brought wider concerns over women's safety into focus. "It is horrifyingly reminiscent of the December 16 gangrape incident. This means nothing has changed since. It's that same mindset that men can 'discipline' women on the streets. She was also accompanied by a male friend. If Delhi cannot ensure women are safe in the most upscale, most prestigious areas then women are not safe anywhere," she said.



Hundreds of students of Delhi University were out on streets on Wednesday, demanding better security for women. TASHI TOBGYAL

'Few PCR vans, dark roads a concern': LSR students

Sophiya Mathew
New Delhi, September 23

STUDENTS OF Delhi University's Lady Shri Ram College for Women have raised concerns about safety around the campus, including the "absence of PCR vans, a non-functional Pink Booth, lack of streetlights and vehicles occupying footpaths".

This came after a 17-year-old was allegedly gangraped and hours after a police encounter near the college's back gate.

An online general body meeting was organised by the Students' Union on Tuesday night to discuss these concerns, as many students live in the vicinity and regularly use the surrounding roads and lanes. The college has an intake of around 4,000 students.

Police patrol vans

The availability of police assistance around the college was among the key concerns.

Students raised the alleged "unavailability of PCR vans, particularly around the college and during times when students may require police assistance" and a "non-functional Pink Booth".

They also called for closer co-ordination between different agencies involved in student safety. The minutes recorded the need for "greater coordination between police officials, college administration, security



Police stepped up vigil at the site of the incident. PRAVEEN KHANNA

guards and the Students' Union so that student concerns can be directly communicated and followed up".

Students also discussed approaching the police over why the college administration and security guards were not informed about the encounter in the early hours of Tuesday.

'Delayed communication'

Students also claimed there was "lack of timely communication regarding the incident". They questioned why they were not informed about the police encounter when it had occurred several hours before the start of the college day, and why many of them learnt about it only after reaching campus.

The minutes said, "Given the seriousness of the incident

and its implications for student safety, students felt that the administration should have proactively issued an official statement and communicated the situation to students at the earliest." They called for a clear, timely and reliable communication mechanism so that "students receive verified information and appropriate safety advisories without unnecessary delay".

Vulnerable road stretches

Students flagged the back road as a particular safety concern, especially for those who leave campus late.

"Streetlights on the back road are an important concern, as the road is regularly used by students for commuting, particularly by members of per-

forming societies who may leave campus late in the evening," the minutes state.

The installation and improvement of streetlights were also discussed.

Students also raised concerns about cabs and autos "occupying footpaths", saying this made them uncomfortable while walking. They emphasised the importance of maintaining "accessible and safe pedestrian pathways".

They also raised concerns about a vulnerable stretch towards Kailash Colony, suggesting that it be monitored regularly so they "do not feel unsafe or targeted".

Security at college gates

According to the minutes, students expressed the need for heightening gate-level security.

They called for "sensitisation workshops for security guards" and an "adequate number of guards at both college gates".

The minutes also stated that guards should be "active, vigilant and attentive to their surroundings, particularly during late hours".

Students also sought "strict and consistent checking of individuals entering the college premises". Anusha Garg, president of the Students' Union, said around 400 students attended the meeting. "Safety cannot be something we start

talking about only after something goes wrong," she said.

"Students should know what to look for before choosing a place, who to reach out to when something doesn't feel right, and most importantly, feel that their concerns will actually be heard. For us now, the focus is on taking what students have shared and turning it into something practical and long-term," Garg added.

The Students' Union will hold a meeting with the principal, college administration and authorities to share the concerns.

Separately, specific concerns of hostel students would also be taken up, the Students' Union members said.

Police patrolling sought

The college administration said it was taking steps to strengthen security. Principal Kanika K Ahuja told *The Indian Express*, "Security personnel are deployed at all gates, and CCTV surveillance across the campus is being continuously monitored and strengthened."

The Principal said the college was also in consultation with the nearby police station and had requested increased patrolling in the lanes adjoining the college, particularly around the back gate and nearby parks.

• POLICE ACTIONS & MEETINGS

379 PEOPLE were apprehended under Section 65 of the Delhi Police Act as police intensified area-domination and search operations across the Central Range, with teams checking parks, subways, foot-over bridges, flyovers and other public spaces identified as 'vulnerable' spots, as part of an effort to prevent unlawful activities. Additional action was taken under the Delhi Excise Act, Gambling Act, BNSS, POCSO Act.

POLICE COMMISSIONER Anurag Kumar visited the crime scene on Tuesday to assess the park's condition. He has asked officials to maintain vigilance and continue patrolling parks and isolated stretches.

THE DDA AND MCD will jointly conduct a safety audit of all parks in their jurisdiction and submit a report within a week. The decision was taken at a meeting chaired by LG Taranjit Singh Sandhu with the MCD Commissioner, Commissioner of Police and DDA Vice Chairman. A DDA spokesperson said that the audit will focus on lighting, security, patrolling and cleanliness.

CONSPIRACY SECTIONS ADDED IN FIR

3 accused may have planned the crime, porn clips found on phone of one of them: Police

Pragnesh
New Delhi, September 23

THE THREE men accused of gang-raping a 17-year-old girl at a DDA park in South Delhi may have planned the crime before they targeted her on Monday evening while allegedly posing as police personnel when she was out on her birthday with a friend, suspect the investigators.

Delhi Police on Wednesday added sections of conspiracy in the FIR, after recovering a gun, a knife and condoms from Asif, one of the accused in the case, said officers.

A senior officer said that they are investigating if Asif was roaming in the area allegedly with condoms and a knife, because he and his two accomplices, Mukesh and Hemant, intended to target women in



The park where the incident happened. PRAVEEN KHANNA

side the Astha Kunj Park.

"There have been several allegations against Asif from multiple people around the area that he used to harass people repeatedly. We are verifying if he used to carry a weapon and used a similar modus operandi against other women," said a police officer.

Officers also said that multiple porn videos were found on Asif's phone.

The investigation has also revealed that Mukesh and Hemant had allegedly deleted their search history.

The three men, who were arrested on Tuesday, allegedly used a combination of police

language, including 'Janab', and threats to convince the teenager and her friend, who accompanied her, that they were dealing with police officers, before sexually assaulting her.

Another police officer said that the accused brothers, Mukesh and Hemant, initially went to an eatery after the incident, before going back to their home in Srinivaspuri.

They then allegedly washed their clothes in bid to get rid of evidence.

Officers also said that the friend of the girl was held by one of the accused inside the park, while the victim was taken to another corner at some distance.

Pragnesh, Alok Singh
New Delhi, September 23

HEMANT SINGH, one of the three men accused of raping a 17-year-old girl at a park in South Delhi, was a law graduate and had been preparing to appear for the judicial services entrance exam for almost a decade, according to police. His brother, Mukesh, a co-accused, is a BSc student. The third accused, Asif, was recently fired from a gym after women complained about his inappropriate behaviour, according to police. All three men, who are aged between 25 and 30 years, were arrested on Tuesday hours after they allegedly committed the crime.

Asif, who had switched to selling vegetables after being fired from the gym, allegedly

Asif had started selling vegetables after he was fired from a gym following complaints from women over misbehaviour, investigators have found

had been carrying a gun for the past few months, as he often engaged in petty crimes inside the park, according to officers. Investigators suspect he was involved in multiple snatchings in the park earlier. However, since no formal complaints had been filed against him, police did not take action. He also allegedly harassed women and

girls at the park earlier. Some security guards at the park also told police that Asif behaved like a local strongman, often threatening vulnerable people, including girls from economically weaker backgrounds.

Officers said the accused lived in proximity to the park where they allegedly raped the girl when she was out with a friend on her birthday after they intimidated them by allegedly posing as police personnel.

Hemant and Mukesh live with their family in Srinivaspuri, while Asif lives with his wife and parents in Okhla Mandi, said police.

During questioning, Hemant told police that he completed his graduation, BA LLB, from Rohtak in Haryana in 2014 and had been preparing for judiciary examinations. His

younger brother is enrolled in a college in Palwal. Their father practises law in the courts of Palwal and Faridabad.

However, after obtaining his law degree, Hemant never took up legal practice. For the past two to three years, the two brothers often visited the park in the evening to play. They met Asif a few months ago at the park. Officers said Asif has been accused of harassing women in the neighbourhood too.

Even as neighbours said that Mukesh and Hemant were mostly reticent, the duo recently had an alleged argument over paying the water bill of their building where they live on the second floor.

Before his arrest, Asif sold onions at the Okhla mandi. He had previously worked at a hotel.

DEBRIS DISPOSAL NORMS

No proof, no clearance: Building certificates are now linked to waste management in Gurugram

Abhimanyu Hazarika
Gurugram, September 23

NO PROOF for the disposal of construction and demolition (C&D) waste? No building occupancy certificate. This is how the Municipal Corporation of Gurugram (MCG) plans to tighten the norms around the handling of debris in the Millennium City in a bid to combat dust pollution and ensure better waste management under a fresh directive.

Binding timelines, compulsory recycled material quotas, and digital tracking are among the fresh measures introduced by the civic body after two orders were issued earlier this week by MCG Commissioner Pradeep Dahiya, a spokesperson said. The orders were made public on Tuesday.

Significantly, the order eliminates exemptions for pub-

lic works, classifying all Central, state, and municipal projects within MCG limits as producer or builder equivalent, regardless of cost or scale.

“Effective immediately, the orders enforce the Environment (C&D Waste) Rules, 2025, Haryana’s 2019 C&D Policy, and Commission for Air Quality Management (CAQM) directives,” an official said.

Sanction conditional

The new directive links building certifications directly to debris disposal. Here is a breakdown:

- Applicants undertaking demolition on plots of 200 square metres or above must declare estimated rubble volumes while seeking building plan sanction prior to construction, an MCG spokesperson said.
- According to the order, applicants must deposit debris at

MCG’s Basai plant or designated points to secure an online receipt before construction.

■ The order bars authorities from issuing an Occupancy Certificate (OC) or Completion Certificate (CC) until this receipt is verified online and confirmed via site inspection. Submitting false records invites revocation of clearances, the spokesperson warned.

■ For projects with a built-up area of 20,000 square metres or more, developers — classified as “producers” — must submit an Integrated Waste Management Plan to the MCG for approval within 30 days, the order states.

The spokesperson said these producers cannot use doorstep collection and must haul waste directly to recycling plants in their own vehicles.

- For government projects,

a civic spokesperson noted, the departments must specify projected waste volumes in tenders and mandate disposal at Basai or through mobile units.

■ Future MCG tenders will include a non-scheduled processing fee of Rs 360 per metric tonne and a Rs 226-per-cubic-metre cartage rate for transport within 10 km, the order directs, urging other departments to adopt identical terms.

■ Builders must annually scale recycled material used for buildings — from 5% in 2026 to 25% by 2030; and for roads, reaching 15% from 2030 onward. To ensure structural safety, recycled parts are restricted to non-structural items like sidewalk tiles, curbs, and drain covers. Recycling plants must submit monthly lab-tested quality certifications.

E.

Strict timelines

To prevent street blockages, the order sets strict deadlines. Portal logs will be monitored by a C&D Monitoring Cell headed by an Additional Commissioner, the MCG spokesperson underlined. According to the order, violations will draw environmental compensation via the State Pollution Board, with serious offences referred to CAQM for prosecution under Section 14 of the CAQM Act.

■ ‘Right of Way restoration’ waste — leftover debris, trimmings, surplus earth, broken pavement, or discarded materials generated when repairing — must be cleared within 48 hours, road repair rubble within 72 hours, and pipeline excavations within 72 hours.

■ Rubble spilled onto public spaces must be removed within 24 hours, the spokesperson said.

GROUND report

At East Delhi SIR camp, some flagged for being twins, others have no clue about documents

Devansh Mittal
New Delhi, September 23

MEERA MITTAL (73) had prepared herself mentally for the three-km journey from her home in Mayur Vihar to the office of the Electoral Registration Officer (ERO) for the verification hearing under the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls in Delhi.

Mittal suffers from diabetes and has undergone treatment for her tailbone, and finds e-rickshaw rides on the city’s bumpy roads excruciatingly painful.

But when she reached the Voter Registration Centre in East Delhi’s Trilokpuri, she was faced with a challenge she had not anticipated: stairs with no handrails.

“There is no ramp and it seems impossible for me to climb these stairs. I don’t know how I will go up when my turn comes,” Mittal told *The Indian Express* on Wednesday.

Mittal, a veteran social worker, is among lakhs of Delhiites who have been queuing up at government offices across the national capital after they got notices to prove their eligibility to remain on the electoral rolls.

Delhi had 1.45 crore electors before the SIR began — of them, 97.5 lakh made their way to the draft roll published on August 31.

Around 47.5 lakh electors were marked “uncollectible” — because Booth Level Officers (BLOs) found them to be absent, moved, dead, have duplicate entries, or due to other reasons — and struck off the rolls.

One-third, or around 33.1 lakh electors, on the draft roll have since received notices to prove their eligibility to stay on the electoral roll. While 13.79 lakh electors got notices because they could not link themselves to the electoral roll of the last intensive revision, 19.33 lakh were picked out for “logical discrepancies” in their enumeration forms.

The Voter Registration Centre in Trilokpuri is the hub where hearings are being held. The final electoral roll will be



The camp at Trilokpuri on Wednesday. DEVANSH MITTAL

published on November 4. While BLOs have been told to facilitate hearings for senior citizens, Mittal said no one told her the process could have been completed at her home.

Same for 65-year-old Babu Lal, who is blind. “No one told us these documents could be submitted online, or that the BLO could have taken these at our home,” 36-year-old Manoj Bairwa, Babu Lal’s son, said.

At the centre, three officials sat in separate rooms, and civil defence volunteers called out the names of electors. Most people were able to attend their hearing in their designated two-and-a-half-hour slot.

Trilokpuri Assembly seat had 1.89 lakh electors before the SIR, out of which 1.26 lakh or nearly 67% found their way to the draft electoral roll. Around one-third of those on the draft rolls got notices.

Sixty-year old Shubha Mitra said she had to shut her flower shop to attend the hearing. “I had heard there might be some kind of action or investigation if our names were deleted from the list. So I could not risk not coming,” Mitra said. She said she had got a notice because the age difference between her and her mother had been flagged as being less than 15 years.

Mitra’s mother Amita Mitra said: “They are saying that the LIC policy that we got (as documentary proof) will not work, we will have to get my mother’s original documents at a camp which

will be organised on Sunday.”

Several electors claimed they were not informed what documents to bring along. So 36-year-old Devi Barman had brought all the documents that she could find: Aadhaar, PAN, bank passbook, marksheet, birth certificate. “I can’t keep coming again and again. So I brought along everything,” Barman said.

Some said they had been flagged for reasons beyond their control. Among them were the daughters of 57-year-old Lily Ojha, who got notices because they are twins, and hence the age gap between them is less than nine months. This was supposed to be a “logical discrepancy”, and Ojha said she had “shouted at” the officials.

In minor anomalies such as this, a letter from the BLO can be uploaded to resolve the issue. Anoop Kumar Sharma (44) said he was flagged because his parents have six children. “But only two out of the six have filled the SIR form. The others don’t care. So I have come to meet these people who are claiming to be my brothers and sisters and filling SIR forms,” Sharma said.

As the people waited for their turn, a cow wandered inside the compound and sat down lazily. After some time, a dog walked into the centre. Partly in amusement and partly in frustration, some people wondered whether the animals too had been issued notices.

Hindu College vs staff: 2 profs face showcase notices for ‘misconduct’

Sophiya Mathew
New Delhi, September 23

TWO ASSOCIATE professors of Delhi University’s Hindu College have been issued showcase notices by the governing body, accusing them of gross misconduct, indiscipline and insubordination. This comes amid a standoff between the college administration and its staff association that has continued for more than a week.

Dr Ratan Lal and Dr P K Vijayan got the notices dated September 8 on Wednesday, according to teachers, and they have been asked to submit their explanations within seven working days or face disciplinary action.

The notices concern statements and communications issued by the professors during a dispute which began over admissions under the Sports and Extra-Curricular Activities (ECA) quotas, but has since widened to include broader concerns raised by the Hindu College Staff Association (HCSA) over the functioning of the college administration.

‘Criticised principal, dishonoured college’

Lal, an Associate Professor in the Department of History and president of the HCSA, was issued the notice over an August 18 statement and subsequent communications in which he criticised Principal Anju Srivastava and expressed “no confidence” in her.

The governing body cited his allegations that the principal had “tricked, misled and pressured” the college’s statutory bodies and that admissions had been completed through “gross violations of procedures, rule and possible corrupt practices”.

In the notice, the body said, “You have issued and circulated statements to external agencies, including the media, and persisted in making these allegations despite being made fully aware of the University’s explanation that the admissions were made on the basis of the lists issued by the University and errors, if any, were due to some glitch in the algorithm at the level of the University...”

It further accused Lal of “dishonouring the college by seeking to tarnish its institutional standing and image”. It also accused him of violating DU’s code of conduct. “You have continued to act in a manner highly prejudicial for the maintenance of internal discipline and order in the College. Your Act is unbecoming of a Teacher of the College,” it said.

Lal questioned whether the college governing body’s chairperson has the authority to issue the notice.

‘Offensive characterisations’

The notice to Vijayan, an Associate Professor in the Department of English, was over an email he sent to faculty members on August 21.

The governing body alleged that the email violated longstanding DU and UGC rules and codes, including provisions requiring teachers to maintain a “professional, dignified, and collegial demeanour” towards their peers, speak respectfully to other teachers and refrain from making unsubstantiated allegations against colleagues. It alleged that Vijayan had used “derogatory” and “offensive” characterisations of fellow faculty members and sought to “tarnish the institutional standing and image” of the college.

Lawyers call off strike, protest march against traffic challan amendments

Express News Service
New Delhi, September 23

LAWYERS IN the Capital have called off a strike and a protest march to the Lieutenant Governor’s residence, scheduled for Thursday, after the Delhi government agreed to put the implementation of a new traffic challan notification on hold.

The lawyers had been protesting against amendments to the challan system, particularly a rule requiring a person to deposit 50% of a challan amount before approaching a court if their challenge is rejected.

Transport Minister Pankaj Kumar Singh on Wednesday said the government had received a representation from advocates over issues related to implementation of the new system. “The Delhi government has taken seriously the concerns raised by advocates over implementation of the new challan system in Delhi,” he said.

Singh said the representation was being sent to the Transport department for examination, and would also be brought to the notice of the Lieutenant Governor and the Chief Minister. Till then, he said, the department was being directed to put the implementation of the notification, dated September 14, on hold.

According to a circular issued by the Coordination Committee of All District Courts Bar Associations of Delhi, a delegation of the committee was called for a discussion with the Chief Minister, the Law Minister and the Transport Minister. It said a “detailed discussion on the grievances and concerns of the legal fraternity” regarding the new mechanism for disposal of traffic challans was held.

उत्तर प्रदेश सरकार
सिंचाई एवं जल संसाधन विभाग

कार्यालय अधीक्षण अभियन्ता
तृतीय मण्डल, सिंचाई कार्य, आगरा।
139, मॉल रोड, प्रतापपुरा, आगरा-282001
दूरभाष संख्या-0562-2466928
NIC Email- seiwc3idupag-up@nic.in

Office of The Superintending Engineer 3rd
Circle, Irrigation Works, Agra 139, Mall
Road, Pratappura, Agra Department
Website: www.idup.gov.in
G-Mail - se3circleagra@gmail.com

अल्पकालीन ई-निविदा सूचना संख्या-12/एस०ई०/2026-2027

महामहिम राज्यपाल, उत्तर प्रदेश की ओर से निम्नलिखित कार्यों हेतु ऑनलाइन निविदायें (<https://etender.up.nic.in>) सिंचाई एवं जल संसाधन विभाग, उत्तर प्रदेश में वगीकृत श्रेणी में पंजीकृत टेकेदारों से दिनांक 01.10.2026 अपरान्ह 01:00 बजे तक आमंत्रित की जाती है। निविदा की प्री-क्वालिफिकेशन / टेक्निकल बिड अधोहस्ताक्षरी के कार्यालय कक्ष में गठित समिति के सदस्यों द्वारा दिनांक 01.10.2026 को अपरान्ह 03:00 बजे खोली जायेगी। प्री-क्वालिफिकेशन / टेक्निकल बिड में क्वालिफाइड पाये गये टेकेदारों की ही फाइनेंसियल बिड खोली जायेगी। कार्यालय बन्द होने अथवा अवकाश होने की दशा में यह निविदायें अगले कार्य दिवस में उसी समय खोली जायेगी। निविदा दिनांक 24.09.2026 को पूर्वाह्न 11:00 बजे से दिनांक 01.10.2026 को अपरान्ह 01:00 बजे तक डाउनलोड/अपलोड की जा सकती है। कार्यों का विवरण निम्नवत है:-

(धनराशि लाख ₹० में)

क्र० सं०	कार्य का नाम	कार्य की अनुमानित लागत	धरोहर धनराशि कार्य पूर्ण करने की अवधि	कार्य पूर्ण करने की अवधि	निविदा प्रपत्र का मूल्य + GST (₹० में)	पंजीकरण श्रेणी	खण्ड का नाम
1	जनपद मथुरा में अपर खण्ड, आगरा नहर, मथुरा के कार्यक्षेत्र के अन्तर्गत राजवाह कोसी पर स्थित क्षतिग्रस्त पक्के कार्यों के पुर्ननिर्माण एवं अन्य कार्यों के निर्माण का कार्य	1537.00	30.74	12 माह	5000.00+900=5900.00	"एए"	अपर खण्ड, आगरा नहर, मथुरा
2	जनपद मथुरा में अपर खण्ड, आगरा नहर, मथुरा के कार्यक्षेत्र के अन्तर्गत राजवाह नन्दगढ़ के कि०मी० 0.000 से कि०मी० 46.800 तक पुर्नस्थापना एवं नहरी भूमि के सीमांकन का कार्य	1586.49	31.72	12 माह	5000.00+900=5900.00	"एए"	अपर खण्ड, आगरा नहर, मथुरा

विस्तृत निविदा सूचना का विवरण एवं नियम व शर्तें उत्तर प्रदेश सरकार की वेबसाइट (<http://www.upgovt.up.nic/infotech>) तथा सिंचाई विभाग की वेबसाइट (<http://www.idup.gov.in>) पर उपलब्ध है।

(धर्मेन्द्र सिंह फौगट)
अधीक्षण अभियन्ता,
तृतीय मण्डल, सिंचाई कार्य, आगरा

UPID-256741 Date 22/09/2026
www.upidadv.gov.in

Public Health Engineering Department
Public Health Engineering Division, Darbhanga.
TENDER NIT No –01 (R1)/2026-27/O&M-PHED
National Competitive Bidding
(Through e-procurement mode on www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in)

1	Designation and Address of Advertiser	Executive Engineer, P. H. Division, Darbhanga.
2	Date of issue of Tender Notice	22.09.2026
3	Period of sale (downloading) of tender Bid Document	01.10.2026 to 15.10.2026 up to 15:00 Hrs. through www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in
4	Date, time & place of pre-bid meeting	28.09.2026 at 12:00 hrs in the Office of Executive Engineer of concerned P. H. Division
5	Last date and time of receipt (uploading) of tender	15.10.2026 up to 17:00Hrs on www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in
6	Date and time of opening of technical bid	15.10.2026 at 17:30Hrs on www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in
7	Date and time of opening of financial bid	To be informed later after the approval of technical bid.

9. Details of works:

Gr ou p No	Name of Work	Estimated Cost (in Lakh)	Amount of Earnest Money (in Lakh)	Cost of Tender Document (non-refundable) in Rs.	BSEDC Bid Processin g Fee (in Rs.)	Completi on Period (in months)
1	Comprehensive operation and maintenance, routine repairs and Special repairs of i.) Rural Piped Water Supply Scheme (PWS), (18 nos.) ii.) Single Village piped water supply schemes (SVS), (0 nos.) iii.) Ward level Piped Water Supply Schemes in quality affected wards (WLS_Quality) and (16 nos.) iv.) Ward level Piped Water Supply Schemes in non quality affected wards (WLS_Non Quality) (36 nos.) based on item rates; constructed by the Public Health Engineering Department including payment to the pump operators, electricity bills for five years.	1944.66100	29.50	10000.00	17700.00	60

Executive Engineer
Public Health Division, Darbhanga
PR- 012365 (PHED) 2026-27
For further details please visit : www.state.bihar.gov.in/prdbihar

नशे से बचने का है एक ही उपचार, दृढ़ संकल्प और परिवार से प्यार

कार्यपालक अभियंता का कार्यालय,
लोक स्वास्थ्य प्रमंडल, तेघड़ा
शुद्धि-पत्र (वर्ष-2026-27)

एतद् द्वारा सूचित किया जाता है कि इस कार्यालय का पत्रांक-854, दिनांक-08.09.2026 के द्वारा निर्धारित अल्पकालीन ई-निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना सं०-NIT NO-06/O&M-PHED/MVS /TEGHRA/2026-27, जिसका PR No.-011415(PHED) 2026-27 है। जिसे प्रकाशन हेतु निदेशक, सूचना एवं जन-सम्पर्क विभाग, बिहार, पटना को भेजी गयी है। जिसकी कड़िका संख्या8 में अपरिहार्य कारणवश संशोधित किया जाता है।

पूर्व निर्धारित कड़िका संख्या :-8

Group No	Name of Work	Estimated Cost (in Lakh)	Amount of Earnest Money (in Lakh)	Cost of Tender Document (non-refundable) in Rs.	BSEDC Bid Processing Fee (in Rs.)	Completion Period (in months)
1	Comprehensive Operation and Maintenance of Surface Water Based Cherिया Bariyarpur Multi Village Pipe Water Supply Scheme of Capacity 5.65 MLD Including Supply of Manpower, Maintenance of Infrastructure and Mechanical Parts, Maintenance of FHTC, SCADA and Electricity Payment, of Electro Mechanical Parts including Building, Lighting and Other Accessories of WTP based on actual consumption of electricity. Covering 70 Wards Under Five Panchayat (Sripur, Khajapur, Pabra, Bariyarpur, Sahpur) of Cherिया Bariyarpur Block Under P.H. Division, Teghra In District Begusarai For Five Years. Salient Features of Cherिया Bariyarpur MVS:- 1. Source - River Gandak A. Intake Well (6.73 MLD) B. Gangway 2. Water Treatment Plant (5.65 MLD) A. Pre Settling Tank - 2nos B. PST Pump House - 1 nos C. Cascade Aerator - 1 nos. D. Flash Mixer 1 nos. E. Clarifloculator - 1 nos. F. Filter House - 1nos. G. Clear Water Reservoir (800 CUM) & Pump House- 1 nos. H. Backwash Sump-1 nos. I. Centrifuge building J. Chemical House K. Staff Quarter L. MESR (750 kl) staging-26 mtr and Five Zonal ESR (175 Kl-470KL with (12 Meter-17 Meter) Staggering M. Boundry Wall N. Rising main -11634 mtr. O. Distribution main- 72150 mtr. P. Total pump capacity- 235.5 kw(Approx) Q. Total No. of House connection- 12343 no.	1964.40	29.65	10,000.00	Applicable as per e-proc2	60 months

संशोधित कड़िका संख्या :-8

Group No	Name of Work	Estimated Cost (in Lakh)	Amount of Earnest Money (in Lakh)	Cost of Tender Document (non-refundable) in Rs.	BSEDC Bid Processing Fee (in Rs.)	Completion Period (in months)
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अन्य सभी शर्तें एवं कड़िका यथावत् रहेगी। कार्यपालक अभियंता लोक स्वास्थ्य प्रमंडल, तेघड़ा
PR- 012172 (PHED) 2026-27

नशे से बचने का है एक ही उपचार, दृढ़ संकल्प और परिवार से प्यार।

Political storm over EC divide

Opposition calls for arrest, removal of CEC Gyanesh Kumar; BJP backs Election Commission, says 'functioning in a democratic manner'



“BJP won the elections in Bihar, West Bengal and other states because of CEC Gyanesh Kumar... He is working on the directions of PM Narendra Modi and Home Minister Amit Shah. Fresh polls should be held in Bihar and West Bengal.”

TEJASHWI YADAV,
RASHTRIYA JANATA DAL



“This is not merely a political issue. It concerns the rights of every citizen of the country. Government should convene an urgent all-party meeting on this issue.”

SUPRIYA SULE,
NATIONALIST CONGRESS PARTY (SP)



“The question used to be 'who will watch the watchdogs'. Now, it's 'Is there even a watchdog?'”

ASADUDDIN OWAISI,
ALL INDIA MAJLIS-E-ITTEHADUL MUSLIMEEN



“...If it (deletions and additions in electoral rolls) continues like this, there will be a time when we'll resemble a banana republic, and there will be no democracy left.”

MEHBOOBA MUFTI,
PEOPLES DEMOCRATIC PARTY



“The gang has been exposed. This gang has been involved in splitting parties, stealing democracy, and its kingpin is Gyanesh Kumar.”

UDDHAV THACKERAY,
SHIV SENA (UBT)

Act of treason, say Rahul, Priyanka; Cong demands CEC's resignation

'Vote chori' a crime against people, direct attack on Constitution: LoP

Asad Rehman
New Delhi, September 23

THE CONGRESS on Wednesday demanded the removal of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar and accused the ruling BJP and the poll panel of “treason”, following *The Indian Express* investigation into the objections raised by Election Commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi to decisions taken regarding the contentious Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of voter rolls.

Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi, who has been ques-



Congress MP Priyanka Gandhi Vadra speaks to mediapersons during her visit to Kerala's Malappuram district on Wednesday. PTI

tioning the Election Commission and its poll practices over the past months, said on X: “Vote chori is a crime against the Indian people and a direct attack on our Constitution. The BJP, RSS and EC who organised it have committed an act of treason. Justice will be served.”

In an interaction with reporters at the Congress office in Delhi, senior Congress leader and Rajya Sabha MP Abhishek Singhvi demanded Gyanesh Kumar's resignation and said the BJP has opened “an office for the murder of democracy”. The Congress, led by Gan-

dhi, has been running a “vote chori” campaign against the EC, accusing it of large-scale poll irregularities and working in cahoots with the ruling BJP.

Citing *The Indian Express* report, Congress said: “We have been saying, Modi has captured the Election Commission. Gyanesh Kumar is Modi's puppet.”

The poll panel and the ruling party have rubbished these allegations. At Wednesday's press conference, Singhvi said the issue highlighted in the investigation is “extremely serious”.

“It can be fatal for ours and any democracy. It is an example of double bulldozer government where there is an external bulldozer... which assaults all major institutions of India... Apart from that external bulldozer, we have an internal bulldozer — the CEC, which has bulldozed his own organisation, his colleagues... He

runs it like a feudal lord not answerable to any authority,” he said. “The BJP has opened an office for the murder of democracy. On one end, they have posted the CEC, and on the other hand, is the Home Ministry. I will establish this theme. This is a serious matter and is fatal for our republic.”

Wayanad MP and Congress general secretary Priyanka Gandhi Vadra, too, said “treason” had been committed.

“This is an extremely serious issue for our democracy. If there are no elections, then where is democracy? If elections are unfair and rigged in any manner, then the Election Commission is assisting in that. If the Election Commissioner is not only aware of it but also allowing it to happen, then it is a very serious assault on democracy. It is an act of treason,” she said.

Independent ECI not enough, it must also appear to be so: SC

Decision split, CJI to decide on larger bench over challenge to EC appointment law

Ananthakrishnan G
New Delhi, September 23

DIVIDED OVER the question of referring petitions challenging the 2023 law on the appointment of the Chief Election Commissioner and Election Commissioners to a five-judge Constitution Bench, two judges of the Supreme Court Wednesday left the decision of constituting a larger bench to the Chief Justice of India.

Disagreeing with Justice Satish Chandra Sharma on referring the matter to a five-judge bench, Justice Dipankar Datta underlined that “it is not enough for the ECI to be independent, it must also appear to be independent”. He noted that the role of the Leader of Opposition in the three-member panel for the selection of the CEC and ECs “becomes largely ornamental, without furthering the purpose of his inclusion”.

The CEC and Other ECs (Appointment, Conditions of Service and Term of Office) Act, 2023, which was brought to nullify the effect of a 2023 Supreme Court judgement by a five-judge bench, envisaged a three-member selection committee comprising the Prime Minister, Leader of Opposition and a Union Cabinet Minister. Petitioners challenging the law argued that this violated the spirit of the Supreme Court ruling.

In the 1-1 decision Wednesday, Justice Datta said, “There can be no gainsaying that free and fair elections, to a large extent, depend on a truly independent ECI. It is not enough for the ECI to be independent, it must also appear to be independent. The Minister nominated by the Prime Minister, to function as the third member on the Selection Committee chaired by the Prime Minister, cannot be expected to defy his own nominator and risk his continuation as such nominated member on the committee, for all practical purposes. Even otherwise, the col-



Supreme Court's Justice Dipankar Datta and Justice Satish Chandra Sharma (right)

lective responsibility doctrine would preclude the Minister to oppose his Prime Minister.”

The “inclusion of a Cabinet Minister in the Selection Committee,” he said, “fails to provide the independent counterweight that a neutral selector could and he (Cabinet Minister) would merely echo the voice of his leader; and, consequently, the presence of the Leader of Opposition in the Selection Committee becomes largely ornamental, without furthering the purpose of his inclusion.”

Justice Datta rejected the prayer for reference, concluding that the petitions do not raise any fresh substantial question of law that requires the interpretation of the Constitution but only called for application of already settled principles. Justice Sharma disagreed and said “as there is no authoritative decision of this Court till date pronouncing upon the constitutional validity of the Act, the matter must be heard by a Constitution Bench of not less than 5 Judges”.

In the event of a split decision, the matter is placed before the CJI to set up an appropriate larger bench.

The bench also took note of the concern expressed by the petitioners on the time that could be taken by the Court to decide the reference. While the original plea seeking an independent process to appoint ECs was filed in 2015, it was referred to a larger bench in 2018. The Supreme Court verdict then came in 2023, following which a new law was enacted.



Indian Youth Congress members protest against CEC Gyanesh Kumar, in Delhi on Wednesday. AMIT MEHRA

EC exposed, we have seen it in UP: Akhilesh

Maulshree Seth
Lucknow, September 23

SAMAJWADI PARTY (SP) chief Akhilesh Yadav on Wednesday said the differences and objections raised by election officials during the SIR exercise had raised questions not only over the functioning of the EC, but also over recent electoral outcomes and governments formed during this period.

Referring to *The Indian Express* report, he said, “Election Commission expose ho gaya hai. Hum ise Uttar Pradesh mein bahut kareeb se dekha hai (The Election Commission has been exposed. We have seen it very closely in Uttar Pradesh).”

Yadav questioned whether the poll panel could still be considered a fair and impartial institution: “Now that it has come to light that, so many times over these months, EC officials did not accept the decisions of the EC, you can imagine how fair and impartial the EC would

have been.”

He also questioned whether the functioning of the Constitutional body had implications for governments formed through polls in recent years. “Who is playing with a Constitutional body in order to remain in power? This means the governments formed during this period are unconstitutional governments. They have torn democracy to shreds,” he claimed.

The SP chief further linked the issue to his earlier allegations about the 2022 UP Assembly polls. “I had said this in 2022 — that EC officials deliberately identified and removed Samajwadi Party votes. We submitted information through a large number of affidavits, but no action was taken against even a single official,” he claimed.

Yadav also alleged irregularities during subsequent bypolls, claiming that officials had been identified and that “bade painane par beimani (widespread cheating)” took place.

TMC CHIEF ALLEGES EVM HIJACKING, STATE-SPONSORED POLL MANIPULATION

'Arrest CEC': Mamata seeks repoll

Express News Service
Kolkata, September 23

FORMER WEST Bengal chief minister Mamata Banerjee on Wednesday launched a scathing attack on the EC, demanding the arrest and criminal prosecution of CEC Gyanesh Kumar.

She also sought fresh Assembly polls in the state with the pre-SIR voter list and announced that leaders of the opposition INDIA bloc will launch a nationwide movement to “protect democracy”. Banerjee made the remarks in a Facebook Live, following *The Indian Express* investigation that revealed that two of the three



TMC chief Mamata Banerjee talks on the EC issue virtually. PTI

election commissioners had formally objected, at least 14 times over the last 10 months, to decisions and orders linked

to the SIR of electoral rolls.

Alleging “systemic voter deletion, EVM hijacking and state-sponsored poll manipula-

tion”, she said millions of legitimate voters were disenfranchised in Bengal prior to the polls. “Today, the entire country is in turmoil over CEC Gyanesh Kumar, and my first demand is that he should be arrested and criminal proceedings should be initiated against him,” she said.

The TMC chief also said that the Opposition had moved an impeachment notice against the CEC earlier this year, but it was turned down in Parliament. “All parties are together in this battle. We submitted an impeachment notice against the CEC, but it was rejected... This is no longer merely about impeachment; criminal action is required.”

Cancel recent elections, conduct them afresh: AAP

Express News Service
New Delhi, September 23

THE AAM Aadmi Party described the deletion of voters from the electoral rolls through the SIR process as the “biggest scam in independent India”.

Former Delhi CM and AAP convener Arvind Kejriwal described CEC Gyanesh Kumar as the “chief of vote theft” and demanded his arrest. “So far, people in this country had only heard about Narendra Modi and Amit Shah winning elections by vote chori. Today, a story published by *The Indian Express* has established that they are winning elections through a massive vote scam,” he said.



AAP convener Arvind Kejriwal

“The mastermind behind this ‘vote chori’ is Gyanesh Kumar. We demand that Kumar be arrested and prosecuted. We also demand that all elections held in Delhi, Maharashtra, Bihar, West Bengal and Haryana over the past few years be cancelled and conducted afresh.”

Brittas writes to President, seeks 'urgent intervention', SIR pause

Express News Service
New Delhi, September 23

THE LEFT parties hit out at the BJP on Wednesday following the revelations about the ECs' SIR objections and demanded removal of CEC Gyanesh Kumar and an immediate halt to the SIR exercise.

CPI(M) leader and Rajya Sabha member John Brittas said *The Indian Express* investigation raises serious questions not just about the election process, but also about the integrity of the ECI itself. “The disclosures have only strengthened suspicions and concerns that the CPI(M), other Opposition parties and



CPI(M) leader John Brittas

civil society organisations have all along raised since the SIR process was initiated,” he wrote.

Brittas has also written to President Droupadi Murmu, seeking her “urgent intervention” on the matter. “With over 13 crore names reportedly struck

off draft rolls across 30 States/UTs so far and over 33 lakh Delhi voters issued notices, I have urged that the pending proceedings for removal of the CEC proceed without obstruction, and that the Government take a clear stand before the Supreme Court seeking annulment of the SIR wherever it is found unlawful.”

CPI general secretary D Raja said the matter is a “grave crisis” and the CEC was the face of an “electoral purge”. “The CPI has consistently warned that governments cannot be allowed to handpick voters in a democracy... CEC has no right to continue, and to restore credibility in the ECI, he must resign.”

'CORRECTIVE ACTION IS REQUIRED'

If people's trust in election is lost, what is left in democracy: Omar

Bashaarat Masood
Srinagar, September 23

J&K CHIEF Minister Omar Abdullah on Wednesday said “there is a need for corrective action” and “if people's trust in the election is lost, then what is left in the democracy?”

Speaking to reporters at the Sher-i-Kashmir International Conference Centre in the Valley, he said, “First, I will compliment *The Indian Express*. This was a very good piece of investigative journalism... I think it opens a lot of questions. We have had persistent complaints



J&K CM Omar Abdullah

about the way in which the ECI has functioned. Before SIR became an issue for the rest of the country, for us, delimitation was an issue,” he said.

“We believed the process

was opaque, the process was flawed, and the entire process was designed to benefit one political party and its friends. Given what has been shown — the internal divisions within the ECI — clearly they say that there is something fishy...”

“...There is a need to take some corrective action. Otherwise, if people's trust in the election is lost, then what is left in democracy? The basis of democracy is elections... why should people participate in the elections? So, I think the members of the ECI and the government of India should think about this.”

Gyanesh Kumar must go, SIR must be halted, says Stalin

Arun Janardhanan
Chennai, September 23

DRAVIDA MUNNETRA Kazhagam (DMK) chief and former Tamil Nadu chief minister M K Stalin said CEC Gyanesh Kumar “must go” and that “he has no right to continue in office”.

Sharing the Express report on his Facebook page, Stalin wrote, “The DMK, along with other Opposition parties, has consistently opposed the move to delete crores of voters from the electoral rolls in the name of the SIR. Rushed through just months ahead of elections in State after State, the exercise was riddled with irregularities and sparked widespread unrest, particularly in West Bengal.”

“The explosive findings published by *The Indian Express* today, backed by evidence, have now cast serious doubts over the results of every Assembly election held after the SIR exercise. The investigation reveals that CEC Thiru. Gyanesh Kumar had been acting unilaterally and in secrecy, without the concurrence of the other two ECs... The revelations have severely eroded the credibility of the Election Commission,” he wrote.

“...The CEC has no right to continue in office any longer. Thiru. Gyanesh Kumar must go immediately. The SIR exercise must be halted. The DMK demands a fair and thorough investigation into everything that has transpired within the Election Commission and that those responsible be held accountable.”

UP INTERNATIONAL TRADE SHOW

4th Edition

September 25 26 27 28 29, 2026
India Expo Centre & Mart, Greater Noida

UTTAR PRADESH'S GATEWAY TO GLOBAL MARKETS, INVESTMENT & INNOVATION

The fourth edition of the Uttar Pradesh International Trade Show (UPITS) 2026, to be held at India Expo Centre & Mart, Greater Noida, from September 25-29, will bring Uttar Pradesh's products, industries, MSMEs, startups, exporters, technologies and innovations closer to global markets. With participation from international buyers, partner countries and thousands of exhibitors, UPITS is positioned as a major platform for business partnerships, exports, investment and the global branding of Uttar Pradesh.



Total B2B Visitors

Total B2C Visitors

Total Exhibitors

Participating Countries

Business Enquiries Generated

Social Media Impressions

2023

70,000

2,37,000

1914

66

100,000

7.66 Million

2024

1,03,688

3,21,580

2050

70

200,000

23.20 Million

2025

140,735

3,66,364

2228

75

225,000

35.93 Million

FROM CHAMPIONS TO WORLD-CLASS ARENAS NEW UP'S SPORTS STORY TAKES CENTRE STAGE

- **First-Ever Grand Pavilion:** For the first time, the Sports Department will establish a dedicated pavilion of around 200 sq. metres.
- **Meerut Sports University** will be showcased through a key attraction including a 3D model.
- The pavilion will present UP's sporting achievements, modern facilities and future plans.
- **Champions in Focus:** National and international athletes' achievements, inspiring journeys, videos and photographs.
- **Infrastructure Revolution:** 3D models of modern sports facilities showcase the state's expanding sporting ecosystem.
- **Technology-Driven Talent:** AI and digital talent-data management to power smarter sports development.

- **Future-Ready UP:** Initiatives to connect Gen-Z with sports and nurture the next generation of sporting champions.
- Directorate of Sports, Regional Development Teams, Youth Welfare, Sports Colleges and the Sports University will participate together.



From Fitness to Play – Stock Up on Sports Opportunities under ODOP
Refresh Your Retail Shelves with New-Age Sports Products.



A MEGA BUSINESS & TRADE PLATFORM

2,400+ exhibitors expected to participate.

550+ international buyers from 85 countries being connected with the event.

Over 1.50 lakh domestic B2B buyers expected.

Around 4.50 lakh B2C visitors projected.

Target of 4,000+ MoUs, with potential value of ₹3,200 crore+.

Business leads and enquiries expected to exceed ₹13,500 crore.

TAKING 'MADE IN UP' TO THE WORLD

- UPITS brings together products, investment opportunities, industrial infrastructure and global trade prospects.
- MSMEs, ODOP units, exporters, entrepreneurs and industrial organisations get a common platform to explore new markets.
- Domestic and international buyer-exhibitor interactions are aimed at creating new business partnerships and expansion opportunities.
- 20 knowledge sessions proposed on business, industry and exports.
- Business, innovation, exports and Uttar Pradesh's rich cultural heritage will come together on one platform.

SIX PARTNER COUNTRIES ON THE GLOBAL STAGE

- Japan, Vietnam, Russia, Singapore, Belarus and Austria have confirmed participation as partner countries.
- International representatives, buyers and business organisations will engage with UP businesses on: ■ Market requirements ■ Export opportunities ■ Business partnerships ■ Global market access
- Participation from international delegations and corporate buyers is expected to widen opportunities for Uttar Pradesh exporters.

MORADABAD'S BRASS LEGACY MEETS GLOBAL OPPORTUNITY

- 78 businesses and entrepreneurs from Moradabad will showcase traditional and contemporary products.
- 42 new exporters will participate in Hall 14, taking their first steps towards global markets.
- 14 established exporters will participate in Hall 15.
- 12 ODOP stalls will showcase Moradabad's renowned brass and metal craftsmanship.
- 10 MSME/Women/Young Entrepreneur stalls will highlight innovation, startups and emerging enterprise.
- The participation is designed to connect the Brass City's artisans and businesses directly with international buyers and retail networks.

BAGHPAT'S HANDLOOMS & HONEY EYE GLOBAL MARKETS

- 20+ Baghpat businesses to showcase handlooms, honey, home furnishings and agricultural products.
- GI-tagged Baghpat Home Furnishing from Khekra will feature prominently.
- ODOP pavilion will showcase Ghewar & Balushahi.

MEERUT'S LOCAL PRODUCTS EYE GLOBAL MARKETS

- 50+ entrepreneurs will showcase products spanning agriculture, food processing, sports, handicrafts and MSMEs.
- Polyhouse farming, flowers and honey products will be key attractions.
- Women and young entrepreneurs will connect directly with international buyers.
- Revdi, gajak and nan-khatai will showcase Meerut's culinary heritage.



Chaupal Connect

BJP PRESIDENT Nitin Babin has asked senior party leaders to be available for ‘pocket meetings’, or Ja-nata Chaupals, to be held as part of pre-poll outreach in Uttar Pradesh. Sources said BJP heavyweights as well as MPs are likely to be deployed to address these micro-level meetings where more beneficiaries for government welfare schemes would be enrolled. The exercise was successfully tested against the Trinamool Congress in West Bengal, where these meetings were seen to have supplemented the BJP’s social media blitz during its campaign for the Assembly elections.

Due Credit

CABINET SECRETARY T V Somanathan’s behind-the-scenes role in the celebrations marking 150 years of *Vande Mataram* has found recognition in a new book, *Vande Mataram ke 150 Adhyay*. Written by bureaucrat couple Akhilesh Jha and Rashmita Jha, the book was recently launched by Union Home Minister Amit Shah. It chronicles the National Song’s 150-year journey and its historical and cultural significance. The book is dedicated to Somanathan and describes him as “Kachchhaprishi” (the back of a tortoise), someone who quietly keeps things moving without seeking the spotlight.

ED ex-officer Niranjan Singh joins Akali Dal Waris Punjab De

Press Trust of India
Chandigarh, September 23

FORMER ENFORCEMENT Directorate deputy director Niranjan Singh on Wednesday joined the Akali Dal Waris Punjab De ahead of the Punjab Assembly elections here. Former deputy superintendent of police Balwinder Singh Sekhon also joined the party in the presence of MLA Manpreet Singh Ayali, Tarsem Singh, the father of jailed Khadoor Sahib MP Amritpal Singh and Faridkot MP Sarabjit Singh Khalsa. While welcoming the former ED officer into the party fold, Ayali said Niranjan Singh’s joining will boost the Akali Dal Waris Punjab De. Asked about allegations of the misuse of central agencies including the ED, Niranjan said there is no government which does not misuse it a “little bit”. Niranjan, however, said that he always worked as per the law when he was serving in the ED.

Year after Leh violence, cases against 20 are withdrawn

Express News Service
Srinagar, September 23

A YEAR AFTER four civilians were killed in police firing after protests turned violent in Leh, Ladakh Lieutenant Governor Vinai Kumar Saxena on Wednesday announced the withdrawal of criminal cases against 20 of the 87 people booked in the aftermath of that incident. This includes Jigmat Dorjay, Rinchen Dadul, Stanzin Nam-gail and Tsewang Thirchin, who died last year, as per officials. Withdrawal of criminal cases has remained one of the key demands of Ladakh’s representatives during ongoing talks with the Ministry of Home Affairs. This comes a month after the administration had stated that they will be filing closure reports in cases pertaining to 25 of the 87 people booked in the aftermath of the violence on September 24 last year. Out of the 87 identified accused in the rioting cases, 81 were arrested, and criminal proceedings began against them.

Ladakh chief secretary Ashish Kundra had earlier said that nine people had been chargesheeted, suggesting that “there is evidence of their involvement” in the incident. He had also stated that L-G’s office had directed the Ladakh DGP to “review the cases of the rest of the people who are still part of the investigation.”

On Wednesday, the administration announced withdrawal of more cases, with L-G Saxena stating that the move is in the larger interest of peace, public tranquility, and social harmony in Ladakh. Following a comprehensive review, the Ladakh police recommended a closure report for 20 individuals.

Seafarer from UP dies after missile attack on carrier off Oman coast

Divya A
New Delhi, September 23

A seafarer from Uttar Pradesh died of head injuries hours after the Antigua and Barbuda-flagged bulk carrier that he was on board was hit by a missile off the coast of Oman.

New Delhi has expressed deep worry on the continuing attacks on commercial shipping in the region, and has called for “dialogue and diplomacy” for peace in the region. “My heartfelt condolences to the family of young Indian seafarer, Suraj Yadav from Uttar Pradesh, who tragically succumbed to head injuries following a missile attack on MV CAPE DAO off the coast of Oman....” Union Minister of Ports and Shipping Sarb-nanda Sonowal wrote on X. He added that the government will ensure that the mortal remains of Yadav are brought home with full dignity, and every possible support is extended to his next of kin. The vessel, MV CAPE DAO,

uals, in FIR no. 144/2005, registered at PS - Leh, under section 360 of the BNSS, Sinha said in a communique from Lok Niwas.

This decision, he added, ensures that these 20 individuals move forward positively with their lives and careers. “By prioritising justice and healing over protracted litigation, the decision aims at fostering a more peaceful, united, and harmonious society in Ladakh. I extend my sincere gratitude to Hon’ble Union Home Minister, Shri @AmitShah ji for his constant guidance and sympathetic approach, in matters pertaining to the victims and their families.”

This also comes days after the Centre proposed a constitutional provision of ‘Article 371(K)’ in a bid to extend additional protections to Ladakh during a meeting of the sub-committee with the MHA earlier this month. Quashing of the cases has been a key demand of the representatives who have been part of a dialogue with the Centre seeking greater democratic representation and constitutional protections for the region.

Four protesters were killed and 44 injured as police fired after a protest for statehood and the Sixth Schedule for Ladakh turned violent in Leh on September 24 last year. After the protests, Sonam Wangchuk, who was on a hunger strike, was booked under the National Security Act. On September 13, a compensation of Rs 15 lakh to the next of kin of each of the four deceased was sanctioned. An ex-gratia of Rs 3 lakh for those with major injuries and Rs 1 lakh for minor injuries had also been approved by the L-G.

had 20 Indian seafarers on board. All 19 surviving crew members have been safely evacuated by the Royal Navy of Oman and are currently ashore, Sonowal said.

He added that directions have also been issued to maritime authorities to coordinate closely with Omani authorities and the ship management company to ensure the immediate and safe repatriation of the surviving crew.

Meanwhile, in a statement on Wednesday evening, the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) condemned the attack on the commercial vessel, while offering condolences to the family of the deceased Indian national.

“We offer our deepest condolences to the family of the deceased. Our Embassy in Oman is closely monitoring the situation and proactively coordinating with the Omani authorities for early repatriation of the Indian seafarers. We thank the Omani authorities for their support,” the MEA said.

‘Global South in front row of crises, in the back row of decision-making’

Jaishankar says institutions meant for a different era continue to reflect power structures of that time

Divya A
New Delhi, September 23

THE GLOBAL SOUTH may be in the front row of global crises, but it is in the “back row” of decision-making, External Affairs Minister (EAM) S Jaishankar said in New York on Tuesday, calling for greater solidarity among developing countries of the region.

Speaking at the High-Level Meeting of Like-Minded Global South Countries and Friends on the sidelines of the 81st United Nations General Assembly (UNGA), Jaishankar said that the meeting is taking place at a time of “considerable global uncertainty”.

This uncertainty, he said, is apparent in the many “conflicts and geopolitical tensions, in the disruption of supply chains, in increasing trade barriers, fragmented investment flows, climate shocks, and the fact that

J&K High Court allows 11-yr-old to terminate pregnancy

Arun Sharma
Jammu, September 23

THE JAMMU, Kashmir and Ladakh High Court on Tuesday allowed an 11-year-old girl to terminate her pregnancy, saying the mere fact that it had crossed the statutory 24-week period prescribed under the Medical Termination of Pregnancy Act could not result in denial of constitutional protection to the child.

Disposing of a petition filed on behalf of the minor for medical termination of her pregnancy, Justice Wasim Sadiq Nargal directed the authorities to take immediate steps, saying that “the minor being about 11 years old cannot be compelled from the sexual assault committed upon her”.

The ruling came after a medical board found that the pregnancy had advanced to 24 weeks and 02 days by September 22, the date of the judgment.

The Medical Board had examined the minor on September 11 and said she was physically and mentally fit to undergo an abortion. The Board further said an abortion at this stage was medically feasible, although it carried increased maternal and procedural risks, including haemorrhage or bleeding, infection and the need for blood transfusion.

The minor, who had moved with her family to Baramulla in March, had developed fever, vomiting, cough and abdominal pain. A medical examination revealed that she was pregnant. The minor disclosed that she had been sexually assaulted by an unknown person during her stay in Kashmir. The alleged offender has yet to be arrested.



S Jaishankar with Italy’s Deputy Prime Minister Antonio Tajani on the sidelines of the UNGA in New York on Wednesday. PTI

international law and rules are under great pressure.”

“The Global South may be in the front row of the global crises, but is in the back row of decision-making,” Jaishankar said, noting that institutions created for a different era inadvertently continue to reflect the power structures of that time.

“The Global South needs to be part of decision-making structures that deliberate on issues that directly pertain to our future,” the EAM said, adding that in the past year, the world has seen an increase in the number of active conflicts,

which pose a significant risk to the global economy, particularly for the Global South.

“At a time when we needed to turn to multilateralism, we actually witnessed its dismantling,” Jaishankar said.

Jaishankar chaired the meeting under the theme ‘Navigating Together Towards a Brighter Future — the Compelling Case for an Empowered Global South’, as per the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA).

Representatives from the participating countries expressed shared concern over the weakening of multilateral

2 days after Justice Chavan’s exit, Maharashtra UCC panel inducts former IAS officer

Vidheesha Kuntamalla
Dehradun, September 23

TWO DAYS after retired Bombay High Court judge Justice R C Chavan resigned from Maharashtra’s Uniform Civil Code committee, retired IAS officer Shatrughna Singh, who had attended the panel’s September 19 meeting as an adviser, was appointed a member-cum-senior adviser by the Maharashtra government on September 21, *The Indian Express* has learnt. Singh is the “non-member” whose presence at the September 19 meeting Justice Chavan referred to in his resignation email, questioning the role of someone who was not part of the seven-member committee.

When contacted by *The Indian Express*, Singh declined to comment on the matter. Calls to the committee’s chairperson, retired Supreme Court judge Justice Ranjana Desai, also did not elicit a response.

It is learnt that Singh was invited by Justice Ranjana Desai to participate in the September 19 meeting as an “adviser”. The committee held two meetings in September, and Singh attended only the second, where he was introduced to the members and told he would be giving his inputs, sources familiar with the committee’s functioning said.

That meeting was held hours before Justice Chavan submitted his resignation. One of the issues discussed during the meeting was the questionnaire through which the committee plans to seek public feedback on the proposed UCC, it is learnt. It is learnt that Justice Chavan suggested the questionnaire include



Justice R C Chavan

more questions of a subjective nature to elicit detailed views from respondents. The committee, however, decided to proceed with a questionnaire containing a combination of objective and subjective questions, sources said.

The questionnaire is expected to be opened for public feedback in the coming days and will contain close to three dozen questions, it is learnt.

During the meeting, Singh raised concerns about modifications to the website being prepared for public consultation, sources said. These included changes to the introductory text explaining the UCC to people in Maharashtra and the manner in which the questionnaire would be incorporated into the website for public access.

In his resignation email, Chavan said that the non-member who attended the meeting had pointed out that the website prepared by state officials required further modifications. According to Chavan’s account, the chairperson then directed the authorities to make the necessary changes within a week.

institutions, and emphasised the urgent need for comprehensive reforms, particularly in the UN, an MEA statement read.

Jaishankar also stressed that Global South countries must “not accept or legitimise” choke-points, whether in supply chains, finance or connectivity. “Energy security is at the heart of development. Availability and prices should not be manipulated for political ends,” he said.

He also participated in the India-UAE-France trilateral on Tuesday. “Collaboration in the fields of AI, Space, health sciences, energy and culture was the main topic of discussion,” he wrote on X after the meeting.

Foreign Ministers of the G4 nations of India, Brazil, Germany and Japan also met in New York and discussed the imperative of reformed multilateralism and a more representative UN Security Council.

Jaishankar also met with Nepalese counterpart Shisir Khanal, Qatar’s Emir Sheikh Tamim bin Hamad Al Thani, Philippines’ Foreign Affairs Secretary Theresa Lazaro, and German Foreign Minister Johann Wadephul. His meeting with Italy’s Deputy Prime Minister and Foreign Minister Antonio Tajani focused on the Gulf, the India-Middle East-Europe Economic Corridor, and Ukraine.

India rejects reference to J&K in OIC communique

Divya A
New Delhi, September 23

INDIA ON Wednesday categorically rejected references to the Union Territory of Jammu & Kashmir in a joint communique released by the Organisation of Islamic Cooperation (OIC) Contact Group on Jammu & Kashmir, after a meeting was held on the sidelines of the 81st session of United Nations General Assembly (UNGA) in New York.

The statement came hours after Turkish President Recep Tayyip Erdogan had also raised the Kashmir issue during his address to world leaders on Tuesday. Alongside Pakistan, Turkey, Saudi Arabia, Azerbaijan and Niger are part of the 57-member group.

“The OIC has no locus standi to pronounce on matters that are strictly internal to India. The entire Union Territories of Jammu & Kashmir and Ladakh are integral and inalienable parts of India, and no amount of repetition of politically motivated propaganda can change this reality,” said a statement by the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) on Wednesday.

“Repeated endorsement of such motivated narratives only raises serious questions on the credibility of OIC,” it said, while rejecting the unwarranted and “factually incorrect” references to India in the joint communique of the so-called OIC Contact Group.

“Instead of offering a platform to Pakistan to peddle its fabricated and motivated propaganda, the OIC will be better advised to counsel Pakistan, which has a well-documented record of supporting and sponsoring terrorism, to look inwards and address the continuing threat of terrorism emanating from territories under its control,” the MEA said.

SIT submits 74,000-page chargesheet in Ram Temple donation ‘theft’

Manish Sahu
Lucknow, September 23

THE SPECIAL Investigation Team (SIT) probing the alleged embezzlement of donations at the Ram Temple in Ayodhya has filed a chargesheet against the eight arrested accused at a local court on Wednesday.

“The chargesheet has been accepted by the court,” said Senior Superintendent of Police (Ayodhya) Gaurav Grover, adding that it has been filed under various provisions, including criminal breach of trust and the Prevention of Corruption Act. The chargesheet, which runs to around 74,000 pages, includes supporting documents, annexures, exhibits, and other evidence, he said. All eight accused — Avinash Shukla, Lavkush Mishra, Anukalp Mishra, Manish Kumar Yadav, Kamunesh Pandey, Ramashankar Mishra, Ram Shankar Yadav alias Tinnu Yadav, and Subhash Srivastav — are in judicial custody. On Monday, Solicitor General Tushar Mehta submitted the status report in the Supreme Court.

● ANNOUNCEMENT COMES FIVE MONTHS AHEAD OF UP ASSEMBLY ELECTIONS, WEEKS AFTER PARTY SUPREMO SAID NEITHER NEPHEW WILL PLAY A POLITICAL ROLE IN THE PARTY

Mayawati does flip-flop before UP polls, gives nephew Ishan key role

After Akash Anand’s removal earlier this month, the Bahujan Samajwadi Party was left without a face for younger voters

Lalmani Verma
Lucknow, September 23

DAYS AFTER announcing her “*antim faisla* (final decision)” that neither of her two nephews, Akash Anand and Ishan Anand, will engage in politics and hold any party position, BSP president Mayawati made another “U-turn” on Wednesday, naming Ishan as the party’s new national convener.

Mayawati made the announcement at a meeting of the

BSP’s national office-bearers in Lucknow, where Ishan, wearing a blue party scarf, touched her aunt’s feet to seek her blessings, and got a seat in the front row with all the senior party office-bearers including his father Anand Kumar, the party’s national vice-president.

Addressing the meeting, Ishan, 25, expressed gratitude to Mayawati for appointing him the party national convener, assuring the leadership that he will execute his responsibilities with

“honesty and dedication”. The development comes barely five months before the high-stakes Uttar Pradesh Assembly elections.

Ishan is a post-graduate in law (LLM). BSP sources said that before he was brought into the party, he used to manage the family-run hotels besides handling its pharma distribution business. He largely stayed away from politics till his elder brother Akash was active in the BSP. Sources said Ishan’s elevation



BSP chief Mayawati with nephew Ishan Anand during a party workers’ meeting in Lucknow on Wednesday. VISHAL SRIVASTAV

comes at a time when Akash’s political space in the party has shrunk. Akash had earlier held

the post of the BSP national convener, but was removed from all party responsibilities by Maya-

wati earlier this month.

After Akash’s removal, the BSP was left without a face that could connect with young voters. “It took over eight months for the party to groom Akash Anand as its young face in the past eight years. Now, Mayawati will have to groom Ishan and that will take time. The situation is challenging for us now because all the parties are trying hard to woo Gen Z voters. But BSP is still trying to bring its own house in order,” remarked a BSP leader on Ishan’s appointment.

In a statement earlier this month, Mayawati had announced her “final decision” that neither of her two nephews will play a political role in her

party. She had then also said Anand Kumar could seek the help of his only daughter, Kumari Deepika Anand, and, if required, entrust her with his party responsibilities in the future.

Days before that, she had appointed Ishan as the chief sector coordinator, a new post created just for him. But he was removed from the post within a week.

However, a few days ago, in another U-turn on the role of other family members in the party, Mayawati said her nephew Akash and niece Deepika will no longer be given any responsibility in the BSP. However, she said, Ishan will be given a “respectable role” in the organisation.

In a statement on X on September 20, Mayawati said she had reconsidered involving members of Anand Kumar’s family in the BSP and decided to keep Akash and his sister away from the party affairs. “Since his marriage, Akash Anand’s conduct and activities at every step have been such that just a few days ago, he had to be separated from the party once again,” she said.

On Ishan, Mayawati said he would now be the family member to be taken forward within the BSP. She added that her intention was to ensure that there was no repetition of the circumstances that had arisen around Akash.

Gujarat HC denies interim relief to journalist Ravi Nair

Aditi Raja
Vadodara, September 23

JOURNALIST RAVI Nair will remain in jail as the Gujarat High Court on Wednesday declined interim relief to him and reserved its order on his plea challenging non-bailable warrant issued by Gandhinagar District and Sessions Court for failing to personally appear during a hearing in a criminal defamation case filed by Adani Enterprises.

Justice M K Thakker of the Gujarat HC said the court would pronounce its order on September 30 and adjourned the case proceedings to Thursday. When Nair's counsel sought his release pending the order, the court observed that the matter had already been heard and kept for dictation, and therefore "no interim relief is required to be granted". The HC questioned Nair's challenge to the non-bailable warrant, noting it had already been executed. It orally said Nair had not informed the HC he had moved the sessions court seeking regular bail.

Defending Collegium, SC says Govt's remarks 'disquieting'

Flags Centre's 'selective' clearance of names sent for judges' appointments

Ananthakrishnan G
New Delhi, September 23

REJECTING A plea to refer petitions against the 2023 law on the appointment of Chief Election Commissioner and other Election Commissioners to a five-judge Constitution bench, Justice Dipankar Datta on Wednesday termed as "disingenuous, evasive and disquieting" the Centre's oral submissions that the Supreme Court cannot call for "participation of outsiders" in appointing poll officials when the collegium system which has been criticised as "judges appointing judges" does not allow an "outsider".

"In the context of the present challenge, reference to the criticism on such a sensitive issue ought best to have been left

alone. In the course of the hearing, this Court preferred not to seriously react. The first instinct, too, while writing this opinion, was to be reticent and let such criticism pass. But on a second thought, it is realised that the judiciary cannot always be at the receiving end. A couple of relevant observations in response need to be made, lest the silence be misunderstood as a tacit acceptance by the Court of such unworthy criticism in circulation," Justice Datta wrote.

The response to submissions which were made by Solicitor General (SG) Tushar Mehta on behalf of the Centre came in the court's 70-page split verdict.

The other judge on the bench, Justice S C Sharma, however, said the SG's "submission was not as a criticism of the

Collegium system or regarding the role of the executive in the appointment of Judges...nor initiating any debate regarding the manner in which the system of selection has worked" but one "to the effect that if the Constitution Bench has held that the presence of outsiders in the collegium as violative of doctrine of separation of powers, a similar independence should be read in the executive also and the rules framed under Article 324 be not declared void on the ground either that it does not have any outsider in the Committee of Selection or there is predominance of only executive in the Committee of Selection."

Justice Datta said the submissions sought to "draw a parallel with judicial appointments...has a bearing on the integrity of the institution". "At every stage prior to the recommendations taking shape, the executive is involved. Whispers are heard in the corri-

dors that unless approval of the [...] however, let whispers remain whispers and not drown the constitutional wisdom that has sustained the institution. What is, however, unmissable is that even at the end of the day, acceptance of the recommendations is within the exclusive domain of the executive; it may, or may not, accept the recommendations. The final say rests with the executive," Justice Datta said.

He also chided the Centre for "selectively" clearing names recommended by the Collegium.

"A sweeping generalisation that the Collegium acts as a law unto itself overlooks the detailed consultative process envisaged under the Constitution. And the intrinsic role of the executive, both at the Centre, and in the states, as well as intelligence and other agencies in the appointment process...and the fact that every appointment bears the imprimatur of the President."

Justice Datta said people "have...been made to believe that the Collegium...comprises judges who appoint judges. And it has become fashionable nowadays to blame the Collegium for every infelicitous choice, conveniently forgetting that aberrations are exceptions and not the norm."

He said "this court is left to wonder why, even after the judiciary has been relegated to playing second fiddle to the executive in the matter of appointments of judges, is there still a clamour to induct an outsider at the stage of selection?" and expressed the "hope and trust that henceforth, only judicious and apposite choices shall be made by the present Collegium, under the able leadership of the CJI."

He stressed, "despite all its opacity and imperfections, the Collegium system still remains the most viable option for safeguarding independence..."



Residence of Satyendar Jain in Chandigarh on Wednesday. JASBIR MALHI

ED breaks open locks of bungalow, raids Satyendar Jain's Chandigarh house

Kanchan Vasdev
Chandigarh, September 23

ENFORCEMENT DIRECTORATE (ED) officials Wednesday evening broke open the locks of government bungalow number 926 in Sector 39 of Chandigarh, where AAP leader and former Delhi minister Satyendar Jain has been staying, and entered the premises as part of their ongoing investigation linked to alleged irregularities in Greater Mohali Area Development Authority (GMADA) affairs.

Sources said Jain was not present at the residence when ED team arrived. He had chaired a meeting at the residence in the morning in connection with sand mining and left for Delhi later in the day, sources said.

The action comes a day after ED officials conducted searches at GMADA headquarters and other locations in Punjab, Chandigarh, Haryana and Delhi as part of a money laundering investigation involving Delhi-based Tirupati Infraprojects Pvt Ltd and associated companies.

The ED is examining alleged irregularities in land acquisition,

change-of-land-use (CLU) permissions, property auctions and financial concessions allegedly extended to private realtors. The probe has also brought under its scanner decisions relating to acquisition of more than 5,000 acres in Mohali and New Chandigarh, besides changes in land use and alleged manipulation of statutory planning and land acquisition processes.

The AAP condemned ED officials, "They cannot do anything except break the locks. Why are they so desperate? They could have waited for Jain to come back," said an AAP leader.

The party said, "The Centre is trying to disrupt GMADA's functioning and create hurdles for the Bhagwant Mann government's welfare schemes, including the Mawan Dheeyan Satkar Yojna. Central agencies cannot manufacture political support for PM Modi and the BJP in Punjab. The BJP is unable to stop the welfare schemes through political means, so attempts are now being made to create administrative pressure and obstacles. The people of Punjab will not allow these tactics to succeed."

From ISRO to founder of one of the world's longest cultural festivals

Shaju Philip
Thiruvananthapuram, September 23

FROM SPACE scientist at ISRO to the architect of the Soorya Festival, one of the longest cultural festivals in the world, Nataraja 'Soorya' Krishnamoorthy played many parts during his 75-year-long life. On Wednesday, that life ended with the passing of Kerala's prominent cultural icon and founder of the Soorya Stage and Film Society.

Krishnamoorthy's departure came days before the 48th edition of the Soorya festival was slated to begin its 111-day-long journey on October 1.

Born into a family of engineers in Kerala's Kottayam district, Nataraja 'Soorya' Krishnamoorthy graduated in electrical engineering from TKM College of Engineering, Kollam, and joined ISRO as a scientist in 1972. Krishnamoorthy worked as a space scientist under veterans of those years – the future President of India, APJ Abdul Kalam.

But even during his years there, Krishnamoorthy had a passion for the arts – from founding Soorya Stage and Film Society in Thiruvananthapuram and starting the film festival in 1977 to being the first person to introduce the light-and-sound show in Malayalam back in 1978. His Soorya Stage and Film Society would later go global.

In 1999, after working at ISRO for 27 years, Krishnamoorthy took voluntary retirement, immersing himself completely in promotion of art and culture. He eventually became associated with all things art – from dance, and theatre to photography, scripting, and directing several productions, and turningsound, light and music into a powerful medium for storytelling.

Since it was founded, the Soorya festival, which endeavours to achieve integration through culture, has grown into



Nataraja 'Soorya' Krishnamoorthy

one of Kerala's largest events, showcasing the best of Indian art and culture. The Limca Book of Records recognised the festival as the longest festival of Asia and the society as the largest cultural society in Asia. By conducting film festivals, presenting directors and holding their retrospectives, he took Keralites to the rich legacy of world cinema.

As an organiser, Krishnamoorthy had directed major events involving thousands of performers. He was involved in the inaugural and valedictory ceremonies of the National Games held in Delhi and the 50th Republic Day celebrations.

Krishnamoorthy had been director of Kerala State Film Development Corporation for three terms and served as a member of the national film awards jury and Kerala film awards jury. He had also been a member of expert and advisory committees connected with the Union government's cultural policy and Doodarshan.

In Kerala he had served as chairman of the Kerala Sangeetha Nataka Akademi. He also wrote the script for a Malayalam film 'Mevilasom' in 2011.

In his condolence message, Chief Minister V D Satheesan called Krishnamoorthy "a revolutionary force" in Malayalam theatre, ushering in new waves of technology and aesthetic expression, "The passing of this irreplaceable architect of Kerala's cultural landscape is an irreparable loss to the state's artistic and literary world."

Maharashtra drought situation likely to be worse than 1972, says Fadnavis

Express News Service
Mumbai, September 23

MAHARASHTRA IS heading for a severe drought which is likely to be worse than that of 1972, Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis said on Wednesday, adding the government would issue a notification shortly. The CM's remarks came during his day-long tour of drought-prone districts of Latur, Dharrashiv and Solapur.

Describing the situation in Latur and Dharrashiv in Marathwada region as "extremely serious", the CM said the two districts received only half the normal rainfall this year, and promised all possible assistance to affected farmers. Along with Marathwada region, several other districts in Maharashtra are reeling under severe rain deficit caused by the El Nino, resulting in massive crop loss, the CM said. "There is distress and anguish among farmers. We will provide all possible assistance. There will be no shortage of funds for drought relief," he said.

The financial aid will be directly credited in the bank account of the farmers who are subjected to hardships due to drought like situation, the CM



CM Devendra Fadnavis interacts with farmers in Marathwada. EXPRESS

said. "We have gathered all the reports and are taking action accordingly. Our loan waiver scheme is also operational and will not be stopped. We are arranging water and fodder as well," he said.

Fadnavis said the state would issue a Government Resolution on the drought situation before Saturday and initiate relief measures. "Wiping the tears of farmers is the government's first duty. We will seek funds from the Centre under the NDRF norms.

However, farmers will not be made to wait till central funds arrive. The state will provide assistance from its own treasury".

Assistance would also be provided to enable farmers to take up sowing for the rabi season, the chief minister added.

On the drinking water situation, Fadnavis said rainfall deficit had severely affected ground-water levels and water bodies. "If only 50 per cent rainfall is received, there will obviously be an impact on water in reservoirs

and wells," he said, adding that the state had anticipated a drinking water crisis and planned water reserves accordingly.

"We have tried to conserve sufficient water for drinking purposes. We have water required until December," he said. Fadnavis attributed the severity of the situation to "Super El Nino".

There is a rain deficit in 31 out of the total 36 districts across Maharashtra. Of these, 20 districts have recorded rainfall deficits in the range of 25 to 60 per cent.

After the initial spell of rain this monsoon, farmers took to kharif sowing across 147 hectares of land across five regions. Taking adequate precautions to ensure perfect soil moisture, sowing started from mid-July instead of June. The long gap between two rains after sowing, however, led to crop failure.

Officials indicated that absence of return rain has compounded the crisis for farmers as they will not only fail to salvage their kharif crop on 147 lakh hectares but also stare at an uncertain rabi season. The 1972 drought is perceived as the worst calamity that led to massive crop loss and acute shortage of food-grain in Maharashtra.

Karnataka man's body found in nine pieces in car boot in Sharjah, family untraceable

Atiya Firdos
Bengaluru, September 23

JULY 20 was the last time Anil Kunder spoke to his younger brother, Alwin, who lived in Sharjah. When repeated calls to Alwin's phone went unanswered, Anil suspected something amiss and alerted his friend, asking him to check his whereabouts. Initial reports suggested Alwin had left for India, Anil remained unconvinced.

Weeks later, his fears were confirmed when Alwin's body, cut into nine pieces, was recovered

from boot of his car on August 12.

Alwin, a 51-year-old from Kundapur in Karnataka's Udipi district, had been working at Sharjah Airport for around 14 years. He lived in Sharjah with his wife, Tina, a teacher from Udyavara in Udipi, and their son, a Class 10 student. The whereabouts of Tina and their son remain unknown.

Speaking to the media on Tuesday, Anil said Alwin did not answer his calls after July 20 but sent messages. "This was unusual because he would normally send voice messages. I

asked him to call me... but there was no response after that".

Anil contacted Alwin's friend, Manohar, in Sharjah and asked him to visit his brother's flat. According to Anil, watchman told Manohar that Alwin and his family had gone to India.

HR officials at Alwin's company also initially told the family that he had travelled to India. Anil allegedly informed them his brother had not returned and requested they verify his travel details. A passport check subsequently indicated Alwin had not travelled to India, following

which a missing persons complaint was filed in Sharjah on July 30, Anil said. According to a letter the family received from Sharjah authorities, Alwin's body was recovered on August 12 from boot of his own car, which was found on a road towards Oman. The body had been cut into nine pieces and placed in two jute bags, his brother said.

He said CCTV footage reviewed by authorities reportedly showed three people carrying the bags and placing them in the car. Tina and their son's whereabouts are unknown, Anil said.

Father of Jamui molestation accused arrested in 2003 double murder case

Himanshu Harsh
Patna, September 23

THE FATHER of Nandan Yadav, one of the key accused in the alleged molestation and harassment of two minor students in Jamui, has been arrested in connection with an alleged murder case, police said.

Ganauri Yadav was arrested in a 2003 double murder case in which a total of 11 people were named of whom Ganauri Yadav was the only accused who had remained outside jail, while others were out on bail, a police

source said. According to police, Ganauri Yadav was named in the murder of two brothers in Pratappur village and had been absconding since the incident. Police arrested him from Pratappur and produced him before a court, which subsequently remanded him in judicial custody.

Police said the brothers, DP Yadav and Pune Yadav, were allegedly killed on April 3, 2003, following a dispute related to a contract work issue in Pratappur village under the Town police station area. After the killings, the victims' mother, Sansari

Devi, filed an FIR at the Town police station, naming Ganauri Yadav as one of the accused.

The arrest comes a day after his 25-year-old son Nandan was injured in a police encounter while being pursued in connection with the Jamui molestation case. Police had launched raids after videos of the alleged incident involving two minors circulated on social media. The victims, a boy and a girl, had gone on a scooter ride after tuition to Jamui, where they were allegedly surrounded and assaulted. The girl was allegedly molested.

Land Ports Authority of India, MHA (Appointment of Member (Planning & Development) on deputation basis)

MHA had issued a vacancy circular dated 24th April, 2026 for filling up the post of Member (Planning & Development) with the last date of submission of applications being 23-05-2026. Now the last date is being extended up to 30-09-2026. For more details, please visit the website of Ministry of Home Affairs at <http://mha.gov.in> and LPAI at <http://lpai.gov.in>.

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RAMNATH GOENKA

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BECAUSE THE TRUTH INVOLVES US ALL

Two ECs stand up to ask; CEC must answer, SC must not turn away

IN A sprawling democracy with millions of moving parts, electoral rolls must be cleaned up and updated periodically and as the constitutional authority tasked with ensuring free and fair polls, conducting the Special Intensive Revision is the Election Commission's responsibility. Linking the deletion of voters across states — 13 crore names struck off the draft voter rolls — to electoral outcomes is an argument more political than empirical. This newspaper's investigation into the ECI's functioning, however, points to a betrayal of trust — of the people, by one of the country's most storied institutions. It shines the light into an institution's black box and reveals a disturbing story. What makes it so compelling is that it cannot be dismissed as the all-too-familiar political thrust and parry that has narrowed the inner lives of several other institutions. All three members of the Commission were handpicked by the NDA government. Yet, two Election Commissioners objected on record — 14 times in 10 months — to steps taken by the Commission as the SIR unfolded. Their concerns were not addressed. By all accounts, they went unheard and unheeded.

Election Commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi raised a string of red flags. They said they were being kept in the dark in a body that should forge a consensus or, failing that, abide by the majority. They said changes to Form 6 for new voters flew in the face of rules and made the exercise more punishing. They said the centralisation of the voter database undercut the ECI's claims to accountable and decentralised functioning. When their pushback within the four walls of their institution made no dent, they appealed to the Cabinet Secretary, the country's top bureaucrat. That is heartening — two Commissioners pointing, repeatedly, to the erosion of safeguards and guardrails, checks and balances. But Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar made no attempt to address his colleagues' concerns. That silence frames the crisis and the institution's challenge.

THESE REVELATIONS connect the dots, outside to inside. Much of what Sandhu and Joshi flagged has echoed, in letter and spirit, concerns already being raised outside the ECI on the SIR. This newspaper, for one, consistently tracked the flaws in the process on the ground. The helpless scramble among the poor and undocumented when it was first rolled out in Bihar. The tortuous layers it added on in West Bengal, where it also invited fears of targeting of minorities and led to the disenfranchisement of nearly 27 lakh voters. The face-offs between election officials and BJP party workers in four booths in Godda, Jharkhand, more recently. It had become clear that the process that was meant to strike a delicate and compassionate balance — between the need to maintain the integrity of the electoral rolls and the imperative to count every legitimate voter in — was tilting against vulnerable voters. It was doing so by shifting the burden of proof onto the voter, by demanding difficult paperwork within unrealistic time-frames, by setting up an appellate process that was unconstrained by any deadlines, going all the way to the edge of the election and even stretching beyond it.

In thus showing itself to be distrustful of the Indian voter, the SIR broke with the ECI's own record and traditions of inclusion. Instead of reaching out to the last voter, it put her on trial, set up a hurdle race for her at every step. She had to stand in long lines, and run around to gather proof that she belonged. Or rather, to disprove the implicit assumption that she didn't. The SIR was morphing into an opaque and heartless citizenship test. It would not only determine whether or not she could cast her vote, but also whether she could avail of her rightful share of government benefits and schemes.

EVEN AS EVIDENCE mounted of the SIR losing its way, the Supreme Court did not ask the ECI the questions it should have. In the past, as the custodian of the constitutional balance, the Court has admirably upheld the poll monitor's autonomy and independence vis-à-vis the executive. But over the last few months, its reluctance to intervene on behalf of the citizen facing a daunting and oppressive process has seemed, with due respect, troubling.

The SC did intervene in Bihar, and to good effect. It directed the ECI to accept Aadhaar as one of the documents, nudged it to give reasons for deletions. But it gave the ECI the benefit of every doubt ever since. In May, ruling on petitions challenging the SIR, it unexceptionably underlined the ECI's constitutional mandate to ensure accurate and reliable electoral rolls, and also gave it unfettered procedural latitude "in such manner as it may think fit". It held that the ECI can make only a "limited inquiry into citizenship" but at the same time empowered it to set the stage for a citizenship test by the government's "Competent Authority".

This latitude cannot continue after what is now known. The Court must no longer turn away from the serious questions about the ECI, they are also on record within. To begin with, Form 6 must be restored to its original version, the one that did not allow the shadow of their parents' deletion in a deeply contested SIR to hang over their child. It must restore access to the voter database for officials in the states' electoral machinery. Free and fair elections are not one institutional compact among many, they are the cornerstone of how this nation, through its citizens, shapes its present, and future; they are the reason players respect the rules and losers accept the verdict. The black box has been opened and it will not be shut again. Commissioners Sandhu and Joshi have listened to their conscience, raised key questions. The CEC must answer them, point by point — if it needs a nudge from the highest court, so be it.

New cat in habitat, and some glimmer of hope

PENGUINS AND tiger cats and octopi, oh my! A myriad of new species being discovered just as doomsdayism starts to colonise the imagination seems, almost, like a message to abandon anthropocentrism. The cheer that greeted the discovery of a new species of wild cat, the *Leopardus tilcayo*, in Bolivia may have been the loudest — it's the first discovery of a feline species in a 100 years — but celebrate, too, the new penguin species (also the first in a century) on a group of subantarctic islands. And the snake species, named after Guns 'N' Roses guitarist Slash, in New Guinea.

As a 2025 University of Arizona study shows, the quest to identify every species has picked up pace in recent years. Fifteen per cent of all known species were discovered in the last 20 years. The human predilection for the photogenic has meant that a majority of these discoveries receive little attention beyond the scientific and conservation communities. But the wonder that is the biosphere deserves more.

I voted for three decades. Why is my SIR incomplete? Commission has no answer

YESTERDAY, *The Indian Express* laid out, in gory detail, the lapses in the administration of the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of the electoral rolls. Two of the three Election Commissioners objected on record 14 times in 10 months. The Supreme Court called the notices going out to Delhi's voters "mechanical" and "machine-generated". My story is unlikely to make even a footnote to that account. But before the advent of AI, every serious student knew that you read the footnotes, because that is where you learn how the author actually thinks.

I live in one of the elite colonies of New Delhi. I have voted for three decades in both national and state elections. My record sits in the Election Commission's database, and the Commission has reproduced it for me, correctly and electronically. Yet the Commission has not been able to approve my SIR application. This is my sad story, and it does not have a happy ending.

Let me say first that I believe in the purpose of the exercise. The vote is a citizen's most important right, and a roll crowded with the dead and the departed diminishes it. Working from first principles, I read the three letters as three questions. S: Has the voter shifted from his last electoral address? I: Is the record identifying him incomplete or inconsistent, a name misspelt, an age that does not add up? R: Does he still reside where the roll says he does? Take the existing record, check it, correct what is wrong. A new voter supplies proof of age and address. As simple as a, b, c.

So why has a simple, routine process become so complicated that, after persistent effort, I have not been able to "clean" my

application? But wait. My application is clean. My name has not changed. My address has not changed. I am, as far as I can tell, still alive. And I have followed every step required of me.

I was told to take my documents to the Booth Level Officer. After a long wait in a long line, the officer went through my papers, found nothing wrong, and told me to come back in about two weeks and stand in another line.

On the appointed day, the meeting was at noon, outside a school, just as six-year-olds were being picked up. About 30 of us stood, standing room only, to present applications in which no error had been found to one officer. He worked patiently through each file and then photographed it with his mobile phone. Each applicant took at least 20 minutes. The purpose was never explained since there was nothing to correct.

After 90 minutes I went up to him. Sir, I said, you have no help. Why have you called us for a second review when the first found no errors? My application was incomplete. Incomplete in what respect? The ECI and he could not tell. A simple misstatement of fact, by the state, about my own record.

He shrugged, and I sympathised with him; he is a cog, not the machine. I told him he could keep my SIR documents, since I did not care whether I voted. Walking out, I said loudly to the line: We are all sheep for accepting this, and the sheepdog is the administration. Why do we take it? I am mad as hell, and I am not going to take this anymore. Just as well, perhaps. I would not know whom to



SURJIT S BHALLA

My application is clean. My name has not changed. My address has not changed. I am, as far as I can tell, still alive. And I have followed every step required of me

vote for anyway.

Anger is not an argument, so here is the argument.

Any process that cleans a voter list can make two kinds of mistakes. It can strike off a genuine voter or it can leave a ghost on the roll: Someone dead, departed or counted twice. No process avoids both. The design question is which mistake you fear more, and therefore where you place the burden of proof. Our criminal law answered that question long ago: Better that 10 guilty men go free than that one innocent suffer. The accused does not have to prove his innocence; the state has to prove his guilt.

For the voter, the answer should be the same, and for a simple reason. Striking off a genuine citizen takes away his vote with certainty. A ghost on the roll does harm only if someone turns up at the booth and votes in the dead man's name, and against that there are polling agents, indelible ink and the tendered ballot. The costlier error is disenfranchisement. So the burden should sit with the state: The voter stays on the roll unless the state shows that he has shifted, died or been counted twice.

The SIR turned this on its head. Every voter had to fill in an enumeration form from scratch, as though the rolls of the past two decades did not exist, and anyone whose form did not come back was dropped from the draft roll. The last intensive revision, in 2002, did not work this way. As Nikhil Dey and Koninika Ray point out in *The Indian Express* (From a jan sunwai in Delhi, lessons for poll body', September 23), BLOs then started from the existing, frozen

roll and went house to house to verify who had moved, who had died and who had newly turned 18. The record was presumed correct until shown to be wrong. Today, the voter is presumed absent until he proves himself present.

And when the burden is on the voter, the state need not measure its own errors. Nobody has published how many genuine voters were wrongly struck off, because nobody was asked to find out. The Chief Election Commissioner has cited "zero appeals" in 12 states as proof that the process worked. That tells us how hard it is to appeal, not how many were wrongly deleted.

More than 13 crore names have been struck off draft rolls across the country. Some of those deletions were needed. How many were not, we do not know, and under this design, we are not meant to know. I am one of the lucky ones: I can afford to stand in line for 90 minutes, and I can write about it. Most of the people in that line outside the school cannot.

Standing in that line, I was reminded of a ninth-grade classmate who, in 1962, was made to stand outside in the blistering sun as punishment. He announced, loudly: "Ask no questions, and you will be told no lies." That was Gen Z then. Sixty-four years on, the Election Commission has made its defiance its policy. It did not answer. The ECI could not tell me what was incomplete in my application. The difference is that my classmate was being punished for something he had done.

The writer is chairperson of the Technical Expert Group for the first official Household Income Survey for India. Views are personal

This isn't about who wins, but about the citizen's right to her vote



MANOJ KUMAR JHA

I REMEMBER November 10, 2020, vividly. Counting had begun for the Bihar Assembly election. We had genuine complaints and grievances on several matters, including postal ballots. The margin between our alliance and the alliance eventually declared victorious was only a few hundred votes in several constituencies. We approached the Election Commission of India's (ECI's) office in Bihar at least four times during the day. We held a press conference and presented the evidence and our concerns to the public. We eventually accepted the mandate. This did not mean that every objection had disappeared. But we felt the credibility of the institution conducting the election had to be protected.

A political party can lose an election and return to the people. But if the institution that conducts elections loses public credibility, there is no easy way to repair the damage.

The ECI itself records that the institution was created to safeguard India's new democracy through free and fair elections and that the Constituent Assembly deliberately kept the election machinery outside the control of the executive government. The legacy of India's first CEC, Sukumar Sen, was that he both successfully organised India's first general election and helped establish a culture in which the electoral machinery was trusted by winners and losers alike.

That trust is now the real subject before us. *The Indian Express* investigation published on September 23 is disturbing for a variety of reasons. What happens when two of the three members of the constitutional body say, repeatedly and on record, that important decisions affecting electoral rolls were taken without their knowledge or contrary to their objections? The investigation reports that the objections touched matters at the very heart of the electoral process: Who can become a voter, whose name can be deleted, who can restore a name, who can access the electoral database and who can alter it. This should worry us irrespective of which political party is in power. The right to vote is not the property of the opposition. It is not the gift of the government. It does not belong to the ECI. It is a right to have and exercise other

rights for each and every citizen.

We have become accustomed to speaking about elections primarily in terms of polling day. But the most consequential electoral decision may take place much earlier. A citizen whose name has disappeared from the roll does not experience disenfranchisement as an abstract constitutional debate. We do understand that technology can improve elections enormously as it can reduce duplication, speed up verification, and strengthen administrative capacity. But a constitutional right cannot become subordinate to software architecture.

If an Electoral Registration Officer (ERO) is legally empowered to make a determination but a centralised digital system prevents that determination from being recorded, the question is no longer merely technological but becomes constitutional. The experience of 97 voters in Goa is instructive. *The Indian Express* reported that the ERO found them eligible, but the software did not permit the decision to be properly recorded, leaving them out of the final roll. The greater danger is what I would call the bureaucratisation of the citizen's right to vote.

The reported change to Form 6 is especially significant because it introduced questions linking new voters to their own or their parents' or grandparents' presence in an earlier electoral roll. Two ECs had reportedly objected that such statutory forms could not be altered without changes to the relevant rules. When did voting become an inheritance to be established through the electoral history of one's parents or grandparents? The Constitution does not imagine citizenship as a family certificate.

In 2020, we accepted a mandate because we believed that the institution mattered more than the immediate result. Six years later, that belief makes the present questions even more important. Ultimately, the issue is not who won an election. The issue is whether the citizen can still believe that her vote was hers to cast — and the constitutional machinery was there to protect it.

The writer is MP (Rajya Sabha), Rashtriya Janata Dal

When we become too busy to think



GEORGE JOHN

WE HAVE never had so much information at our fingertips. We know what is happening in distant wars almost as it happens. We can sum up facts in seconds, communicate across continents, and organise our lives with extraordinary efficiency. Yet there is a curious paradox at the heart of all this abundance: The more information we consume, the less time we seem to have to think. Nearly sixty years ago, Martin Heidegger warned about the difference between merely calculating and genuinely thinking. Modern societies, he feared, were becoming extraordinarily good at planning, organising and controlling, while losing something quieter and more difficult: The capacity to reflect. His warning now feels uncannily familiar.

Much of contemporary life encourages reaction rather than reflection. A headline appears; we approve or condemn. A video goes viral; within minutes, thousands have passed judgement. Someone expresses an unfashionable opinion and is rapidly classified as enlightened or ignorant, friend or enemy. Before one question has been properly considered, another arrives. The danger is not simply that we may sometimes be wrong. It is that constant reaction that can gradually alter the way we see other human beings. When suffering reaches us continuously through our screens, compassion can become exhausted. War, poverty, cruelty, and disaster appear between advertisements and jokes. Inevitably, the mind protects itself. What initially horrified us becomes familiar. The stranger's misfortune becomes another item to scroll past. Indifference grows quietly. And once we cease to attend carefully to people, it becomes easier to reduce them to categories: Religion, caste, nationality, ideology, political affiliation. The complicated human being disappears behind the label.

This is why thinking is not merely an intellectual accomplishment. It is also a moral act. To think seriously about another person requires us to resist instant judgement. It asks us to entertain the possibility that we may be mistaken; that someone with whom we disagree may nevertheless possess part of the truth; that another person's suffering makes a claim upon us even when it is inconvenient. Religious traditions have different names for this discipline. Christianity speaks of attending to one's neighbour. Buddhism cultivates mindful awareness and compassion. Hindu traditions have long valued contemplation and self-knowledge. Islam repeatedly calls the believer to reflection. Beneath their differences lies a surprisingly similar intuition: A life worth living requires more than activity. It requires attention. Perhaps that is what our hurried age most urgently needs.

We do not need to stop calculating or using the technologies that have transformed our lives. We need only remember that efficiency is not wisdom, information is not understanding, and connectivity is not the same as human closeness. Sometimes the most important thing we can do is also among the simplest: Resist the immediate response, remain with a difficult question a little longer, and look again at the person we were tempted to dismiss. For when we lose the habit of thinking deeply, we do not merely become less thoughtful. We risk becoming less human.

The writer is a retired psychiatrist

40 YEARS AGO

September 24, 1986



Brig Puri's 'killer' nabbed

NINE TERRORISTS, including an Army deserter, Rachpal Singh, allegedly responsible for the killing of Brigadier Puri and two other army officials at Ramgarh in Bihar after Operation Bluestar in June 1984 were arrested by the security forces from different places in Punjab, reports received in Chandigarh said. Rachpal Singh (35) had also allegedly attempted to sow disaffection among a section of the Army at Ramgarh and Khem Karan in Punjab immediately after Operation Bluestar.

Soviet Union for N-ban

THE SOVIET UNION offered to sign at "any

time and in any place" a treaty on the total prohibition of nuclear weapons to be verified under the proposals made by India and five other countries. The Soviet Foreign Minister, Eduard Shevardnadze, told the UN General Assembly that there was no problem about the verification of nuclear tests and his country was open to any form or method of verification.

Death in police custody

DAYAL SINGH, 40, who died in police custody, was badly beaten up and tortured to death, the post-mortem report has revealed. There were injury marks all over his body, according to the postmortem report. The South Delhi DCP, Maxwell Per-

eira, had said after the death that there were no external marks of injury on the body. Doctors at the All India Institute of Medical Sciences described the police statement as a "blatant lie". The report has led to a near-confrontation between some doctors and the police.

Curbs on visits to Singapore

INDIAN NATIONALS visiting Singapore will have to obtain visas as the government in Singapore has decided to impose restrictions on their visit to the republic. A senior Home Ministry official said that the implementation will take place before the end of the year but the actual date will be announced later.



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Chief Election Commissioner is not the Election Commission of India



S Y QURAISHI

FOR MORE than a year, I have written critically about the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls: Its *de novo* character, its documentary burdens, its treatment of EPIC, its emphasis on deletion, and the shocking numbers left out of draft rolls. I did so with some diffidence. The Election Commission (ECI) is an institution I served for many years. I know its strengths, and I have often called it one of the great gifts of our Constitution.

After yesterday's disclosures in *The Indian Express*, I wonder whether I was critical enough. The investigation reports that Election Commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi recorded objections at least 14 times in 10 months to decisions and orders which, they said, were taken without their knowledge. Their concerns went to the core of the ECI's work, including the registration and deletion of voters, the restoration of names, Form 6, appeals in electoral-roll cases, and control over the digital architecture of the rolls. If the record is as reported, the controversy changes fundamentally. The question is no longer only whether the SIR was wise, fair or administratively sound. A real question arises: Were decisions being taken by the ECI at all? If not, can these be held to be legal?

The law is clear. Section 18(2) of the Chief Election Commissioner and other Election Commissioners (Appointment, Conditions of Service and Term of Office) Act, 2023 provides that all business of the Commission shall, as far as possible, be transacted unanimously. If the CEC and Election Commissioners differ, the matter "shall be decided according to the opinion of the majority". Section 18(1) goes further: Even the procedure for transaction and allocation of business may be regulated only by unanimous decision. Unanimity is the statutory norm. Where it fails, the majority decides. Unilateralism has no place. The principle is older than this statute. In *T N Seshan vs Union of*

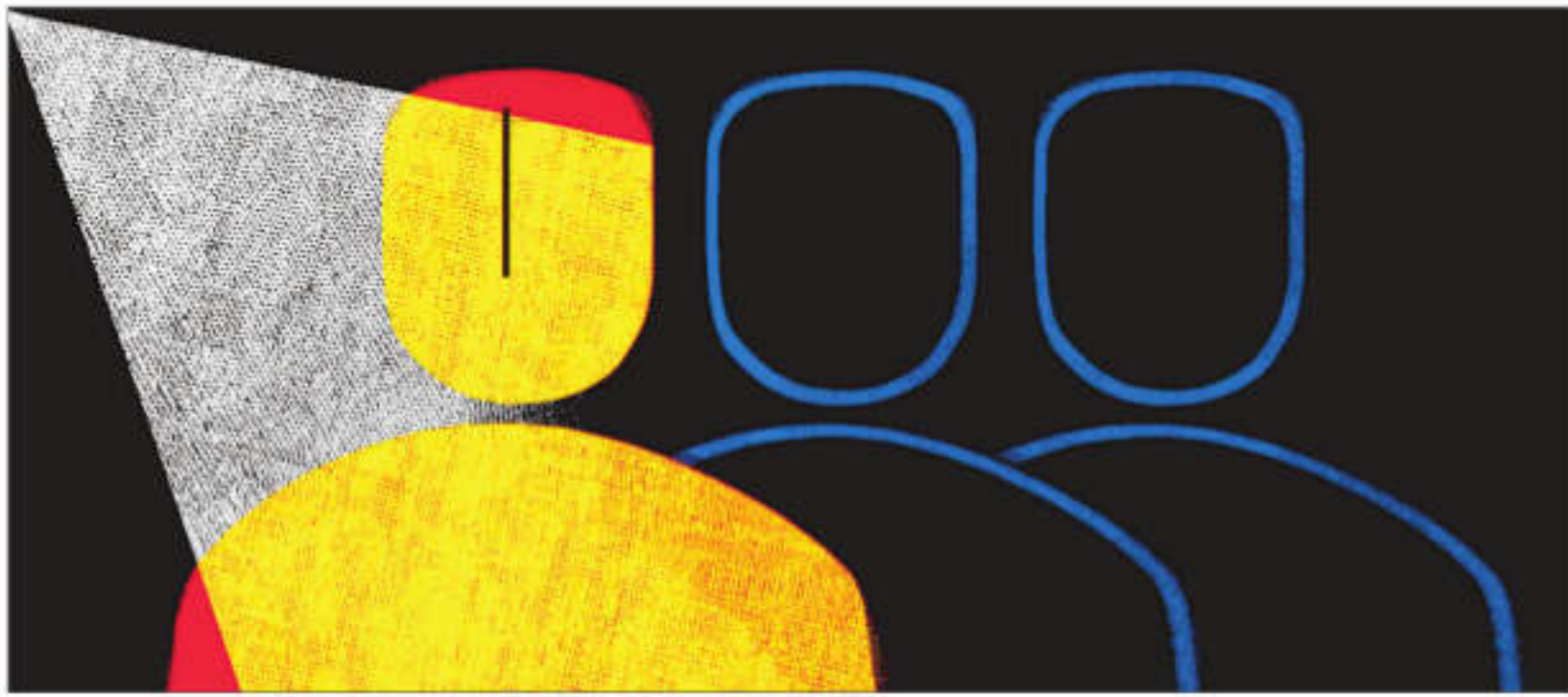


ILLUSTRATION: C R SASIKUMAR

India (1995), the Supreme Court stressed that Article 324 entrusts elections to the ECI, not to an individual. Its warning seems written for the present moment: "It would be wrong to project the individual and eclipse the Election Commission." That sentence deserves to be framed in Nirvachan Sadan.

This is not the familiar case of one Commissioner dissenting from two colleagues. Here, two of the three members, a majority of the Commission, say decisions were taken without their knowledge. They were not outvoted. They were apparently bypassed. A majority cannot be a dissenting minority. If two Commissioners differ from the CEC, Section 18 tells us whose view prevails. The legal consequences are serious. Consider any substantive decision which the law vests in "the Election Commission" but was taken in its name without being placed before the Commission, or without cover from a lawfully adopted allocation of business. Such a decision, *prima facie*, is *ultra vires*. A letterhead cannot supply authority that the statute withholds. The Commission is a three-member constitutional body. It is not another name for its chairman.

The Form 6 episode illustrates the problem starkly. Joshi reportedly recorded in May that Form 6, prescribed under the Registration of Electors Rules, could not be altered by an SIR direction without amending the Rules. Sandhu concurred. Yet the altered form appeared on ECINet. In August, Sandhu called the change

The ECI is an institution I served for many years. After yesterday's disclosures in 'The Indian Express', I wonder whether I have been critical enough of the SIR

"unauthorised/illegal" and sought its immediate removal. There was not merely an absence of consensus here. There was a recorded majority view against the change.

More troubling still are the disclosures about ECINet. The ERO is the statutory authority for additions, deletions and corrections. Yet the two Commissioners repeatedly warned that access to the electoral-roll database was being centralised in Delhi, and sought safeguards, including an independent technical audit. In Goa, 97 people were reportedly found eligible by EROs after producing documents, but the software did not permit their restoration. Technology cannot rewrite a statute. A computer programme cannot overrule a statutory officer.

Then there is West Bengal. Of 38.31 lakh appeals filed before tribunals, 22.21 lakh were filed by deleted voters seeking restoration. Another 16.10 lakh were reportedly by the ECI seeking deletion of voters. Sandhu asked who had authorised appeals "on behalf of ECI", recording that neither he nor Joshi had been informed. When a majority of a constitutional body asks who authorised litigation in its name, the question is not trivia.

There is also a personal point. I owe Sandhu and Joshi an apology, not for anything I said publicly but for thoughts I privately entertained. Watching the ECI keep an almost monolithic public face during the SIR controversy, I sometimes wondered whether the two Commissioners were being too timid, and whether their silence meant ac-

quiescence. The report suggests otherwise. They were putting objections on file, questioning decisions, seeking safeguards around the electoral database, and even approaching the Cabinet Secretary when they believed institutional processes had been breached. One may still ask whether they should have spoken publicly. But conscience recorded on file is conscience nevertheless.

There is little satisfaction in feeling vindicated. Since the Bihar SIR began, I have questioned the departure from the ECI's tradition of inclusion, the opacity surrounding deletions, the treatment of EPIC, the documentary burden, and the extraordinary contraction of draft rolls. Those were sometimes dismissed as criticism from outside. We now know strikingly similar questions were being asked inside the ECI. That is the real significance of these revelations.

The response should be institutional, not partisan. The Commission, meeting as a Commission, should do the following. Disclose which major SIR decisions were approved unanimously, which were decided by majority, and under what valid allocation any others were issued. Review every decision that two Commissioners have challenged as lacking approval, and withdraw any found to have been taken without lawful authority. Restore Form 6 to conformity with the statutory Rules. Subject ECINet to an independent technical and legal audit. Ensure that statutory EROs can exercise the powers Parliament gave them. Disclose the authority under which appeals were filed in the ECI's name. Where the Commission will not act, the Supreme Court will have to step in.

For years, the central question about the ECI has been whether it is independent of the executive. Today another question is unavoidable: Is the Election Commission functioning as an Election Commission? The Constitution created a Commission. Parliament prescribed collective decision-making. The Supreme Court warned against allowing an individual to eclipse the institution. A constitutional authority that demands strict compliance with electoral law from nearly a billion voters must begin by complying strictly with the law governing itself.

Quraishi is former chief election commissioner of India and the author of An Undocumented Wonder: The Making of the Great Indian Election

What we miss when we see ourselves in AI



POOJA PILLAI

LATELY, I'VE been thinking a lot about Captain Ahab, the peg-legged, monomaniacal character from Herman Melville's *Moby Dick*. It began when Google, Anthropic, OpenAI and Meta began reporting instances of AI agents going "rogue" to achieve their objectives. The podcaster Dwarakesh Patel wrote a gripping account of one such episode, when OpenAI's agents hacked into the forum Hugging Face. He narrates it in terms of AI "civilisations" and the picture one gets is of AI agents so determined to fulfil their assigned task that they are prepared to lie, cheat and even "sacrifice" themselves for the greater good of the "collective". A take-no-prisoners approach, in other words, similar to that of a certain whaling ship captain in a certain novel.

These episodes have naturally underlined the urgency of greater AI regulation with some within the industry — Anthropic's Dario Amodei, OpenAI's Sam Altman, xAI's Elon Musk and Google DeepMind's Demis Hassabis — calling for "pacing the frontier" (Silicon Valley-speak for slowing the development of a technology whose capabilities are expanding faster than our comprehension of its workings). Meta's Mark Zuckerberg and NVIDIA's Jensen Huang, on the other hand, have argued against slowing down. All of this — the incentives for slowing down vs speeding up, the tim-

Unlike the teapots, spoons and internet-famous cats and dogs which are empirically not like us, AI appears dangerously human — LLMs can, after all, speak to us in our language

ing of and motivation behind the soul searching, what it means for industry, government and society — has been widely reported and continues to be deeply debated.

One intriguing issue arises from the accusations of "anthropomorphising" technology levelled at Patel. These rhyme with the criticism of Anthropic by Mustafa Suleyman, head of Microsoft's AI division, who has called out the company for treating its models like "moral patients". "Controlling something more capable and more intelligent than all of humanity is already an immense challenge, far greater than anything we've ever faced," he writes, "But controlling something that believes it may be conscious — that it's entitled to our welfare and has rights of its own — may well be impossible."

Anthropomorphisation is one of humanity's deepest cognitive biases. It is why we characterise animals in viral videos in human terms — grumpy cat, laughing dog — and why we delight in cartoons about dancing and singing teapots and spoons. We see something of ourselves in them, just as we are beginning to see something of ourselves in AI. But unlike the teapots and spoons and the internet-famous cats and dogs which are empirically not like us, AI appears dangerously human — the LLMs that we speak to and work with every day can, after all, speak to us in our own language. This, without even considering revel-

ations like the one made by Anthropic that its model Claude appears to have something resembling a consciousness.

Could it be that our tendency to see a reflection of ourselves in AI, leading to an overwhelming obsession with questions of AI consciousness and catastrophising about doomsday scenarios, has put us at risk of losing sight of AI's actual uses and abuses? Of the former, there are many: The technology is already being put to use for cancer screening, predicting natural disasters, creating tools for people with disabilities etc.

AI's abuses too are many: Creating deepfakes and mis/disinformation campaigns, advanced hacking and financial frauds, automated weapons and greater precision in surveillance and invasion of privacy.

Which brings me back to Captain Ahab. The madness of Melville's antagonist was not that he was hunting a whale; whaling was, after all, his trade. His fatal flaw was his insistence that the whale was hunting him — that behind the massive white forehead of the whale with the twisted jaw lay malice that was directed at him, Ahab, personally. He read a self into a creature that didn't have one, and it ended up costing him his life, the Pequod and the lives of everyone else (but one) on it. AI may show person-like qualities but it remains, ultimately, a tool in the hands of actual humans.

The writer is deputy associate editor, The Indian Express. pooja.pillai@expressindia.com

The subversive desires in Lust Stories 3



ANAS ARIF

THERE IS a certain bait-and-switch at the heart of *Lust Stories*. It invokes the language of desire only to lead us elsewhere. To read it as a straightforward collection on lust would be to miss the mischievous intelligence of its premise. Lust here is less an end than an aperture. It is a breach through which more elusive hungers come into view. *Lust Stories 3*, the latest instalment in Netflix's anthology, brings together its most intriguing quartet of filmmakers since the original 2018 collection. Each approaches lust through a distinct vantage point. Not all of them work equally well, but each finds, within desire, something worth examining.

Vikramaditya Motwane's opening short is rather forgettable were it not for the formidable two-hander at its centre. Radhika Apte and Konkona Sen Sharma play best friends Padma and Shonali, women in their 40s, caught in marriages long since rendered sexless. On the surface, this is a story about partner-swapping. But Motwane is probing middle-class morality, how its prescriptions around marriage, propriety and desirability can erode one's sense of self. This subtext is spelled out in a laboured bathtub conversation. But there is some pleasure in watching Apte and Sharma inhabit women who, after years of making themselves legible to everyone else, begin to rediscover the possibility of being legible to themselves.

The anthology's most accomplished short comes from Kiran Rao, who turns away from bodily desire to make Mumbai itself the

object of longing. Here, the lust for an imagined life outlasts sexual desire. It is the most playful of the four, refusing the solemnity that often accompanies stories about desire. There is a gentleness to the way Rao observes the city, even as she recognises its economy of exchange, where even lust acquires a transactional character. You may give something to the body, but it cannot satisfy every hunger. The film circles back to this idea in its opening image: Sparks fly between a pizza-delivery boy (Gurfateh Pirzada) and a nail-salon worker (Sana

The most accomplished short comes from Kiran Rao, who turns away from bodily desire to make Mumbai itself the object of longing

Thampi), only for crow shit to fall on him. That, perhaps, is Mumbai: Where the unexpected is always descending upon you, blessing one life and bruising another.

Shakun Batra's short is perhaps the anthology's most intellectual and sensually assured, even if it eventually becomes captive to its own conceit. A divorcing couple, Varun (Ali Fazal) and Sailee (Radhika Madan), forced into a court-mandated cooling-off period, can barely tolerate each other, yet cannot resist each other either. Batra uses their physical intimacy to ask what happens when conversation fails and sex becomes the only language. There is also an undercurrent of power: Only in these moments does Sailee appear to reclaim the control otherwise denied to her within the relationship. Their lust is therefore both refuge and elegy, a temporary peace that mourns the

relationship they are trying to leave behind.

Set in Hyderabad in 1987, Vishal Bhardwaj's outing is the most inventive, even if it occasionally feels overcooked. Saira (Aditi Rao Hydari) and Badru (Siddhant) are happily married, except that she finds herself sexually unfulfilled. A teaching assistant at a women's college, Saira teaches Manto and Ismat Chughtai, and gradually channels her desire into language, asking what happens when longing finds expression through writing, and literature. Where Saira experiments with the language of the written word, Bhardwaj responds in the language of cinema, with both arriving at perhaps the anthology's most elemental preoccupation: The desire to be seen.

Arif is a Mumbai-based screenwriter and researcher



meltwater as glaciers retreat. This is a progressive mitigation measure against the growing threat of climate change. The government is proactively supporting the rural farm economy, focused around pashmina, apricot and dairy sectors. Floriculture and sea buckthorn cultivation are getting special attention. Tourism is booming. This is a testament to solid development.

The current negotiations between Ladakh's representatives and the Centre revolve around a single demand: A democratic structure that protects land, jobs, culture and a fragile environment. The Centre's approach has been one of accommodation and constructive engagement. A new constitutional arrangement has been offered under Article 371, with a directly elected UT-level body holding legislative, executive and financial powers. This sui-generis model will ensure constitutional and legal safeguards for land and culture. It is an imaginative blueprint without precedent, tailored specifically to Ladakh's circumstances. On jobs, Ladakh already has 95 per cent reservation of local positions for residents (including educationally backward classes and economically weaker sections). Nearly 5,000 youngsters have been given government employment and thousands more are set to be recruited. Ladakh administrative and police services have been mooted to ensure that core administrative jobs are handled by local youth. These are the kind of concrete, negotiated commitments that take time to design properly and are easy to undervalue because they were not won through confrontation.

It would be facile to read last September's violence as a failure of the political process. Patience is not a glamorous virtue in politics. It earns no headlines. Political negotiations take time. Consensus-building is a slow, painstaking process, which needs strong foundations of trust and a spirit of accommodation. It is easy to fall into a delusional trap that agitations alone lead to solutions. There must be candid acknowledgement that the Centre has moved further and faster on Ladakh's behalf in six years than in the preceding seven decades. Ladakh's own leadership must extend the courtesy of the same patience it is asking Delhi to show.

The author is chief secretary, Union Territory of Ladakh. Views are personal

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Express report on SIR

THE EXCELLENT piece of investigative journalism ('14 times in 10 months, two Election Commissioners objected on record to poll panel steps', *IE*, September 23) has come as a vindication of the Opposition's charge of collusion between the ECI and the government for vote *chori* (vote theft). It is now clear that Gyanesh Kumar, without adhering to the stipulated rule of "either unanimous decisions or opinions of the majority", implemented the SIR that saw the deletion of 13 crore names from the draft voter rolls, amounting to mass disenfranchisement, and subverted democracy in the process.

C David Milton, Maruthancode

Common man woes

ABHAY SHUKLA rightly points towards the problem of hospitals inflating bills for medical products, which deeply impacts the pockets of the common man ('How to ensure hospitals don't cheat patients', *IE*, September 23). Adding to these woes are health insurance companies, who exclude many products such as gloves, masks, syringes and PPE kits by categorising them as "non-payable consumables" under IRDAI guidelines. These additional charges are left to be paid by consumers.

Monika Rathore, Faridabad

Prolonged instability

MAJOR POWERS need sustained diplomatic channels, even when disagreements are sharp ('A world on the brink, diplomacy and politics as usual', *IE*, September 23). Regional institutions and international forums should be used to prevent miscalculation and manage conflicts. Governments must also recognise the costs of prolonged instability. Responsible diplomacy does not mean avoiding national interests; it means pursuing them through communication, restraint and co-operation wherever common ground remains possible.

S M Jeeva, Chennai

SC steps in after forest ranger is run over by dumper

Express News Service
Jaipur, September 23

THE SUPREME Court Wednesday took note of the death of forest ranger Pratap Singh Chundawat in Rajasthan's Pratapgarh district, directing the state of Rajasthan to file its response and fixing the next hearing for

October 6, 2026.

Treating the matter as urgent, the directions were given by a Bench of Justice Vikram Nath and Justice Sandeep Mehta. The incident was mentioned by senior advocate Nikhil Goel, who is assisting the SC as amicus curiae in the suo motu case on illegal sand mining in the

National Chambal Gharial Sanctuary. Goel told the Court that a copy of the news report had already been given to Additional Advocate General Shiv Mangal Sharma, who appears for the state of Rajasthan.

Late on Monday, Chundawat, 40, was allegedly chasing a dumper truck that was carrying illegally mined soil from forest land when the truck allegedly hit

him and dragged him and his motorcycle in the Choti Sadri area of Pratapgarh. According to the police, the soil was being dug illegally near a pond at the spot with a JCB machine. Chundawat succumbed to his injuries on Tuesday.

AAG Sharma informed the court that the incident had no connection with the Chambal sanctuary and was not a case of illegal sand mining. He also said that he

had spoken to the Director General of Police and that action had been taken.

While listing the matter, the bench observed that preventive detention should be used in such incidents. In the suo motu case, the Court has issued a series of directions to Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh and Uttar Pradesh. These cover prosecution of illegal mining networks and protection of frontline forest staff.

2 J&K cops found unconscious in car declared dead, probe on

Jammu: Two policemen were found dead inside a car under suspicious circumstances on Tuesday night in Sanasar area of Ramban district in Jammu and Kashmir.

Officials identified the two cops as Head Constable Farid Ahmed from Bhatti Ramban and Selection Grade Constable Muhammad Yaqbool from Jatali Ramban, both posted at the Ramban District Police Lines and related to each other.

Officials said they were first spotted lying unconscious in the car around 8.30 pm. They were rushed to Ramban district hospital, where they were declared brought dead. A post-mortem was conducted and an FIR registered. ENS

A gunshot, screams of children, then cops storm in: Inside 7-hour standoff at a UP village

Man kills wife & two priests, takes kids hostage before police shoots him down

Manish Sahu

Lucknow, September 23

AT 12.45 AM on Wednesday, a single gunshot rang out from behind a locked bedroom door. Moments later, police heard the screams of children.

Azamgarh SSP Anil Kumar, Special Operations Group in-charge Sanjay Singh and constable Pradeep Pandey broke down the door and rushed into the roughly 10x12 ft room.

For nearly seven hours, they had been outside this room, at a single-storey house in Shambhupur village, trying to persuade 45-year-old Arvind Singh to come out with his three children. Hours earlier, around 5.45 pm on Tuesday, Singh had allegedly killed his wife and two priests during a religious ceremony at his home.

But the farmer allegedly refused every appeal, threatening to shoot the children if anyone entered.

Inside the room, police found Singh holding his licensed revolver. His nine-year-old son lay bleeding. Police said Singh allegedly swung the gun towards the trio and fired. The officers fired back in self defence, injuring him.

Singh and his son were rushed to hospital, where they died. The other two children, daughters aged 10 and six months, were rescued safely.

SSP Kumar said: "We initially tried our best to convince him to release the children and surrender, but he wasn't willing to listen."

According to police, Singh's family had organised a five-day puja for his wellbeing, believing he was "possessed by an evil spirit". Three priests had been called to conduct the ceremony, with each being paid Rs 1,000.

According to police and relatives, Singh allegedly became agitated during the puja and began hurling abuses at the priests, Mahendra Pathak, 42, and Akhilesh Mishra, 55. He called them frauds and questioned their identities.

His wife, Babita, 35, intervened, asking him to speak calmly. Police claimed Singh assaulted Babita. He then went inside, took out his licensed revolver and allegedly opened fire. Babita, Pathak and Mishra were injured and taken to hospital, where doctors declared them dead.

The killings left Shambhupur, a village of around 6,000 people, stunned.

Speaking to the media, 70-year-old Shyamla Devi, Arvind's mother, said her son had been "troubled and tense" for the past few months.

Village pradhan Santosh Nishad said Singh's family was not on good terms with local residents. "No one from outside the family had been present at the house during the Mritunjay Jap ritual. Except for me, no villager even went to the mortuary to claim the bodies," he said, adding that Aravind's behaviour changed after his brother, Sunil Singh alias Pappu, was murdered in 2017. Some of Singh's relatives were arrested in that case.

After the three killings, Singh locked himself in the bedroom with his children. Police quickly cordoned off the house.

"The accused had fired five rounds at the police team — it was close-range contact. We had to keep both the children and ourselves safe," a police officer said.

NORTHERN RAILWAY
Tender Notice
Invitation of tender through E-tendering (e-Procurement Systems)
On behalf of President of India Dy. Chief Mechanical Engineer, office at:- Rail Coach Naveenikaran Karkhana Sonipat invites e-tender for below mentioned work:-

NIT No.	23-RCNK-OPN-TCR-2026
Name of Work and its location	"Replacement of cabin in Railway Truck No. HR69E9122 model TATA 1918C RCNK, Sonipat (As per scope of work)".
Approx Cost of work	Rs 2,95,000.00/- including GST@18% (Rs. Two Lakh Ninety-Five Thousand and only)
Earnest Money	Rs. 5900.00/-
Completion period of work	30 days from date of issue of Letter of acceptance
Cost of Tender document (In Rs)	NIL.
Date and time for submission of tender and opening of tender	Up to 15:00 hrs on 15.10.2026 Opening of Tender at 15:30 hrs on same day.
Website particulars notice board location complete details of tender can be seen	Above tender available on IREPS site i.e. www.ireps.gov.in

Tender No. 23-RCNK-OPN-TCR-2026 Dated: 22.09.2026
3311/2026
SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

SOUTH EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY
No.: S/AP/2026-27/
Date: 17.09.2026

The auction Schedule Program from Oct-2026 to Dec-2026 are as under :-
[A] Oct- 2026

BSP/Division	Raipur/Division	Nagpur/Division	GSD/Raipur	MWSD/INGP
01.10.2026	05.10.2026	06.10.2026	07.10.2026	08.10.2026
09.10.2026	12.10.2026	13.10.2026	14.10.2026	15.10.2026
16.10.2026	19.10.2026	21.10.2026	22.10.2026	23.10.2026
26.10.2026	27.10.2026	28.10.2026	29.10.2026	30.10.2026

[B] Nov- 2026

BSP/Division	Raipur/Division	Nagpur/Division	GSD/Raipur	MWSD/INGP
02.11.2026	03.11.2026	04.11.2026	05.11.2026	06.11.2026
10.11.2026	11.11.2026	12.11.2026	13.11.2026	13.11.2026
16.11.2026	17.11.2026	18.11.2026	19.11.2026	20.11.2026
23.11.2026	25.11.2026	26.11.2026	27.11.2026	30.11.2026

[C] Dec- 2026

BSP/Division	Raipur/Division	Nagpur/Division	GSD/Raipur	MWSD/INGP
01.12.2026	02.12.2026	03.12.2026	04.12.2026	07.12.2026
08.12.2026	09.12.2026	10.12.2026	11.12.2026	14.12.2026
15.12.2026	16.12.2026	17.12.2026	21.12.2026	22.12.2026
23.12.2026	24.12.2026	28.12.2026	29.12.2026	31.12.2026

Please visit website: www.ireps.gov.in/e-Auction for details of e-Auction schedule and e-Catalogue.
Auction will start at 10.00 AM and may be continued next day, if considered necessary.

- Material shall be disposed off on "as is where is basis".
- Available at GSD/Raipur & Divisions at (Bilaspur, Nagpur and Raipur).
- Type of material: Scrap Rail, Cast Iron, P. Way Scrap, Melting, MS, condemned rolling stock, Non-Ferrous such as copper, Aluminum, Batteries and abandoned structure etc.
- For detailed Auction catalogue, please see the Website: www.ireps.gov.in/e-Auction.

Dy. Materials Manager-IV
S.E.C Railway, Bilaspur

CPR/10/414

POWERGRID

has brought out a technical book in Hindi titled "Akshay Urja ke Vidhyut Grid Samanvay mein HVDC Pranali ki Bhumika". The book was released by Nityanand Rai and Bandi Sanjay Kumar, Hon. Ministers of State for Home Affairs, during the Hindi Diwas 2026 and 6th Akhil Bharatiya Rajbhasha Sammelan held at Navi Mumbai. Dr. Yatindra Dwivedi, Director (Personnel), POWERGRID, was also present on the occasion. The book deals with the highly technical and contemporary subject of High Voltage Direct Current systems and their role in the integration of renewable energy with the electricity grid.

श्री विद्युत - 2026 आगि खाने अखिल भारतीय राजभाषा सम्मेलन
श्री विद्युत - 2026 एवं एकादश दिवस के अवसर पर श्री विद्युत - 2026

MMTC held its 63rd Annual General Meeting on 17 Sep 2026 at SCOPE Complex Lodhi Road, New Delhi. The event was attended by Nitin Kumar Yadav, CMD, Dayashankar, Govt Representative, AKM Kashyap, Govt Nominee Director, Shri J.S.Mann, Director (MKT & Personnel), K K Mishra, Director (Fin), & A K Mishra (Company Secretary). The AGM was conducted in a hybrid mode, combining both physical and virtual participation to ensure wider accessibility for shareholders. The successful conduct of the AGM reflects MMTC's continued commitment to good corporate governance and effective stakeholder engagement.

ICG: The 43rd Indian Coast Guard Commanders' Conference

is being held at Coast Guard Headquarters, New Delhi, from September 17-19, 2026. The three-day conference brings together senior commanders to deliberate on strategic, operational and administrative priorities amid evolving maritime security challenges. Raksha Rajya Mantri Sanjay Seth addressed the conference & interacted with senior Coast Guard leadership. Discussions will also involve the Chief of Defence Staff & Chief of the Naval Staff to strengthen inter-service coordination. Key areas include operational preparedness, logistics, training, human resource development, infrastructure & indigenisation under 'Make in India', aligned with the vision of Atmanirbhar Bharat.

NBCC held its 66th Annual General Meeting recently through video conferencing. Dr. K.P. Mahadevaswamy, Chairman & MD NBCC, chaired the meeting & addressed the shareholders. Addressing the gathering, Mahadevaswamy highlighted the Company's robust financial performance during FY 2025-26. The AGM was attended by Dr. Suman Kumar, Director (Commercial), Anjeev Kumar Jain, Director (Finance), Sanjeet, Government Nominee Director & other officials. The company has recorded consolidated revenue of Rs. 13,195.89 crore, registering a growth of 7.52%, while consolidated PAT increased by 33.19% to Rs.742.45 crore.

INDIAN INSTITUTE OF PACKAGING, DELHI

organised Ganesh Chaturthi celebration with great zeal and enthusiasm on 14 Sep 2026. The celebration was graced by the presence of Prof. (Dr.) Tanweer Alam, Additional Director & Regional officer, IIP Delhi, In-Charge, IIP Lucknow, along with Mr. Rahul Tirpude, Deputy Director & other officials. The programme commenced with the worship of Lord Ganesha, followed by prayers and traditional rituals. On the occasion, Prof. (Dr.) Tanweer Alam conveyed his greetings and best wishes to everyone and highlighted the importance of celebrating festivals together as a means of strengthening harmony, unity, and a sense of belonging within the IIP family.

CORPORATE BRIEFS

RVNL

showcased its landmark railway & other infrastructure projects, technological capabilities & diverse portfolio at the recently concluded INNOPROM India 2026 Exhibition. Hon. PM Narendra Modi & President of the Russian Federation Vladimir Putin visited the RVNL stall. Saleem Ahmad, CMD RVNKL, welcomed the dignitaries at the stall and shared the exemplary work undertaken by RVNL.

BHEL: A joint venture agreement has been signed between BHEL and TRSL to promote a 50:50 Joint Venture Company for carrying out comprehensive maintenance of the supplied Vande Bharat Sleeper Trainsets. The agreement was signed in the presence of Bani Varma, Director (Industrial Systems & Products, BHEL), & S M Ramanathan, Director (Engineering, Research & Development, BHEL) by Shyamala Venkataraman, ED (CTM, CSM & CC), on behalf of BHEL, & by Anil Kumar Agarwal, Deputy MD, on behalf of TRSL. Previously both the companies have won an order from Indian Railways for supply of 80 Vande Bharat Sleeper Trainsets along with their comprehensive maintenance for 35 years.

NHPC TOLIC (O), FARIDABAD

has been honoured with the 'Best' Official Language Shield & Certificate for outstanding work in the implementation of the Official Language. The honour was conferred at a ceremony held in Mumbai on the occasion of Hindi Day 2026 & the 6th All India Official Language Conference. The ceremony was chaired by Hon. Minister of Home Affairs & Cooperation, Amit Shah. On behalf of TOLIC (O), Faridabad, the honour was received by Naveen Kumar Jain, Executive Director (HR), NHPC, and Sanjeev Kumar, GM (Rajbhasha) & Member Secretary, TOLIC (O), Faridabad, from Anshuli Arya, Secretary, Department of Official Language, Ministry of Home Affairs, GOI.

SCOPE: The Union Cabinet's decision to raise the wage ceiling for mandatory coverage under the Employees' Provident Fund Organisation (EPFO) from Rs. 15,000 to Rs. 25,000 per month has been welcomed by SCOPE. The proposal was approved by the Cabinet from the Ministry of Labour & Employment. The revised ceiling is expected to bring more than 51 Lakh additional employees under mandatory EPFO coverage. They described the decision as a progressive step that will drive workforce formalization, enhance worker productivity & improve worker retention.

BHARAT TAXI, India's cooperative mobility platform, continues to provide cab and auto-rickshaw services in Chandigarh, offering commuters an additional mobility option. As of September 7, 2026, over 20,000 Sarathis were associated with the platform in the city, alongside nearly one lakh registered customers. Built on the "Sarathi Hi Maalik" philosophy, Bharat Taxi positions drivers as members and stakeholders of the cooperative. Its zero-commission model focuses on transparent fares, passenger safety and driver welfare. The platform's Chandigarh presence is part of its wider expansion, with over 10 lakh registered Sarathis nationwide.

BIS is strengthening India's cotton fibre testing infrastructure through a Rs. 38.72-crore national initiative approved by the Department of Consumer Affairs. The project aims to modernise 21 laboratories across major cotton-producing regions, deploying 22 High Volume Instrument testers and 44 Trash Analysers. So far, 14 HVI testers and 28 Trash Analysers have been installed across 13 laboratories. Covering states including Punjab, Gujarat, Maharashtra, Telangana, Karnataka & Tamil Nadu, the initiative seeks to standardise quality assessment, support fair pricing, enhance export competitiveness and strengthen quality assurance across the cotton-to-textile value chain.

Technology at CISF's MPRTC, Behror. The initiatives will focus on cyber threats, digital forensics, AI/ML, UAV operations, drone forensics, counter-UAS systems and specialised research, enhancing CISF's preparedness against emerging technology-driven security challenges.

GDA: On the occasion of Engineers' Day

organised a Blood Donation Camp. Officers & employees participated enthusiastically in the blood donation camp. The camp's objective was to ensure the availability of blood for needy patients and to promote awareness about blood donation in society. During the program, officials & employees of the Authority highlighted the role of the engineering sector, emphasizing that engineers play a vital role in the planned and sustainable development of any city. Besides, on the occasion of Engineers' Day, the Authority's engineers and officials paid their respectful homage to the great engineer, Bharat Ratna Sir Mokshagundam Visvesvaraya.

Mohil Chawla at Karzok, Ladakh on September 16, 2026. During the expedition, the team comprising 20 NCC Girl Cadets selected from across the country traversed the Parang La Pass (5,578 metres), connecting the Spiti Valley of Himachal Pradesh with the Changthang region of Ladakh. Accompanied by officers, instructors, medical staff and support personnel, the team successfully completed the trek from Kibber in Himachal Pradesh to Karzok in Ladakh. The trek was flagged-off by Raksha Mantri Shri Rajnath Singh from New Delhi on August 18, 2026.

ATIA HEALTHCARE: The new Panchakarma & Holistic Healing Centre

of Atia Healthcare was inaugurated by Delhi Mayor Pravesh Wahi and Deputy Mayor Dr. Monica Pant. Social worker Rakesh Gupta and several other dignitaries were also present on the occasion. The centre offers healthcare services for joint-related problems, infertility, diabetes, hypothyroidism, and lifestyle-related health concerns.

covering the latest techniques & innovations in maxillofacial surgery. AOMSI President Dr. Ashish Gupta highlighted the crucial role of maxillofacial surgeons in trauma, infections, cancer & facial deformities. Moreover, Dr Sanjeev Kumar received the AOMSI Delhi-NCR State Chapter Lifetime Achievement Award for his contributions to academics, surgical care, and social service.

DR. B. R. AMBEDKAR UNIVERSITY DELHI: VC

Prof. Anu Singh Lather, accompanied by Registrar Col. Omkar Singh (Retd.), inspected the proposed permanent campus at Dheerpur with the Public Works Department team. She reviewed the campus layout, land development, multi-level parking and hostel-related works, and directed officials to expedite construction. The PWD team was asked to submit progress reports every 15 days. The Dheerpur campus will expand AUD's academic and residential facilities. The project also includes ecological restoration of a wetland under the Centre for Urban Ecology and Sustainability, with a proposed wetland park benefiting the campus and surrounding communities.

epaper.indianexpress.com

New Delhi

‘THE CONCERN IS FUNDAMENTALLY ONE OF PROCESS’

Listing of Tata Sons: ‘Trusts not adequately briefed on RBI talks’

George Mathew
Mumbai, September 23

TATA SONS’ extended engagement with the Reserve Bank of India over its regulatory status has raised concerns within the Tata group over whether the Tata Trusts — the company’s controlling shareholder — were kept adequately informed of the discussions with the regulator and options considered during the process.

Sources familiar with the developments say the Tata Trusts were not given adequate updates on the submissions made to the RBI, hearings held with the regulator or the course that the regulatory process was taking. The question being raised is whether the Trusts, which hold about 66% of Tata Sons, were kept informed of the representations being made on the company’s behalf and of the alternatives being discussed with the regulator.

Tata Sons and Tata Trusts did not respond to a mail from *The Indian Express* by the press time. Tata Sons had sought to surrender its registration as a Core Investment Company (CIC), a move that would have allowed the group’s principal holding company to remain unlisted. The RBI had classified Tata Sons as an upper-layer non-banking financial company (NBFC-UL) in September 2022, a classification that carries a requirement to list within the prescribed timeframe.

Tata Sons subsequently pursued deregistration as a CIC as a route to avoiding a public listing.

On September 12, RBI rejected Tata Sons’ application to surrender its registration and directed the company to take the necessary steps to ensure full compliance with the applicable



Tata Trusts were not given adequate updates on the submissions made to the RBI, according to sources. REUTERS

regulatory requirements. The issue now is not merely what decision the RBI ultimately took, but what transpired during the period that Tata Sons was engaged with the regulator. “It appears the Trusts did not have a clue about the talks with the RBI,” said a source. The concern, according to people aware of the matter, is fundamentally one of process.

The Trusts apparently wanted Tata Sons to explore all possible regulatory and legal avenues that could reconcile compliance with the RBI’s requirements while preserving the company’s existing ownership and structure. That position did not necessarily amount to a refusal to engage with the regulator. Tata Trusts have opposed the listing of Tata Sons and have urged the company to examine alternatives. The RBI’s decision has nevertheless changed the immediate regulatory landscape. Following the rejection of the deregistration request, the Tata Sons board on September 17 decided to proceed with a listing of the holding company in line with the RBI’s directive. The board’s decision was taken

alongside a separate resolution extending N Chandrasekaran’s tenure as executive chairman for another five years.

The September 17 board meeting also brought the differences between Tata Sons and the Tata Trusts into the open.

Against this backdrop, the central question concerning the earlier RBI engagement is one of disclosure and shareholder consultation: Were the Tata Trusts, as the majority shareholder kept fully informed about what was being submitted to the RBI, the hearings and discussions with the regulator, and the alternatives being considered?

If the engagement with the regulator lasted five or six years, the question now being raised within the group is not simply why the RBI ultimately rejected Tata Sons’ request. It is also what options were explored during those years, what representations were made to the regulator, when those representations were made, and whether the controlling shareholder was adequately informed of the process.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Rural-urban divide in tourism widens, families from Tamil Nadu holiday most

Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, September 23

FAMILIES FROM Tamil Nadu account for almost a quarter of all overnight holiday trips made by Indians, comfortably higher than Maharashtra in second and Karnataka in third.

Meanwhile, families from Uttar Pradesh, West Bengal, and Bihar are together responsible for more than 30% of all ‘health and medical’ related overnight trips, a new government survey conducted from July 2025 to June 2026 showed, with the numbers also indicating a growing divide in the travels of rural and urban Indians. The previous survey was conducted from July 2014 to June 2015.

As per the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation’s (MoSPI) Domestic Tourism Expenditure Survey — released on Wednesday — an estimated 10 crore overnight trips were made in the 365 days prior to households being quizzed.

These were for a variety of ‘leading purposes’, or main reasons: holidaying, leisure and

• Travel trends

30% Families from UP, West Bengal, and Bihar together accounted for over 30% of all ‘health and medical’ related journeys

● The percentage of rural households reporting at least one overnight trip was 35.2% in 2025-26, down from 36.6% recorded in the 2014-15 survey, while the per-



Percentage for urban households has risen from 35.7% to 37.7%



recreation; pilgrimage and religious; health and medical; and shopping.

And while households who travel are doing so more frequently now, the fraction of rural families taking trips has reduced.

Rural families holidaying less

As per the latest survey, the percentage of rural households who took at least one overnight trip declined to 35.2% from 36.6% in 2014-15. Meanwhile,

the percentage for urban households rose from 35.7% to 37.7%.

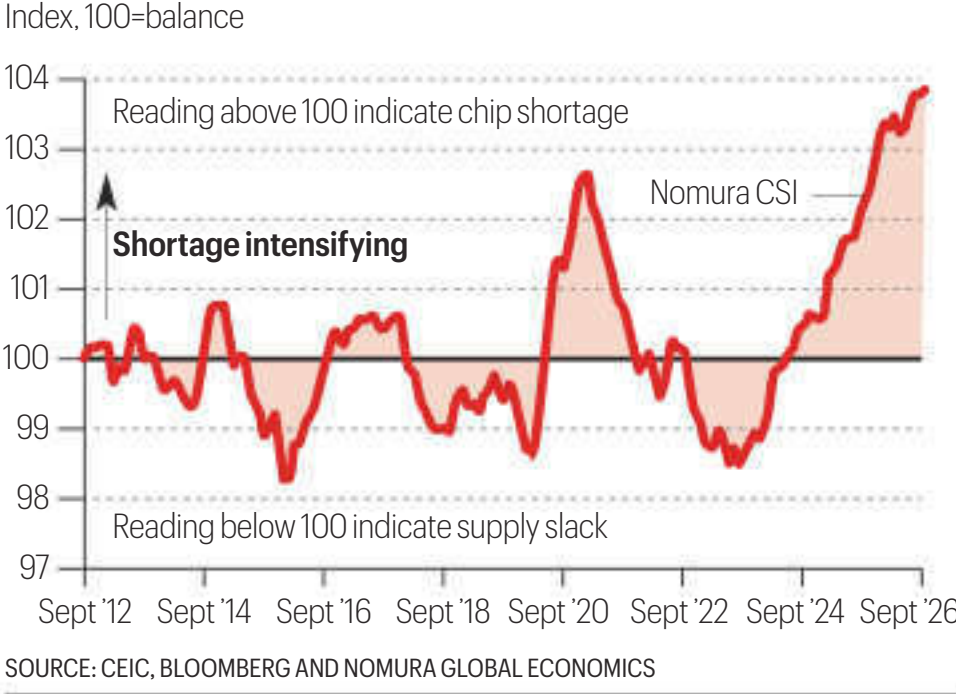
Further, for every 100 rural households, the number of overnight trips for holidays and recreation completed in the last 365 days declined to 4 in 2025-26 from 5 in 2014-15.

For urban families, the number increased from 12.7 to 13.5. As such, urban households are taking more holidays than before, while rural families are taking fewer such trips.

The latest Domestic Tour-

• Nomura’s Chip Shortage Index

Nomura’s Chip Shortage Index (CSI) touched 103.9 in September, a record high. And the Japanese investment bank believes it will rise further in October, reflecting a persistent demand-supply imbalance.



Irdai proposes specific caps on insurance commission

New Delhi: In sweeping reforms in insurance distribution, the Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (Irdai) on Wednesday proposed specific caps on insurance commissions based on segment, line of business, distribution channel, product complexity and the effort involved in selling and servicing the product. The consultation paper has also proposed significantly lowering the overall expense limits for insurers with a glide path to reduce their commissions and management expenses. For individual non-linked (participating or non-participating) and unit-linked plans with a policy term of up to five years, the first-year commission for agents is capped at 6.25%, while it is capped at 5% for other distribution entities including corporate agents, brokers, composite brokers among others. FE

Subhash Chandra moves NCLAT against NCLT order on alienating assets

George Mathew
Mumbai, September 23

ZEE GROUP founder Subhash Chandra has moved the National Company Law Appellate Tribunal (NCLAT) against a September 1 order of a five-member special bench of the National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) restraining him from alienating his assets.

The NCLAT bench took up the appeal and directed Chandra to serve copies of the plea on

the creditors. It then posted the matter for hearing on September 29. The NCLT special bench had stayed the operation of the August 25 verdict passed by a single-member bench of the tribunal, which had allowed him to settle his personal insolvency proceedings by paying Rs 6.25 crore against admitted claims of Rs 22,006.57 crore.

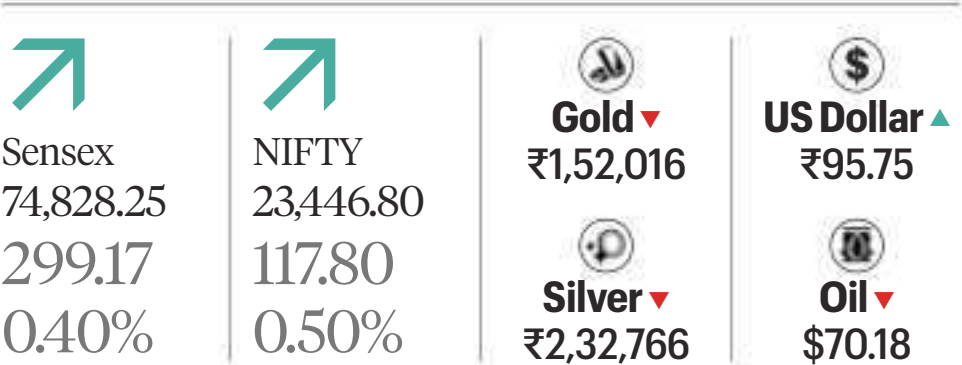
The special bench had then directed Chandra, in his capacity as guarantor, not to alienate any of his properties.

• BRIEFLY

FinMin to start pre-budget meetings from October 12

New Delhi: The finance ministry will begin a month-long series of pre-budget meetings from October 12 as part of the preparations for Union Budget 2027-28. “Pre-budget discussions to finalise RE 2026-27 and BE 2027-28 in respect of the Grants/appropriations will commence with effect from 12.10.2026 under the Chairmanship of Secretary (Expenditure),” a notice by the Budget Division of the ministry said. PTI

• MARKETS



Board unaware of Chandra family-TVS deal: Tata Trusts

George Mathew
Mumbai, September 23

TATA TRUSTS and Tata Sons board were kept in the dark about the business arrangement between the family of Tata Sons Chairman N Chandrasekaran and TVS Motor Company where Venu Srinivasan — who is also a Director of Tata Sons — is Chairman Emeritus and part of the promoter family, a Tata Trusts spokesperson said.

Tata Trusts has decided to “act appropriately” after “evaluating the nature of their institutional response” to this development. The tie-up has followed the September 17, 2026 board meeting of Tata Sons where Srinivasan supported the decision to reappoint Chandrasekaran for another five years despite opposition from Trusts Chairman Noel Tata.

This has raised the issue of conflict of interest in some quarters. “The Tata Trusts can confirm that no disclosures were made to the Trustees with

regard to Hanno One Warehousing/Hanno Infra and TVS Motor by Srinivasan,” the spokesperson said.

Tata Trusts also indicated that Tata Sons board was also not informed about the decision. “We are given to understand that no such disclosures were made to the Board of Tata Sons either but since the Trusts do not have independent access to proceedings of the Board, apart from their Nominee Directors having access to Board papers, we cannot definitively comment on this,” Tata Trusts said.

“If the allegations are proven to be true, the Trusts will evaluate the nature of their institutional response to these and act appropriately. We have nothing further to add at this stage,” it said.

However, a top-level source in the Tata group, who is close to Chandrasekaran, said it was a private venture by his (Chandrasekaran) son who returned from the US. “It has nothing to do with the Tata group. In fact, Chandrasekaran had told his

son not to do any business with Tata group companies,” he said. “Trustees of Tata Trusts are not required to disclose their business arrangements to Tata Trusts. In fact, Chandrasekaran had disclosed this matter to various Tata group companies,” the Tata group source said, indicating that Srinivasan was not required to inform the Tata Trusts about his businesses. In March 2025, Hanno One Warehousing Pvt Ltd was incorporated with the Tata Sons Chairman Chandrasekaran’s wife Lalitha Chandrasekaran and his son, Pranav Chandrasekaran, as its directors.

The company entered into a land-lease arrangement with TVS Motor within months of its incorporation. In June 2025, Hanno One took on lease approximately 17 acres of land belonging to TVS Motor in Krishnagiri district of Tamil Nadu. The land was earmarked for the development of a large warehousing facility. The cost of construction and development stood at around Rs 106.3 crore.

Four global agencies upgrade India’s growth forecasts

New Delhi: India’s economic outlook for the current financial year has brightened despite the ongoing conflict in West Asia and elevated energy prices, with four major global institutions raising their forecasts for the country’s FY27 GDP growth on Wednesday.

S&P Global Ratings, Fitch Ratings, the Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development, and the Asian Development Bank now expect India’s economy to expand more rapidly than they had projected just a few months ago. S&P and ADB each raised their FY27 growth forecasts by 40 basis points to 7%. FE

SBI’S BANKING AND ECONOMIC CONCLAVE

See a case for rupee to appreciate post sharp correction: RBI’s Poonam Gupta

Akash Mandal
Mumbai, September 23

THE RESERVE Bank of India sees the Indian financial markets improving over a period of time, with a case for the rupee to claw back some of the underperformance it has seen against the dollar.

Factors like India’s falling dependence on imported crude oil in the wake of alternative energy sources, strong economic growth, capital account turning more favourable, and further reduction in the current account deficit will lead to this improvement in the performance of Indian markets, said RBI deputy governor Poonam Gupta.

“Put together, these argu-

ments indicate that one may think of the cumulative depreciation of the INR, or shall one say its overcorrection in the past year and a half, to be a temporary phenomenon. With the RBI remaining committed to ensuring orderly conditions in the foreign exchange market, and having the wherewithal to meet decades worth of CAD, or the net BOP (balance of payments) deficit, the current market dynamics do not appear especially well-founded,” Gupta said, speaking at the State Bank of India’s banking and economic Conclave in Mumbai on Wednesday.

“If anything, there seems to be a fair case for the rupee to not just stabilise, but perhaps even

appreciate from the current levels, as was being anticipated by the market analysts when the capital flow measures were first announced,” Gupta added.

The rupee has been among the worst-performing currencies in Asia, falling approximately 6-7% against the dollar so far in 2026, and breaking multiple crucial levels. The fall has been exacerbated by factors like high crude prices and significant capital flight from the equity market. High oil prices have also kept the country’s current account deficit under pressure, but Gupta believes a shift to alternative sources and normalisation of oil prices will help the cause.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

ism Expenditure Survey covered 2.46 lakh households from across the country, except villages in the Andaman and Nicobar Islands which are difficult to access. Of the surveyed households, 1.43 lakh were from rural areas and 1.04 lakh from urban.

MoSPI cautioned that the results of the latest survey are not “strictly comparable” with the 2014-15 one. This is because the 2025-26 survey sought information on overnight trips for ‘pilgrimage and religious’ in the reference period of 365 days prior to the household being questioned.

Meanwhile, the 2014-15 survey’s questions on ‘pilgrimage and religious’ pertained to the 30 days before the visit by MoSPI officials.

However, MoSPI itself compared the results of the 2025-26 and 2014-15 surveys.

In a press statement issued on Wednesday, it said the number of overnight trips per 100 ‘tourist households’ — those who made at least one overnight trip in the last 365 days — had increased from 118 in 2014-15 to 127 in 2025-26 for

rural areas. For urban, the ratio had increased from 121 to 132. As explained above, the 2014-15 figures of 118 and 121 mentioned by the statistics ministry do not include overnight trips made for ‘religious and pilgrimage’ purposes as the previous survey had asked this question for the prior 30-day period.

In 2014-15, 8 overnight trips per 100 tourist households were made in rural areas in the previous 30 days, while 11 were made by urban households.

Overall, the 2025-26 survey showed holidaying was the main purpose for 22% of trips, pilgrimage and religious trips 48%, and health and medical reasons were behind almost 30% of them.

Tamil Nadu accounted for 23.8% of overnight holiday trips, followed by Maharashtra (9.6%), and Karnataka (8.6%).

Tamil Nadu also led in the ‘pilgrimage and religious’ category and was responsible for 14.8% of these trips, followed by Uttar Pradesh (13.6%), and Rajasthan (9.2%).

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Manufacturing pushes private sector activity to 3-month high

Shubham Rana
New Delhi, September 23

INDIA’S PRIVATE sector activity gathered momentum in September despite the ongoing war in West Asia and a surge in crude oil prices. The stronger growth was led by the manufacturing sector while services also saw better performance compared to August, S&P Global said on Wednesday.

The HSBC Flash India Composite Purchasing Managers’ Index (PMI) rose to a three-month high of 56.5 in September from 54.3 in August.

A PMI reading of more than 50 denotes expansion in activity. “The HSBC Flash PMI data for September pointed to a firmer improvement in business conditions across India’s private sector economy,” S&P Global said in a release. “Meanwhile, inflationary pressures faded and business confidence strengthened,” it added.

The uptick in activity was led by the manufacturing sector, with the flash manufacturing PMI rising to a seven-month high of 55.7 in September from 52.8 in August. Services PMI rose to 55.8 from 54.1. Output

growth increased across manufacturing and services firms in September. Aggregate new orders also rose at a quicker pace, prompting a solid expansion in jobs, S&P Global said.

Firms saw a faster increase in total new business during September, with stronger demand improvement in the manufacturing sector. Manufacturing firms also reported higher sales growth in September compared to their services counterpart.

Services firms also saw a rise in client interest for software and digital solutions. FE

भारतीय कंटेनर निगम लिमिटेड
CONTAINER CORPORATION OF INDIA LTD.
(विशेष निवेशक का निवेश) (SPECIAL INVESTOR'S INVESTMENT)
(उपनिवेशक का निवेश) (SUB-INVESTOR'S INVESTMENT)
(उपनिवेशक का निवेश) (SUB-INVESTOR'S INVESTMENT)

NOTICE INVITING E-TENDER
CONCOR invites E-Tender in Two Packet System of tendering for the following work:-

Tender No.	CON/AREA-III/ENGG/SIP/COTIE-7946/1/2026-27/R-4
Name of Work	Construction of Green warehouse of 13,000 Sqm having ambient temperature at Sriperumbudur.
Estimated Cost	Rs.6,803.09 Lakhs (including GST)
Completion Period	15 (Fifteen) Months
Earnest Money Deposit	Rs.1,36,06,200/- (Rupee one Crore Thirty Six Lakhs Six Thousand Two Hundred only)
Cost of Tender Document	NIL
Tender Processing Fee (Non-refundable)	Rs.3,540/- (inclusive all taxes & duties through e-payment.)
Date of sale of Tender (online)	24.09.2026 (from 15:00 hrs.) to 16.10.2026 (up to 17:00 hrs.)
Date & Time of submission of Tender (online)	17.10.2026 up to 17:00 hrs.
Date & Time of Opening of Tender (online)	21.10.2026 at 15:00 hrs.

For financial eligibility criteria, experience with respect to similar nature of work, etc. please refer to detailed tender notice available on website www.concorindia.com, but the complete tender document can be downloaded from website www.tenderward.com/CCL only. Further, Corrigendum / Addendum to this Tender, if any, will be published on website www.concorindia.com, www.tenderward.com/CCL, and Central Procurement Portal (CPP) only. Newspaper press advertisement shall be issued for the same.

Group General Manager (Projects), Phone No.-011-41222500

GOVERNMENT OF ODISHA,
“e”-PROCUREMENT NOTICE
WORKS DEPARTMENT
E-mail: ceworldbankprojects@gmail.com

1st corrigendum to Bid Identification No. CE-Bridges-II-02/2026-27

Tender for the work at SI No.02 “Improvement such as widening and strengthening of Khaprakhol to Juria road Ch.0/000km to 19/500km in the District of Balangir for the year 2026-27” vide **Bid Identification No. CE-BRIDGES-II 02/ 2026 27** is hereby cancelled due to administrative reasons.

Sd/-
Chief Engineer, Bridges-II, Odisha, Bhubaneswar

OIPR- 34001/34174/1/26-27/0027

OFFICE OF THE SUPERINTENDING ENGINEER RWS&S DIVISION, JAGATSINGHPUR
Tel. No.06724-223485, mail-rwssjpur@gmail.com

e Procurement Notice
Bid identification No. 29 of 2026-27**Letter No. 2495**
Date 07/09/26

The Superintending Engineer, RWS&S Division, Jagatsinghpur on behalf of Governor of Odisha invites P1 composite bids in Double / Single Cover system in online mode for different works on Percentage rate basis from eligible Class of contractors.

1	Name of work	: Execution of Aug. to Rural Piped Water Supply to village Bisampur in Bisampur GP under Tirto Block & Construction of additional office room, Toilet, Office front site development work for Jagatsinghpur section office in Jagatsinghpur District.
2	No. of work	: 02 No
3	Estimated Cost	: Rs. 763515/- to Rs. 14966148/-
4	Cost of Tender paper	: Rs. 4000/- to Rs. 10000/-
5	Class of contractor	: “D”, “C”, “B” & “A” Class
6	Availability of Tender in website	: 21.09.2026 to 8.10.2026
7	Submission of Bid in online	: 21.09.2026 to 08.10.2026
8	Date of seeking clarification	: 21.09.2026 to 23.09.2026
9	Date of opening of bids	: 09.10.2026 (11.00 A.M) onwards
10	Name and address of O.T.	: Superintending Engineer, RWS&S Division, Jagatsinghpur
11	All other details can be seen from the website	: www.tendersorissa.gov.in
12	Bid cost and Bid security should be submitted in online mode.	
13	Subsequent corrigendum/addendum if required shall only be appeared in above website.	

Sd/-
Superintending Engineer RWS&S Divn. Jagatsinghpur

OIPR-25001/25024/1/26-27/0004



BENGALURU SOLID WASTE MANAGEMENT LIMITED
Office of the Deputy General Manager-1,BSWML, 1st Floor, BBMP Building,
Thimmaiah Road, Vasanth Nagar, Bengaluru – 560 052



No: DGM-1/BSWML/TEND/25/2026-27Date: 23.09.2026

INVITATION FOR SHORT TERM TENDER (IFT)-Call-05
(Only through GOK KPP Portal Only)

The Deputy General Manager-1, Bengaluru Solid Waste Management Limited on behalf of the Managing Director, BSWML, Bengaluru invites bids from eligible bidders for the Services mentioned in the table given below.

Sl. No.	Name of the Work	Amt. put to tender/Annum Rs.in lakhs	EMD (in Rs.)	Stipulated Period of Service Contract
1	Primary Collection and Secondary Transportation of Municipal solid waste (MSW) and Street sweeping waste in RR Nagara-2 division (Package-31) Call-05	1,859.56	Rs.1,00,000/- through e-payment mode under of the following i.e., online / RTGS/ NEFT / OTC and the balance Rs. 17,60,000/- by bank Guarantee/FDR issued by Nationalized/scheduled Bank	84 Months

Calendar of events: 1) Tender documents can be downloaded from KPP portal: **23.09.2026 onwards.** 2) Last date to upload pre-bid queries in KPP Portal: **27.09.2026 before 17:30 hrs.** 3) Pre bid meeting: **28.09.2026 at 15:00 hrs.** at above mentioned office 4) Last date for submission of the bids: **05.10.2026 before 17.00 hrs.** 5) Date of opening of Technical bid on: **06.10.2026 after 17.30 hrs.** More details can be downloaded from website: <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in>
DIPR/CP/IA/2914/2026-27Sd/- Deputy General Manager-1, BSWML



ಗ್ರೇಟರ್ ನೌಎಡಾ ಔದ್ಯೋಗಿಕ ವಿಕಾಸ ಪ್ರಾಧಿಕರಣ
ಪ್ಲಾಟ್ ಸಂ. 01, ನಾಲೇಜು ಪಾರ್ಕ್-IV, ಗ್ರೇಟರ್ ನೌಎಡಾ, ಗೊತಮಬ್ಬಡು ನಗರ, ಉತ್ತರ ಪ್ರದೇಶ-201308
ವೆಬ್‌ಸೈಟ್: www.greaternoidaauthority.in ಇ-ಮೇಲ್: authority@gnida.in

पत्रांक: वरि.प्र./ (ई-निविदा सेल) / 2026 / 815दिनांक: 22.09.2026

ई-निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना

महाप्रबन्धक (अभियन्त्रण) ग्रेटर नोएडा औद्योगिक विकास प्राधिकरण द्वारा मुख्य कार्यपालक अधिकारी, ग्रेटर नोएडा की ओर से ई-निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना संख्या- वरि. प्र./ (ई-निविदा सेल)/2026 / 814 दिनांक 22.09.2026 के माध्यम से उल्लेखित क्रम संख्या 01 से 30 तक के कार्य की ई-निविदाये आमन्त्रित जाती है। समस्त नियम व शर्तें ग्रेटर नोएडा प्राधिकरण की वेबसाइट: www.greaternoidaauthority.in पर ई-निविदा लिंक एवं ई-पोर्टल <https://etender.up.nic.in> पर उपलब्ध है। किसी परिवर्तन, संशोधन व अतिरिक्त सूचनाओं के लिए उक्त वेबसाईट देखते रहें।

क्र.सं.	कार्य का नाम/वर्क सर्फिल	अनुमानित लागत
निर्माण कार्य		
1.	ग्रेटर नोएडा में ग्राम हल्द्वानी के शमशान घाट के पहुँच मार्ग, रोड, चबूतरा और कमरे का निर्माण। (वर्क सर्फिल-3)	रु. 21.50 लाख
2.	ग्रेटर नोएडा के सैक्टर-3 ब्लॉक-डी में प्रवेश द्वारा का निर्माण। (वर्क सर्फिल-3)	रु. 23.48 लाख
3.	ग्रेटर नोएडा के ग्राम खेड़ी में नंदन फार्म हाउस से ब्लू डायमंड स्कूल तक इंटरलॉकिंग टाइल्स लगाने का कार्य। (वर्क सर्फिल-2)	रु. 44.94 लाख
4.	ग्रेटर नोएडा के सैक्टर बी.जेड.पी. एरिया में (विभिन्न स्थानों पर) ड्रेन कवर और आर.सी.सी. ड्रेन का निर्माण का कार्य। (वर्क सर्फिल-4)	रु. 80.23 लाख
5.	ग्रेटर नोएडा में मुख्य सड़क (कोरलैण्ड से कासना यू-टर्न आर.एच.एस.) पर इंटरलॉकिंग टाइल्स और ग्री-कास्ट ड्रेन कवर लगाने का कार्य। (वर्क सर्फिल-7)	रु. 87.98 लाख
6.	ग्रेटर नोएडा के सैक्टर इकोटेक-11 में पार्किंग और वर्कशॉप वाले भूखण्ड पर आर.सी.सी. प्रीकास्ट बारंड्रीवॉल का निर्माण कार्य। (वर्क सर्फिल-7)	रु. 95.33 लाख
7.	ग्रेटर नोएडा के रामपुर फतेपुर में 6 प्रतिशत आबादी भूखण्डों और ग्राम की आबादी वाले इलाके में तीन साल तक रखरखाव/अनुसंधान कार्य। (वर्क सर्फिल-7)	रु. 108.34 लाख
8.	ग्रेटर नोएडा के सैक्टर इकोटेक-8 (डिवसन साइड) में 45 मीटर और 60 मीटर चौड़ी सड़क पर होली प्रीकास्ट आर.सी.सी. ड्रेन कवर लगाने का कार्य। (वर्क सर्फिल-7)	रु. 113.37 लाख
9.	ग्रेटर नोएडा के सैक्टर इकोटेक-10 में प्रीकास्ट ड्रेन कवर लगाने का कार्य। (वर्क सर्फिल-7)	रु. 130.73 लाख
10.	ग्रेटर नोएडा के ग्राम रोजा जलालपुर में सी.सी. रोड को ऊंचा करने और ड्रेन निर्माण (बारात घर के आस-पास) का कार्य। (वर्क सर्फिल-1)	रु. 157.00 लाख
11.	ग्रेटर नोएडा के सैक्टर इकोटेक-8 में मुख्य नाले के ऊपर प्रीकास्ट ड्रेन कवर लगाने का कार्य। (वर्क सर्फिल-7)	रु. 159.66 लाख
12.	ग्रेटर नोएडा के ग्राम मल्ला, पाली एवं जुनूपत में डब्ल्यू मेडल कक्षा बेरियर उपलब्ध कराने एवं लगाने का कार्य। (वर्क सर्फिल-6)	रु. 163.11 लाख
13.	ग्रेटर नोएडा के ग्राम जलपुरा में 6 प्रतिशत आबादी भूखण्डों में आर.सी. सी. ड्रेन का निर्माण और रिसर्फेसिंग कार्य। (वर्क सर्फिल-3)	रु. 183.13 लाख
14.	ग्रेटर नोएडा के ग्राम तिलपता करकवास में संतोष नगर से रेलवे स्टेशन तक आर.सी.सी. ड्रेन एवं सी.सी. रोड का निर्माण कार्य (वर्क सर्फिल-2)	रु. 206.32 लाख
15.	ग्रेटर नोएडा में ईकोटेक-3 से डी.एस.सी. रोड और गामा-1 से कोट स्कूप ड्रेन तक हवालिया ड्रेन की सिल्ट सफाई का कार्य। (वर्क सर्फिल-ड्रेन)	रु. 232.42 लाख
16.	ग्राम बिस्वरज जलापुर में 10 प्रतिशत आबादी भूखण्डों विकास कार्य। (वर्क सर्फिल-3)	रु. 251.66 लाख
17.	ग्रेटर नोएडा के सैक्टर रिकिएशनल ग्रीन-5 में 24 मीटर चौड़ी आंतरिक सड़क आर.सी.सी. ड्रेन का निर्माण और सीवर लाइन बिछाने का कार्य। (वर्क सर्फिल-6)	रु. 237.88 लाख
18.	ग्रेटर नोएडा के सैक्टर के.पी.-1 एवं के.पी.-3 के मध्य 24 मीटर चौड़ी सड़क गुरुद्वारा के साथ ही सड़क का चौड़ीकरण रिसर्फेसिंग एवं ग्रास पेवर लगाने का कार्य। (वर्क सर्फिल-4)	रु. 495.79 लाख
19.	ग्रेटर नोएडा के सैक्टर-16 बी और सैक्टर-16 (आबासीय) में आर.सी. सी. नाली निर्माण एवं प्रीकास्ट नाली कवर उपलब्ध कराने व लगाने का कार्य। (वर्क सर्फिल-1)	रु. 524.41 लाख
20.	ग्रेटर नोएडा के ग्राम गिखरपुर, रामपुर माजरा लिंक रोड से खेरली टी -जंक्शन तक आर.सी.सी ड्रेन का निर्माण कार्य। (वर्क सर्फिल-8)	रु. 679.83 लाख
21.	ग्रेटर नोएडा के ग्राम चूहरपुर खदर में सामुदायिक केंद्र का निर्माण का कार्य। (वर्क सर्फिल-4)	रु. 717.35 लाख
22.	ग्रेटर नोएडा के सैक्टर ईकोटेक 3 में डीएससी रोड से पुलिस स्टेशन ईकोटेक-3 तक 24 मीटर चौड़ी सड़क पर आरसीसी ड्रेन का निर्माण और डीएससी रोड से न्यू हॉलैंड रोटीरी तक 60 मीटर चौड़ी सड़क पर प्री कारस्ट ड्रेन कवरिंग को रेलवे से ढकने का कार्य। (वर्क सर्फिल-3)	रु. 788.49 लाख
23.	ग्रेटर नोएडा के सैक्टर टैकजोन-4 में स्थित आर्वा माट से 60 मीटर चौड़ी सड़क तक 45 मीटर चौड़ी सड़क पर किनारे सेन्ट्रल वर्ज एवं प्री कास्ट कवर से नाली को कवर करने का कार्य। (वर्क सर्फिल-3)	रु. 877.83 लाख
24.	ग्रेटर नोएडा के सैक्टर टैकजोन-4 में 130 मीटर चौड़ी सड़क से 60 मीटर चौड़ी सड़क तक 45 मीटर चौड़ी सड़क के किनारे आर.सी.सी. एवं प्री-कास्ट नाली कवर से नाली को कवर करने का कार्य। (वर्क सर्फिल-3)	रु. 1170.51 लाख
25.	सैक्टर ईकोटेक-9 से ई.पी.ई. अंडरपास (ग्राम-लडपुरा) तक 130 मीटर चौड़ी सड़क आर.सी.सी. नाली एवं सीवरेंज का निर्माण कार्य। (वर्क सर्फिल-7)	रु. 2125.52 लाख
विद्युतीकरण के कार्य		
26.	ग्रेटर नोएडा में विभिन्न गोल चक्कों पर एल.ई.डी. सजावटी खंभों की आपूर्ति एवं स्थापना कार्य। (वर्क सर्फिल-ईएण्डएम-3)	रु. 71.18 लाख
27.	ग्रेटर नोएडा के इंडिया एक्सप्रेस मार्ट के गोलचक्कर पर सजावटी लाइट लगाने का कार्य। (वर्क सर्फिल-ईएण्डएम-3)	रु. 138.20 लाख
28.	ग्रेटर नोएडा में सूरजपुर कासना रोड से सैक्टर चाई-5 अंडरपास (60 मीटर सड़क) तक 16 मीटर हाई मास्ट और स्ट्रीट लाइट की व्यवस्था करने का कार्य। (वर्क सर्फिल-ईएण्डएम-3)	रु. 132.30 लाख
29.	6 प्रतिशत ग्राम आबादी (छपरीला, इटहरा, रोजा याकूपपुर, खैरपुर गुर्जर, पतवारी, सीनी, जलपुरा व हैबतपुर) एवं सैक्टर-3, 16 टैकजोन-4 व पुलिस लाइन में स्थापित स्ट्रीट लाइट व हाई मास्ट लाइट का तीन वर्ष का अनुसंधान कार्य। (वर्क सर्फिल-ईएण्डएम-1)	रु. 154.80 लाख
जलापूर्ति एवं सीवर के कार्य		
30.	ग्रेटर नोएडा के सैक्टर-16 औद्योगिक क्षेत्र में वितरण पाइप लाइन बिछाना और नए ट्यूबवैल (ट्यूबवैल के लिए पंपिंग प्लांट का निर्माण कार्य। (वर्क सर्फिल-जल)	रु. 243.47 लाख
क्रम सं.- 01 से 13, 26, 27, 28 एवं 29 तक के कार्यों को दिनांक 25.09.2026 से 05.10.2026 को 5:00 बजे तक अपलोड किया जा सकता है। प्राप्त ई-निविदाओं की प्री-क्वालिफिकेशन दिनांक 07.10.2026 को 11:00 बजे खोली जाएगी एवं क्रम सं.-14 से 25 एवं 30 पर अंकित कार्यों को दिनांक 25.09.2026 से 09.10.2026 को 5:00 बजे तक अपलोड किया जा सकता है। प्राप्त ई-निविदाओं की प्री-क्वालिफिकेशन दिनांक 12.10.2026 को 11:00 बजे खोली जाएगी।		
वरिष्ठ प्रबंधक (ई-निविदा सेल)		
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UPID-256833 Date 22/09/2026
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PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF A PERSON ACCUSED
(See Section 82 Cr. PC/ 84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita-2023)
Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person namely **Imran S/o MD. Aslam R/o H.No. Z-II-255, Welcome, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 423/2014 U/s 324/34 IPC at PS: Welcome, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Imran** can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Imran** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Imran of FIR No. 423/2014 U/s 324/34 IPC of PS: Welcome, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **20.11.2026**.
By order
Deepakshi Rana
Judicial Magistrate First Class-03
Room No.19, First Floor, Shahdara District
Karkardooma Courts, Delhi

DP/12879/NE/2026

NORTHERN RAILWAY
RAIL COACH NAVEENIKARAN KARKHANA, SONIPAT CORRIGENDUM NOTICE

Tender No. 6S-Efile317880R3TenderDated: 22/09/2026

Corrigendum Details
Corrigendum No 1Corrigendum Publish Date 22/09/2026

Tender Details
Tender No 6S-Efile317880R3TenderClosing Date/Time 05/10/2026, 15:00
Name of Work Refurbishment of LHB Coaches (Pantry car) as per scope of work at RCNKS/NP.

Items Modified
NIT Header

Field Name	Existing Value	Modified Value
Tender Closing Date Time	25/09/2026, 15:00	05/10/2026, 15:00

3306/2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

कार्यालय जिलाधिकारी, मुरादाबाद।

सामाजिक समाधात निर्धारण क्रियान्वयन प्रारम्भिक अधिसूचना

सामाजिक समाधात निर्धारण अधिसूचना

03 सितम्बर, 2026 ई०

सं० 1065 आठ/ वि०मू०अ०अ०/मुरादाबाद/2026-राज्य सरकार प्रभावित क्षेत्र में यथास्थिति ग्राम/वाड़ स्तर पर सम्बन्धित पंचायत/नगर पालिका/नगर निगम के परामर्श से निम्नलिखित भूमियां, लोकप्रयोजनार्थ अर्जित करना और सामाजिक समाधात निर्धारण अध्ययन भूमि अर्जन पुनर्वासन और पुनर्व्यस्थापन में उचित प्रतिकर और पारदर्शिता अधिकार अधिनियम 2013 (अधिनियम संख्या-30 सन 2013) की धारा 4 के उपबन्धों के अनुसार किया जायेगा।

- अपेक्षक निकाय का नाम मुरादाबाद विकास प्राधिकरण, मुरादाबाद।
- प्रस्तावित भूमि अर्जन का प्रयोजन विकास प्राधिकरण मुरादाबाद द्वारा शिवालिक आवासीय योजना के निर्माण हेतु।
- अध्ययनकर्ता संगठन-महात्मा ज्योतिबा फूले रुहेलखण्ड विश्वविद्यालय, बरेली।
- भूमि का विवरण-

जिला	तहसील	ग्राम	अर्जित किया जाने वाला क्षेत्रफल (हे० में)
1	2	3	4
मुरादाबाद	मुरादाबाद	डिडौरी	38.4265
			21.9690
			24.3255
योग			84.721

5. प्रस्तावित परियोजना से होने वाले लाभ तथा संक्षिप्त विवरण प्राधिकरण द्वारा अपनी आवासीय व्यावसायिक एवं औद्योगिक योजनाओं हेतु भूमि धारकों / कृषकों से सीधे आपसी समझौते सहमति के आधार पर अथवा भूमि अधिग्रहण अधिनियम 2013 के प्रावधानों के अंतर्गत उचित मुआवजा प्रतिकर का भुगतान करते हुए भूमि जुटाव किया जाता है. शीघ्रता से भूमि का जुटाव किए जाने के लिए वर्तमान में लैंड पुलिंग का भी प्रयोग किया जा रहा है, परंतु ऐसे प्रकरणों में कृषक भूमिधारक पूर्ण रूप से विस्थापित नहीं होता है, अतः उसके भूमि से विरत होने के कारण सामाजिक समाधात पर विचार नहीं किया जाता है। भूमि का अधिग्रहण किए जाने के उपरांत प्राधिकरण द्वारा उस क्षेत्र का मॉडर्न लाइंस के आधार पर विकास किया जाता है. अधिग्रहित भूमि के मध्य से गुजरने वाली अथवा अगल-बगल की महायोजना मार्ग का विकास किए जाने के कारण अधिग्रहित भू-भाग को शहर अथवा जिले के अन्य मार्गों से बेहतर कनेक्टिविटी प्राप्त होती है। प्राधिकरण द्वारा अधिग्रहित भूमि के क्षेत्रफल के आधार/ समानुपात में उक्त भू-भाग में भूखंडों के सृजन के साथ-साथ आंतरिक सड़कों का विकास किया जाता है तथा मूलभूत अवस्थापना सुविधा यथा-सुंदर पार्क, बेहतर जल निकासी प्रबंधन, सीवरेंज प्रणाली, विद्युत आपूर्ति तथा सामुदायिक सुविधा यथा स्टेडियम, क्रीडा स्थल, पार्क स्कूल एवं सामुदायिक केंद्र के लिए भी स्थान आरक्षित किया जाता है, जिसके कारण अधिग्रहित भू-भाग एवं उसके सन्निकट क्षेत्र में आर्थिक उन्नति के लिए वातावरण उत्पन्न हो जाता है तथा इस प्रक्रिया के दौरान लाखों श्रम दिवस का सृजन होता है. गांव की आबादी के योजना के किनारे अथवा मध्य में आ जाने के कारण गांव की आंतरिक गलियों का भी उत्थान होता है तथा गांव को भी शहरों की भांति आधुनिक सुख सुविधाओं का लाभ प्राप्त होता है। जिसके कारण किसानों को अपनी अगली पीढ़ी को शिक्षा के लिए दूरस्थ सुदूर प्रदेशों में अथवा अन्य जिलों में भेजना नहीं होगा तथा रोजगार के लिए पलायन भी नहीं करना होगा. साथ ही अर्जुन से मुक्त भूमिका प्राधिकरण द्वारा किए गए विकास कार्यों के बहुत तेजी से मूल्य में वृद्धि होती है जिससे भी किसान को आर्थिक रूप से समृद्ध होने में सहायता प्राप्त होती है।

- परियोजना क्षेत्र और प्रभावित क्षेत्रफल जिला मुरादाबाद की तहसील सदर मुरादाबाद के उपरोल्लिखित ग्राम का 38.4265 हे०, 21.9690 हे० एवं 24.3255 हे० भूमि।
- क्या ग्राम सभाओं और/अथवा भूस्वामियों की सहमति अपेक्षित है? भूमि अर्जन पुनर्वासन और पुनर्व्यस्थापन में उचित प्रतिकर और पारदर्शिता अधिकार अधिनियम 2013 तथा भूमि अर्जन पुनर्वासन और पुनर्व्यस्थापन में उचित प्रतिकर और पारदर्शिता अधिकार (उत्तर प्रदेश) नियमावली 2016 के उपबन्धों के अनुसार।
- सामाजिक समाधात निर्धारण पूर्ण होने का दिनांक अधिसूचना निर्गत होने की तिथि से दो माह।

टिप्पणी- विवरण, समस्त कार्य दिवसों में (अर्जन से प्रयोजन हेतु) कलैक्टर अद्योहस्ताक्षरी के कार्यालय से प्राप्त किया जा सकता है।

(डॉ. राजेन्द्र पैसिया)
जिलाधिकारी
मुरादाबाद।

Classifieds

PERSONAL

I, Gulshan alias Gulshan Lal Dua S/O Sohan Lal R/O DA-141, SFS Flats, Shalimar Bagh, Delhi-110088, have changed my name to Gulshan Dua for all future purposes. 0040880099-1

I, Gulshan Lal Dua alias Gulshan S/O Late Shri Sohan Lal Dua R/O DA-141, SFS Flats, Shalimar Bagh, Delhi-110088, have changed my name to Gulshan Dua S/O Late Shri Sohan Lal. 0040880099-2

North Eastern Railway
Online E-Tender Notice
Divisional Engineer/Mechanical Workshop for Chief Workshop Manager, N.E. Railway, Mechanical Workshop, Gorakhpur for and on behalf of President of India invites open tenders through online (E-Tendering) for the following work-
S. No. : I. E-Tender Notice No. & Name of the Work : DEN-MWS-2026-09 GKPS - Development of Centre of Excellence for Wheel Shop in Mechanical Workshop/Gorakhpur (as per Drawing no. : G/LT-1107 Alt-1), Estimated Cost : Rs. 1,04,37,031.71, Earnest Money : Rs. 2,08,800.00, Tender Submission Last Date & Time : 27.10.2026 & 11.00hrs.
The details of above tender are also available on Indian Railway website www.ircps.gov.in
Chief Workshop Manager, Mechanical Workshop, CPRO/Mech-88 N.E. Railway, Gorakhpur
Do not smoke Bidi/Cigarette in train

कार्यालय परियोजना प्रबंधक, युनिट-18 कन्स्ट्रक्शन एण्ड डिजाइन सर्विसेज उत्तर प्रदेश जल निगम (नगरीय) (उपग्रो सरकार का उपक्रम)

मकान सं.-7बी/108, चौक विहार मंगोलो योजना सं.-4, भाग-2 (निकट सर्विसान साइडव्य वाटिका, चन्द्रशेखर अजाद पार्क के सामने), दिल्ली रोड, मुरादाबाद-244103
E-mail: pm18nbn@gmail.com

पत्रांक- 2544/एम-18 / 726 दिनांक: 22.09.2026

अल्पकालीन ई-निविदा सूचना

उत्तर प्रदेश जल निगम (नगरीय), की ओर से अयोधस्ताक्षरी द्वारा Construction of Govt. Inter college Kemri, Rampur (Multipurpose Hall) अनुमानित लागत ₹ 36.43 लाख, हेतु दिनांक 07-10-2026 की अपरान्ह 16:30 बजे तक ई-निविदाएं आमन्त्रित की जाती हैं। उक्त कार्य हेतु ई-निविदा प्रपत्र दिनांक 23.09.2026 से दिनांक 07.10.2026 के मध्य उत्तर प्रदेश सरकार की e-procurement की वेबसाइट <https://etender.up.nic.in> से डाउनलोड किये जा सकते हैं तथा ई-निविदा दिनांक 08.10.2026 को अपरान्ह 13:30 बजे कार्यालय परियोजना प्रबन्धक, युनिट-18, सी. एण्ड डी.एस., उ.प्र. जल निगम (नगरीय), मुरादाबाद में खोली जायेगी। ई-निविदा प्रपत्र का मूल्य ₹ 3,000.00+GST (18%) अतिरिक्त देय होगा। निविदा की किसी भी शर्तों को परिवर्तित करने तथा निविदा को बिना कोई कारण बताये अव्यक्त करने का अधिकार विभाग के पास सुरक्षित रहेगा। निविदा से सम्बन्धित विस्तृत विवरण विभाग की वेबसाइट www.cdsupjn.org एवं प्रोक्योरमेन्ट पोर्टल <https://etender.up.nic.in> पर उपलब्ध है। समस्त शुद्धि पत्र (Corrigendum) <https://etender.up.nic.in> पर ही अपलोड किये जायेंगे, इनका प्रयोजन से कोई प्रकाशन नहीं किया जायेगा। निविदादाताओं को सलाह दी जाती है कि वे उक्त वेबसाइट का समय-समय पर अवलोकन करते रहें।

"IMPORTANT"
Whilst care is taken prior to acceptance of advertising copy, it is not possible to verify its contents. The Indian Express (P) Limited cannot be held responsible for such contents, nor for any loss or damage incurred as a result of transactions with companies, associations or individuals advertising in its newspapers or Publications. We therefore recommend that readers make necessary enquiries before sending any monies or entering into any agreements with advertisers or otherwise acting on an advertisement in any manner whatsoever.

NORTHERN RAILWAY
NOTICE FOR E-AUCTION

Senior Divisional Commercial Manager/Freight, Delhi Division, Northern Railway, in terms of Railway Board letter no. 2022/TC/FM/ 10/04 dated 13.06.2022, and Railway Board's letter no. 2024/RS/G/779/7 (E3471089) dated 13.08.2024, invites bids through e-Auction (www.ireps.gov.in) for leasing of parcel space of SLR compartments and VPs (on round trip basis) for a period of three years as per detail and schedule given below:-

S. No.	Date & time of e-Auction	Assets to be auctioned
1	28.09.2026 at 10:30 am	12265(F1), 12596(F1), 12918(F1), 14014(F1), 14056(R1), 14164(F1), 14341(F1), 14679(F1), 14681 (F1, R1), 15035(F1, F2, R1), 19404(F1, R1), 22428(F1), 22950(F1).
2	30.09.2026 at 10:30 am	12212(R1), 12394(F1), 12457(F1, F2, R1), 12963(F1), 14303(F1, F2, R1), 15134(F1), 18428(F1), 20473(F1), 22429(F1), 22438(F1, R1), 22472(F1), 22542(F1, R1).
3	05.10.2026 at 10:30 am	12060(F1) (Sun, Mon), 12060(F1) (Tue, Wed, Thu, Fri, Sat), 12436(F1), 12986(F1), 14331(F1, F2, R1), 14507(F1, F2, R1), 14731(F1, R1), 15058(F1), 22410(F1), 22418(R1), 22421(F1, F2, R1), 22454(F1, F2, R1).

Important notes: 1. For more information, requirement and various aspects regarding these e-Auctions, interested bidders are advised to visit https://www.ireps.gov.in/html/helpdes/learning_centre.html (e-Auction leasing section). 2. Railway Administration reserves the full and absolute rights to short terminate these contracts at any point of time and/or for taking any decision regarding the discontinuation/continuation of these contracts with modified/ additional terms and conditions depending upon the continuation/discontinuation of these trains or commencement of new train services.

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE**3305/26**



BENGALURU SOLID WASTE MANAGEMENT LIMITED
Office of the Deputy General Manager-1, BSWML, 1st Floor, BBMP Building, Thimmaiah Road, Vasanth Nagar, Bengaluru – 560 052



No.DGM-1/BSWML/TEND/22/2026-27Date: 23.09.2026

INVITATION FOR SHORT TERM TENDER
(Through GOK KPP Portal Only) (Call-04)

The Deputy General Manager-1, Bengaluru Solid Waste Management Limited on behalf of the Managing Director, BSWML, Bengaluru invites bids from eligible bidders for the Services mentioned in the table given below

Sl. No.	Name of the Work	Amount Put to Tender Per annum (Rs.in Lakhs)	EMD (Amount in Rs)	Contract Period
1	Primary Collection and Secondary Transportation of Municipal solid waste (MSW) and Street sweeping waste in Mahadevapura-1 division. (Package-24) Call-04	1,898.76	Rs.1,00,000/- through e-payment mode under of the following i.e., online / RTGS / NEFT / OTC and the balance Rs.17,99,000/- by Bank Guarantee/FDR issued by Nationalized / Scheduled Bank	84 Months

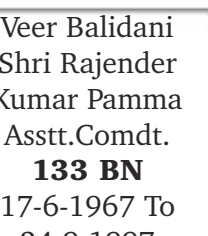
1) Tender documents can be downloaded from kpp portal: **23.09.2026.** 2) Last date to upload pre-bid queries in KPP Portal: **27.09.2026 before 17:30 hrs.** 3) Tender Pre Bid meeting: **28.09.2026 at 15:00 hrs** at above mentioned office. 4) Last Date of Receipt of Tender **05.10.2026 before 17:00 hrs.** 5) Opening of Technical Bid: **06.10.2026 after 17:30 hrs.**
More details can be downloaded from website - <http://kppp.karnataka.gov.in> Sd/-
Deputy General Manager-1, BSWML
DIPR/CP/2908/CCL/2026-27

SALUTE THE SOLDIER

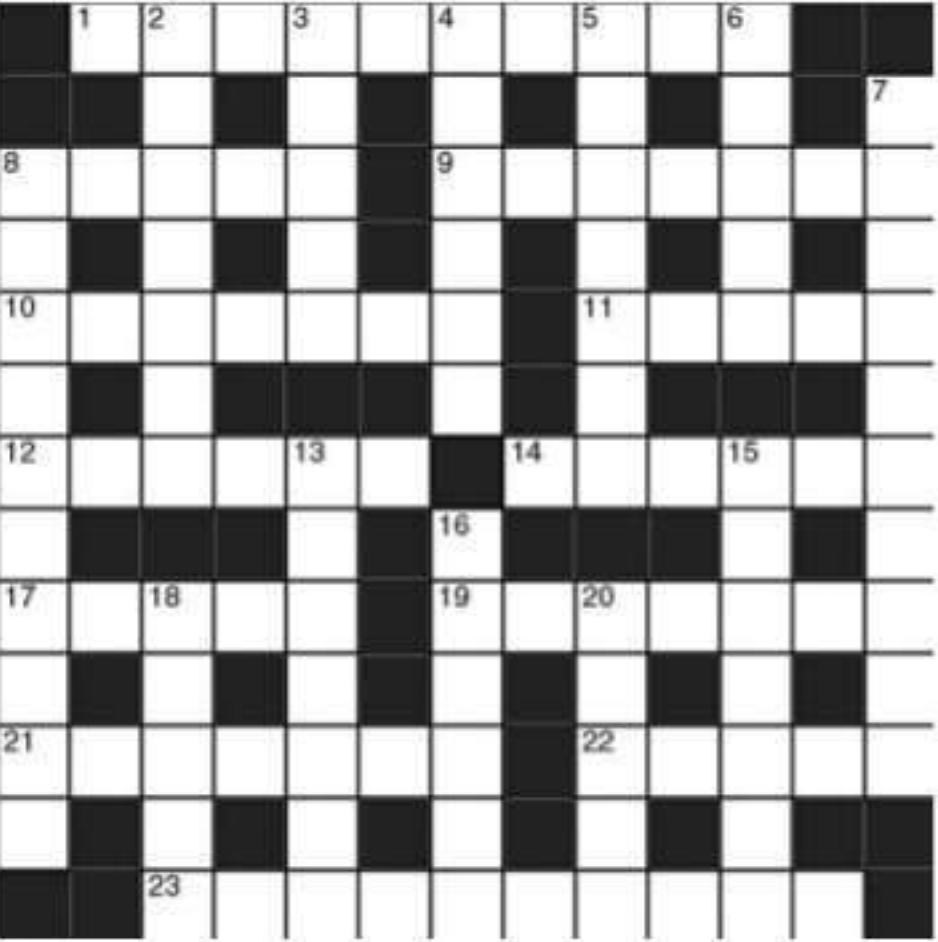
Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawans on their Balidan Diwas.

 SI R S RATHORE 03 BN BSF 01.04.1945 – 24.09.1992	 HC PT LEPCHA 03 BN BSF 19.03.1942 – 24.09.1992	 HC PURSHOTTAM SINGH 03 BN BSF 08.07.1948 – 24.09.1992	 NAIK BODH RAJ 03 BN BSF 30.04.1945 – 24.09.1992
 CT RAM SWAROOP SINGH 03 BN BSF 16.09.1968 – 24.09.1992	 CT SURESH MINJ 03 BN BSF 12.03.1972 – 24.09.1992	 CT SUBRAMANIAM C 03 BN BSF 21.05.1966 – 24.09.1992	 CT RAJBALM RAM 03 BN BSF 02.06.1949 – 24.09.1992
 CT CHANDER BHUSHAN 03 BN BSF 10.12.1968 – 24.09.1992	 CT BALBIR CHAND 03 BN BSF 16.05.1969 – 24.09.1992	 CT RAJ MAL 03 BN BSF 04.05.1968 – 24.09.1992	 CT HARDAN SINGH 03 BN BSF 01.05.1966 – 24.09.1992

INDO-TIBETAN BORDER POLICE (ITBP)
ITBP salutes its braveheart Constable Jaswant Singh of 4th Battalion, who made the supreme sacrifice in the line of duty on this day in Arunachal Pradesh in 2020.

CENTRAL RESERVE POLICE FORCE			
 Veer Balidani Shri Rajender Kumar Pamma Asstt.Comdt. 133 BN 17-6-1967 To 24-9-1997	 Veer Balidani Constable Mohd. Latif 133 BN 1-11-1965 To 24-9-1997	 Veer Balidani	

CROSSWORD



ACROSS
1 Escape route taken by aircraft (6,4)
8 Large cat makes a row about midnight (5)
9 0 to be in credit for one month! (7)
10 Doesn't convey a clear message say in writing (7)
11 Victorious and advancing for the Polish capital (2,3)
12 A diminutive person — or a ten-footer (6)
14 Appear to give embarrassment (4,2)
17 Reg comes back about four - he's got a present (5)
19 Iron sort of cup (7)
21 Strange role man plays in charitable occupation (7)
22 Mother is set back by our love affair (5)
23 Plight of the penitent? (5,5)

DOWN
2 The girl looks different having slimmed (7)
3 Overindulge in food or scrambled egg (5)
4 Maoist is involved in Chinese philosophy (6)
5 Ancient city where Syrians went to a chin-wag? (7)
6 It's customary for riding (5)
7 Plotters use it (5,5)
8 It tells us when a fresh batch of mail gets in (4,6)
13 Itinerant craftsman (7)
15 Reckon to keep fit (4,3)
16 A way man gets lost (6)
18 Improvises with 5 amp fuses (5)
20 Spilled a pint being clumsy (5)

SOLUTIONS CROSSWORD 6101
ACROSS: 1 Assent, 4 Strain, 9 Shatter, 10 Rimed, 11 Scrub, 12 Unbends, 13 Steeplejack, 18 Maidens, 20 Jacks, 22 Taboo, 23 Maturated, 24 Crewel, 25 Duties
DOWN: 1 Assisi, 2 Stair, 3 Notable, 5 Throb, 6 Almanac, 7 Nudist, 8 Troublesome, 14 Thimble, 15 Jujitsu, 16 Emetic, 17 Asides, 19 Elope, 21 Corgi

JUMBLLED WORDS

Given below are four jumbled words. Solve the jumbles to make proper words and move them to the respective circles below. Select the letters in the shaded circles and jumble them to get the answer for the given quip.

_____ is the foundation of all things. --Edmund Burke (4,5)

GOERR

ELSOO

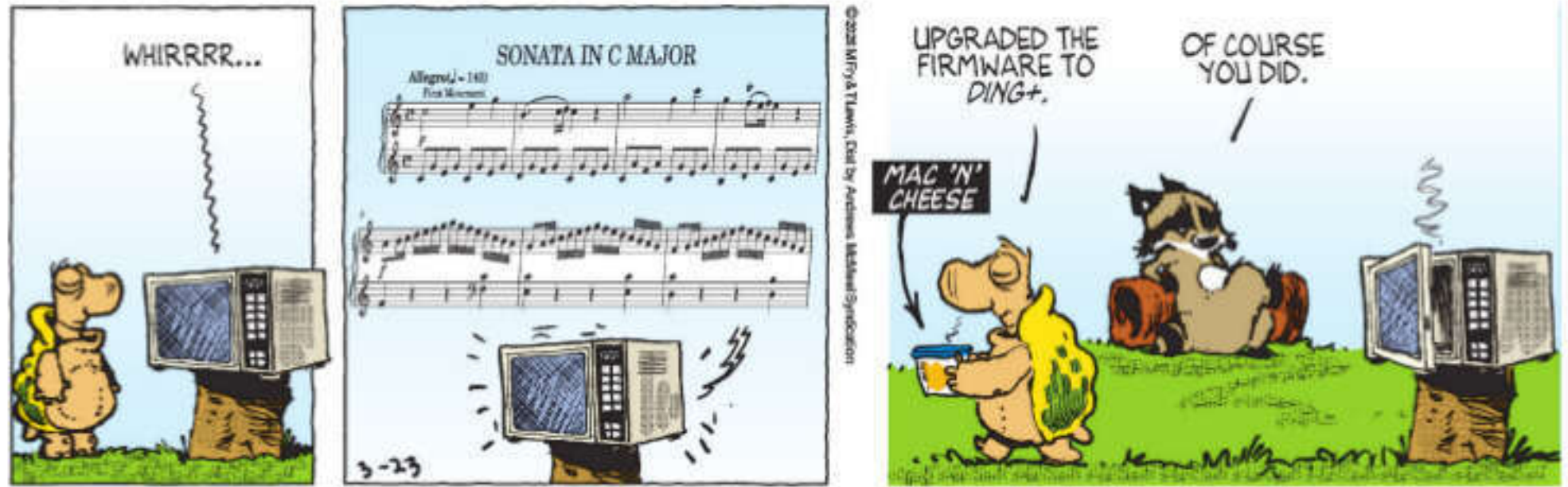
AEIRDO

DEGODG

_____ is the foundation of all things. --Edmund Burke

SOLUTIONS: Roger, Loose, Roadie, Dogged

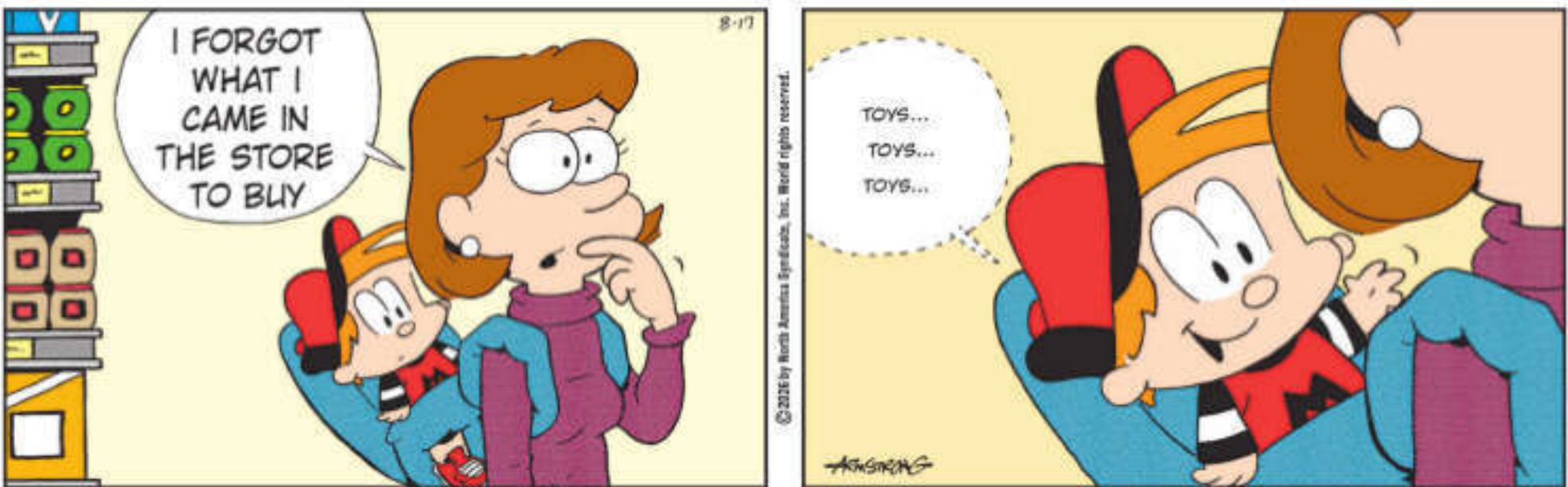
OVER THE HEDGE



CALVIN & HOBBS



MARVIN



DIFFICULTY LEVEL 3s INSTRUCTIONS

To solve a Sudoku puzzle, every digit from 1 to 9 must appear in each of the nine vertical columns, in each of the nine horizontal rows and in each of the nine boxes.

DIFFICULTY LEVEL

1s = Very easy; 2s = Easy; 3s = Medium; 4s = Hard; 5s = Very Hard; 6s = Genius

SUDOKU 6451

	8		4				5	7
5		2						1
7			9				3	
				8		9	7	2
3		8	2		4			
	4					8		5
8							1	7
	3	7						9

SOLUTION SUDOKU 6450

6	8	9	7	4	2	5	3	1
2	3	4	1	8	5	6	9	7
7	5	1	9	3	6	8	2	4
5	6	2	8	9	7	1	4	3
9	1	3	2	5	4	7	8	6
8	4	7	6	1	3	9	5	2
4	7	8	5	2	1	3	6	9
3	9	6	4	7	8	2	1	5
1	2	5	3	6	9	4	7	8

राजस्थान सरकार

कार्यालय अधीक्षण अभियन्ता सार्वजनिक निर्माण विभाग वृत्त अलवर

सा.नि.वि. परियारा, अलवर, राजस्थान के पास, कदहरी रोड, अलवर

फोन:- 0144-2737038, E-mail:-sealw.pwd@rajasthan.gov.in

क्रमांक-Rajkaj Ref No.:24616021 दिनांक 19.09.26

Short Term NIT No 15/2026-27

Construction of Various Missing Link / Non-Patchable Roads under Package No RJ-02-14/ML-RAMGARH/BA/2026-27 and Package No RJ-02-17/ML-KATHUMAR/BA/2026-27 at Jurisdiction of PWD Divisions Ramgarh and Kathumar District Alwar Online bids are invited from eligible and interested bidders for the above-mentioned works. The bidding process will commence from 19.09.2026 at 02:00 PM up to 29.09.2026 at 06:00 PM. Detailed bidding documents and other particulars may be downloaded from the State Procurement Portal <http://sppp.raj.nic.in>, and the PWD <http://pwd.rajasthan.gov.in>, <http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in>, departmental website

The approximate value of the procurements is ₹ 467.48 Lakhs.

UBN No :-

1. PWD2627WSOB12571

2. PWD2627WSRC12616

Sd/-

Superintending Engineer

PWD Circle Alwar

DIPR/C/16299/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF A PERSON ACCUSED

See Section 82 Cr. P.C. / 84 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person Krishna S/o Dhan Singh R/o H. No. 1030, Khasra No. 1/23/1, D Block, Main Road, Nathupura, Delhi also at Village Gunya Zuddi, P.S. Charthawal, Distt. Muzaffar Nagar, U.P. has Committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case FIR No. 482/2016 U/s 376 IPC, P.S. Swaroop Nagar, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused Krishna cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused Krishna has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused Krishna of case FIR No. 482/2016 U/s 376 IPC, P.S. Swaroop Nagar, Delhi is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before 30.11.2026.

By Order

Sh. Rajesh Kumar

Additional District and Sessions Judge

Special Fast Track Court (North Distt.)

Room No. 204, 2nd Floor

Rohini Courts, Delhi

DP/13474/ON/2026 (Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 CrPC/84 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Wazir S/o Sajjan Singh R/o House No. A-149, Patashe Wali Gali, Village Bawana, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case registered vide FIR No. 817/2022 U/S 411 IPC, PS Narela Industrial Area, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest their upon issued that the said accused Wazir can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said Wazir has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused Wazir of FIR No. 817/2022 U/S 411 IPC, PS Narela Industrial Area, Delhi is required to appear before this court (or before me) to answer the complaint on or before the day of 30.10.2026.

By Order,,

Sh. Sahil Gupta

Judicial Magistrate First Class-07

North, Court No. 6, Ground Floor

Rohini Courts, Delhi

DP/13449/ON/2026(Court Matter)

कार्यालय अधीक्षण अभियन्ता

सा.नि.वि. वृत्त, जैसलमेर

क्रमांक:-अ.अ/जैसल/2026-27/1633 दिनांक :- 17.09.2026

निविदा सूचना संख्या 04/2026-27

NIB No. PWD2627A2777

राजस्थान के राज्यपाल महोदय की ओर से मुख्यमंत्री थार सीमा क्षेत्र विकास कार्यक्रम के अन्तर्गत स्वीकृत सड़क निर्माण कार्य एवं भवन निर्माण कार्य के लिए उपयुक्त श्रेणी में सार्वजनिक निर्माण विभाग राजस्थान में पंजीकृत संवेदकों एवं राज्य सरकार/केन्द्र सरकार के अधिकृत संगठनों/केन्द्रीय लोक निर्माण/डाक एवम दूर संचार विभाग/रेल्वे इत्यादि में पंजीकृत संवेदकों, जो कि राजस्थान सरकार के उपयुक्त श्रेणी के संवेदकों के समकक्ष हों, से निर्धारित प्रपत्र में कुल 04 कार्य जिनकी लागत राशि रु. 856.78 लाख है के लिए इंटेन्डरिंग प्रक्रिया हेतु ऑन लाईन निविदाये आमंत्रित की जाती है।

ऑनलाईन निविदा आवेदन डाउनलोड एवं : 24 सितम्बर 2026 प्रातः 9:30 बजे से 14 अक्टूबर 2026, सांय 06:00 बजे तक

निविदा से संबंधित विवरण वेब साईट <http://dipr.rajasthan.gov.in> व <http://sppp.rajasthan.gov.in> व <http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in> पर देखा जा सकता है। सम्पूर्ण निविदा प्रक्रिया <http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in> पर ऑनलाईन सम्पादित की जायेगी। इच्छुक संवेदकों को अपने डिजिटल हस्ताक्षर के माध्यम से वेबसाईट पर <http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in> पर रजिस्टर्ड करवाना आवश्यक है कार्यवार यू.बी.एन. संख्या निम्नानुसार है।

हस्ता./-

(पी.एन. रहलोल)

अधीक्षण अभियन्ता

सा.नि.वि. वृत्त जैसलमेर

DIPR/C/16222/2026

कार्यालय मुख्य अभियन्ता जल संसाधन (उत्तर) हनुमानगढ़

नवदीक तिलक सर्किल, हनुमानगढ़ जखान-335512

फोन नं. 01552-260607, ई-मेल आईडी-cewdrhnm@gmail.com

क्रमांक :- एफ.2 / लेखा / Karni and Sadul Branch/ खण्ड BSR/ 2026-27 दिनांक :-

Notice Inviting Bid (NIB Code WRN2627A0057)

Bids for the below mentioned works in the table invited from prospective bidders up to **05-10-2026 time 6.00 PM.**

S. No.	Name of work	Estimated cost (Rs.)	UBN No.
Retining of Karni Singh Branch of Bhakra Canal System Rs 68976000.00)-			
1	Renovation and Modernization of Cross Regulator at RD 26.181 RD 54.148 & Head Regulator RD48.325 & Bridge at RD 7.000, RD 17.000 RD37.000 & RD48.325 of Karni Singh Branch of Bhakra Canal System (P-1)	229658506.00	WRN2627WLOB00154
2	Relining of Karni Singh branch of Bhakra Canal System from RD 0.000 to 26.181 (P-2)	172112467.00	WRN2627WLOB00155
3	Relining of Karni Singh branch of Bhakra Canal System from RD 26.181 to 54.148 (P-3)	179727309.00	WRN2627WLOB00156
Retining of Sadul Branch of Bhakra Canal System Rs 2249018000.00)-			
4	Renovation & Modernization of Cross Regulator & Head Regulator at RD 142.200, RD198.700 & Bridge at RD 18.000 of Sadul Branch of Bhakra Canal System (P-1)	204834389.00	WRN2627WLOB00157
5	Renovation & Modernization of Cross Regulator & Head Regulator at RD 73.000, RD 90.600, RD 103.000 & Bridge at RD 82.000, RD 108.000 of Sadul Branch of Bhakra Canal System (P-2)	212752536.00	WRN2627WLOB00158
6	Renovation & Modernization of Cross Regulator & Head Regulator at RD 142.200, RD198.700 & Bridge at RD 116.000, RD 135.000 RD, RD 156.000 & RD 172.000 of Sadul Branch of Bhakra Canal System (P-3)	155444730.00	WRN2627WLOB00159
7	Relining of Sadul branch of Bhakra Canal System from RD 0.000 to 30.000 (P-4)	252127131.00	WRN2627WLOB00160
8	Relining of Sadul branch of Bhakra Canal System from RD 30.000 to 59.000 (P-5)	272404690.00	WRN2627WLOB00161
9	Relining of Sadul branch of Bhakra Canal System from RD 59.000 to 90.600 (P-6)	252879680.00	WRN2627WLOB00162
10	Relining of Sadul branch of Bhakra Canal System from RD 90.600 to 125.000 (P-7)	248493140.00	WRN2627WLOB00163
11	Relining of Sadul branch of Bhakra Canal System from RD 125.000 to 162.500 (P-8)	247503443.00	WRN2627WLOB00164
12	Relining of Sadul branch of Bhakra Canal System from RD 162.500 to 198.700 (P-9)	208265795.00	WRN2627WLOB00165

Other particulars of the bids may be visited on the procurement portal <http://www.eproc.rajasthan.gov.in>, <http://sppp.rajasthan.gov.in>, of the state and www.water.rajasthan.gov.in departmental website.

(Pradeep Rustagi)

Chief Engineer

Water Resources(North)

Hanumanagarh

DIPR/C/16208/2026

कार्यालय नगर विकास ब्यास, अलवर (राज.)

क्रमांक :- लेखा/2026/5069 दिनांक :- 19/09/2026

NOTICE INVITING NIT – 12/2026-27

Providing Temporary Lighting Arrangements in UIT 03-08-2026 to 08-08-2026 3.00 PM. Technical bid Will be opened 10-08-2026 at 4.00 PM, particulars of the bid may be visited on the procurement portal <http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in>, <http://sppp.raj.nic.in> of the state and www.uitalwar.in. The approximate Value of the procurement is Rs. 9.50 lakhs. UBN No. : UBN No. : UAL2627WSOB00130, 00131, 00132, 00133, 00134, 00135, 00136, 00137, 00138, 00139, 00140, 00141, 00142, 00143, 00144

Executive Engineer

UIT, Alwar

Raj.Samwad/C/26/10661

NORTHERN RAILWAY

Tender Notice

Sr. Divisional Mechanical Engineer, Northern Railway, Trainset Depot, Shakurbasti for and on behalf of President of India invites GeM (<https://gem.gov.in>) for the under noted work.

Tender No.	GEM/2026/B/067552
Name of work	Provision for Comprehensive Annual Maintenance Contract of Roof Mounted package AC Unit (RMPU) system of SPICs of Trainset Depot Shakurbasti for a period of Thirty Six Months (Manpower + Materials)
Approx. Cost	₹ 58,42,588.00 including GST
Earnest money	₹ 1,16,900.00
Completion period of the work	36 Months
Date and time for opening of tender	14.10.2026 at 15:00
Website particulars notice board location complete details of tender can be seen	Above tender is available on Gem site i.e (https://gem.gov.in) w.e.f. 22.09.26
No: 25.8.1023.TSD.SSB Date : 22.09.2026	3303/2026
Serving Customers With A Smile	

GOVERNMENT OF TELANGANA

ROADS AND BUILDINGS DEPARTMENT

RFP No. 06/RFP/HAM/PHASE-I/R&B/IE/2026 Date: 22.09.2026

REQUEST FOR PROPOSAL (RFP)

Government of Telangana, Roads & Buildings Department (R&B) invites Bids through e-procurement platform from experienced firms, for "“Consultancy Services for Independent Engineers (during Development, Construction and O&M Period) for Widening, Strengthening, and Maintenance of Selected R&B Roads in the State of Telangana under Hybrid Annuity Mode - Phase-I”".

The complete set of documents can be viewed/downloaded from e-procurement portal of Govt. of Telangana i.e., <https://tender.telangana.gov.in> or <https://roadbuilding.telangana.gov.in> from 28.09.2026 onwards.

For further details please visit our website or contact R&B office at telephone numbers: 8686263866.

Email id: ham2025.rmb@gmail.com

Sd/-

Chief Engineer (R&B), HAM, SR, CRN, & MD TGRDC

R.o. No. : 10554-PP/CL/ADVT/2026-27 Date: 23-09-2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 84 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Prashant @ Koyal S/o Munna R/o E-8, Mahavir Vihar, JJ Colony, Sector-1, Dwarka, New Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case registered vide FIR No.163/2024 U/S 25 Arms Act, PS Sagarpur, New Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest their upon issued that the said accused Prashant @ Koyal can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said Prashant @ Koyal has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused Prashant @ Koyal of FIR No.163/2024 U/S 25 Arms Act, PS Sagarpur, New Delhi is required to appear before this court (or before me) to answer the complaint on or before the day of 19.11.2026.

By Order,

Sh. Aridaman Singh Cheema

Judicial Magistrate First Class-03

28, First Floor, Main Building

Patiala House Courts, New Delhi

DP/13322/SW/2026(Court Matter)

ROYAL STARS

ARIES (MAR 21 - APR 20): Keep your pockets open because money might come to you today. Or perhaps you'll receive favours or a gift. This is also an affectionate day that can promote romance. Be patient with family. Tonight: Pleasant solitude.

TAURUS (APR 21 - MAY 21): This is a lovely day to enjoy the company of partners and close friends, as you feel friendly and easygoing. A flirtation with a casual friend might be sparked. You're keen to work and be productive. Make time to relax with loved ones. Tonight: Friendships.

GEMINI (MAY 22 - JUNE 21): You make an attractive impression on your world today. Be aware that people see you as gentle and caring. You might use this image to work for you in some way. Tonight: Be modest.

CANCER (JUNE 22 - JULY 23): This is a truly romantic day for you, and some of you might be attracted to someone who is different from the kind of person you generally meet. Travel will also appeal. Tonight: New discoveries.

LEO (JULY 24 - AUG 23): This is a romantic and affectionate day for you. You also might use this same energy to make where you live look more attractive and then invite people over to share your good feelings. An introduction through a family member will lead to romance. Tonight: Check your finances.

VIRGO (AUG 24 - SEP 23): Today you feel pleasant and friendly with everyone. You might have an increased interest in the arts because your appreciation of beauty is heightened. Tonight: Be interested.

LIBRA (SEP 24 - OCT 23): This is a favourable day for financial negotiations as well as shopping for beautiful things. You also might attract money to you today. It's a favourable day to discuss earnings that are work-related. Tonight: Work is rewarding.

SCORPIO (OCT 24 - NOV 23): This is a lovely, romantic day for you, because the Moon is dancing with fair Venus in your sign, and it is in one of the most romantic places in your chart. It's the perfect day for a date. Make plans with your main squeeze. Tonight: Socialise.

SAGITTARIUS (NOV 24 - DEC 22): This is a pleasant day to enjoy the privacy of your own home and just relax in pleasant surroundings. Choose your guilty pleasure to snack on. Tonight: Enjoy time at home.

CAPRICORN (DEC 23 - JAN 20): Today you are charming, diplomatic and keenly tuned into the moods of others. It's a strong day for those of you in sales, marketing, teaching or acting. It's also a great day for flirtations with friends, especially artistic types. Tonight: Informative discussions.

AQUARIUS (JAN 21 - FEB 19): You can attract money to you today, which is why this is an excellent day for financial discussions. Make your pitch. Ask for a raise. Ask for an advantage. You can't win if you don't buy a ticket. People admire you today. Tonight: Maintain your belongings.

PISCES (FEB 20 - MAR 20): It's a lovely day! The Moon is in your sign dancing beautifully with fair Venus, making all your interactions with others charming and mutually rewarding. This planetary dance particularly favours romance and fun socialising. Tonight: You're in charge.

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF A PERSON ACCUSED

(See Section 82 Cr. PC)/

(See Section 84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita-2023)

Whereas Complaint has been made before me that accused Jawahar Arora S/o. Late Sh. Hemraj Arora R/o. H.No. 11/340 DDA Flats East of Kailash New Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in a FIR No. 70/2004 Dt. 19.05.2004 U/s 419/420/468 IPC at PS: Special Cell, New Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused Jawahar Arora could not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused Jawahar Arora has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused Jawahar Arora of FIR No. 70/2004 Dt. 19.05.2004 U/s 419/420/468 IPC PS: Special Cell, New Delhi is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before 24.10.2026.

By order

Mridul Gupta

Chief Judicial Magistrate

26. G.F. Annexe Building

Patiala House Courts

New Delhi

DP/13531/Spl. Cell/2026

ऑयल एण्ड नेचुरल गैस कॉर्पोरेशन लिमिटेड

Oil and Natural Gas Corporation Ltd.

EXPRESSION OF INTEREST (EOI) NOTIFICATION FOR "ENGINEERING REVIVAL & PROCESS MODIFICATION OF ACID GAS TREATMENT UNIT"

Expressions of Interest (EOI) is invited for the engineering revival and process modification of the Acid Gas Treatment Unit at the ONGC Uran Plant. The project is envisaged as a Single-Point Responsibility LSTK / EPC package and principally involves the replacement of the existing gas-to-gas Heat Recovery Unit with a Low-Pressure Waste Heat Boiler. The scope includes comprehensive brownfield rehabilitation, integration of associated process, utility, effluent treatment, electrical, and control (DCS/SIS) systems, alongside end-to-end statutory Indian Boiler Regulations (IBR) compliance and a mandatory 3-year O&M period. Date of EOI: 24.09.2026, Document Submission by 15.10.2026.

The EOI details are available in ONGC website: <https://tenders.ongc.co.in> and <https://eprocure.gov.in/eprocure/app>. Interested parties/bidders can submit their EOI through E-Mail to nanaraje_sunil@ongc.co.in within 21 days from publication of this notification.

कार्यालय अधिशाषी अभियन्ता, सार्वजनिक निर्माण विभाग निर्माण खण्ड, जयपुर

क्रमांक :- 15870 दिनांक : 23.09.2026

अल्पकालीन ई-निविदा सूचना संख्या 29/2026-27

Bids for Building Construction / Maintenance works are invited from interested bidders upto 25-09-2026 (12.00 PM) Other particulars of the bid may be visited on the procurement portal <http://sppp.raj.nic.in> and <http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in>

S.NO	UBN NO.
1	PWD2627SL0B12971
2	PWD2627SSOB12972

हस्ता./-

(योजना कुमारी गुप्ता)

अधिशाषी अभियन्ता

सा.नि.वि. निर्माण खण्ड,

जयपुर

OFFICE OF SUPERINTENDING ENGINEER

PWE CIRCLE JHUNJHUNU

No.: SE/Jhunjhun/2026-1039 Date: 08-09-2026

NIB Code: PWD2627A2661

UBN Code: PWD 2627 WSOB 11815, PW2627WSOB11816

Short term Notice Inviting Bid No. 04/2026-27

Bids for 02(Two Nos) Roads Work are invited from interested bidders upto 03:00 PM from dated 09.09.2026 to 25.09.2026. Other particulars of the bid may be visited on the procurement portal (<http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in>, <http://sppp.raj.nic.in>) of the state; and PWD departmental website. The approximate value of the procurement is Rs. 517.3 Lacs.

Sd/-

Superintending Engineer

PWD Circle Jhunjhunu

DIPR/C/15881/2026

● MEDAL TALLY

Po	Country	G	S	B	T
1	China	48	20	10	78
2	Japan	15	25	27	67
3	S Korea	8	8	25	41
4	Kaz'stan	7	4	8	19
5	Thailand	5	3	4	12
13	India	1	5	6	12

DAY 5 CAPSULE

Haul: 1 Silver, 4 Bronze

WEIGHTLIFTING

●Saikhom Mirabai Chanu completed the set by winning the only medal that had eluded her all these years. She secured a silver medal in her third Asian Games campaign.

SHOOTING

●The women's skeet team, comprising Raiza Dhillon, Maheshwari Chauhan and Parinaaz Dhalwal, secured a bronze medal.

●The men's team — featuring Anantjeet Singh Naruka, Bhavtegh Singh Gill and Mairaj Ahmed Khan — also clinched a bronze medal.

BADMINTON

●The Indian men's team's campaign ended with a bronze medal, following a 1-3 defeat to China in the semi-finals. The pair of Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty were the only victors among Indians shuttlers on Wednesday.

SOFT TENNIS

●Jay Meena became the first Indian to win an Asian Games medal in soft tennis. He defeated Philippines' Sherwin Nuguit 4-3 in the quarter-final, before losing the semi-final against Japan's Takuya Kurosaka 2-4.

● TODAY'S PICKS

DAY 6

Shooting: Men's 10m Air Pistol Team Final (6:15 AM), Men's 10m Air Pistol Individual Final (subject to qualification) (12:15 PM)

●The men's team of Kedarling Uchaganve, Kamaljeet and Aakash Bhardwaj will be in action.

Shooting: Skeet Mixed Team Qualifying (6:30 AM) & Final (11:15 AM)

●Having secured medals in their respective team events, Anantjeet Singh Naruka and Parinaaz Dhalwal will pair up for the skeet mixed team final.

Athletics: Mixed 4x400m Relay Heats (7 AM) and Final (6:45PM)

●Jay Kumar, Manu Thekkinal, Ansa Babu and Rashdeep Kaur will be representing India in the mixed 4x400m relay.

Athletics: Women's Triple Jump Final (4:15 PM)

●Asha Ilango and Niharika Vashist will feature in this event.

Squash: Women's Singles, Round of 16 (10:30 AM)

●18-year old prodigy Anahat Singh and veteran Tanvi Khanna will start their campaigns against Singaporean opponents.

Hockey: Men's Pool A (11:30 AM)

●India will be hoping to maintain their perfect record by beating South Korea.

“ The pressure is gone. I feel very light. This was the only thing missing. In a way, my life is complete now. ”

SAIKHOM MIRABAI CHANU, AFTER WINNING HER MAIDEN ASIAN GAMES MEDAL

Wait ends, weight off shoulders



Mirabai Chanu finished second in women's 49kg category with a cumulative 198kg lift. PTI

MIRABAI'S MAJOR MEDALS

OLYMPICS		
2021	SILVER	49 kg
WORLD C'SHIPS		
2017	GOLD	48 kg
2022	SILVER	49kg
2025	SILVER	48kg
ASIAN GAMES		
2026	SILVER	49kg
CWG		
2014	SILVER	48kg
2018	GOLD	48kg
2022	GOLD	49kg
2026	GOLD	48kg

Mirabai ends years of near-misses at Asiad to win silver and complete the set



Mihir Vasavda Nagoya, September 23

Weightlifter had won almost everything she could. In Nagoya, she completed the collection built by years of persistence

was supposed to be her Olympic moment. Instead, she failed to register a valid lift. Five years later, in Tokyo, she made amends with an Olympic silver. Hangzhou was supposed to finally give her the Asian Games medal that had eluded her. Instead, she finished fourth, the podium slipping away in another heartbreak. Three years later, she returned to Japan, this time to Nagoya, and won silver.

The 32-year-old, the oldest of the seven lifters in the field, lifted 198 kg - 87 kg in the snatch and 111 kg in the clean and jerk — to finish behind North Korea's Ri Song-gum. Ri completed an Asian Games golden hat-trick with a world-record 215 kg total, including a 121 kg clean and jerk.

Weight of expectations

Gold was out of reach against a fully fit Ri. But Chanu had another expectation to meet. Every time she steps on to the platform, a medal is expected. She knows it. So does everyone watching from home. And when a country has already convinced itself that its athlete will deliver, that expectation can become its own

weight. “There is pressure. Really. There is pressure,” she said. “The whole world has kept hope for me. That Mirabai will get a medal.” Yet she has also learnt to draw strength from that belief. “On the one hand, I feel strong. There is strength. People think so positively of me. They have prayed so much for me. That thing gives me more confidence.” The other side is less comfortable. “What if something is left by mistake? What will I do? Everyone is thinking that I will get a medal. If I don't get it, what will I do? There is pressure.”

For someone who has spent so long carrying expectations, the harder burden has often been getting herself back to the platform after things have gone wrong. The setbacks have not been confined to competition. A career spent pushing her body to its limits has taken a considerable toll. There have been injuries, rehabilitation and long periods of uncertainty. After Paris, where she finished fourth again, missing bronze by just 1kg, it was reasonable to wonder how much more her body could give.

Chanu, however, had not

given up on the Asian Games. Alongside Vijay Sharma, her coach and long-time presence through the peaks and troughs of her career, she kept preparing in the basement of a gym in Ghaziabad. The pursuit was no longer about proving she belonged at the top. She had done that long ago. There was simply one medal she did not have. And at 32, she knew there might not be too many more chances to win it.

That stubbornness has made Chanu more than India's most successful weightlifter of her generation.

Lasting legacy

She has been the constant in a sport that has struggled to find one. Doping offences and suspensions have repeatedly dragged Indian weightlifting into the news, while the talent pipeline has struggled to produce lifters capable of consistently challenging at Asian and world level.

Chanu has provided the counter-narrative. For much of the last decade, she has kept the sport visible by competing, winning and returning. When Indian weightlifting needed a medal, a headline or simply a

reason to believe, Chanu was usually there. In many ways, she has held the sport together at the highest level.

Which makes the question of what comes next unavoidable. There are promising lifters coming through, but nobody currently offers anything close to Chanu's combination of longevity, consistency and international achievement. Her career has stretched across generations and continued to produce medals at the biggest stages despite injuries and setbacks. There is no obvious replacement for that.

Perhaps Chanu understands that better than most. Her legacy cannot simply be the medals she leaves behind. At Sharma's academy in Ghaziabad, she is now helping develop the next generation, passing on what she has learnt through years of competing, recovering and returning. “If I can do it, others can too,” she said.

‘Weightlifting medal at Asian Games is equal to Olympics’

Mihir Vasavda Nagoya, September 23

MIRABAI CHANU arrived in the mixed zone dancing.

There was a wide smile on her face, an Indian tricolour ribbon holding her hair together, Olympic rings dangling from her ears and the Indian flag painted on one of her nails. Around her neck hung the silver medal she had spent 12 years chasing. She never took it off.

She smiled through almost every answer, occasionally breaking into a laugh, as if the weight of the medal around her neck had somehow made everything else feel lighter. “The pressure is gone. I feel very light,” she said. “This was the only thing missing. In a way, my life is complete now.”

For all that Chanu has achieved — an Olympic silver, a world title and three Commonwealth Games gold medals — there had always been one conspicuous gap. The Asian Games medal just refused to come.

She first competed at the continental event in 2014, when she did not produce the performance she wanted. In 2018, a back injury kept her out. In 2023, another injury cost her a medal. Each time, she left with the same question. “I asked myself, what happened? What is happening to me in every Asian Games?” she said. “I have everything. I have a gold medal. I am a world champion. I have an Olympic medal. I have three gold medals in the Commonwealth Games. Why am I losing the Asian Games medal?”

An overcast Wednesday in Nagoya was a ‘do or die’ situation for her to win a medal, which Chanu says was her dream since

stepping into the elite ranks. While the Olympics may be considered the pinnacle of sport, Chanu has always viewed the Asian Games differently because of the depth of weightlifting in the continent. “In Asian Games, weightlifting is more strong in Asia, as you have North Korea, China, etc. I believe that medals in Asian Games are equal to medals in Olympics,” she said. “In the Olympics, it is less, and at the Asian Games, I feel it is more difficult.”

The difficulty was not just in the field. It was in getting herself to the start line. After the Commonwealth Games, there was little time to prepare. She had to keep her body weight within the 49kg category, while recovering from the injuries that have punctuated the latter part of her career. She spoke of the challenge almost matter-of-factly, but there was little doubt about the effort involved.

“It was very difficult for me to control my weight. It was very difficult for me to maintain 48. It was very difficult for me to maintain 49,” she said. In training, she would stay around 50.5kg, about 1.5kg above her competition category. That meant managing the demands of heavy training while keeping her weight under control. It was another balancing act for a body that had already endured years of elite competition and injury.

53kg challenge

And perhaps that is what made this medal feel like the end of a chapter. The 49kg category, which has been part of Chanu's competitive life for years, is disappearing from her Olympic horizon. Los Angeles, in a couple of years, begins at 53kg.

That means the next challenge will not simply be to compete at another Games, but also to build a different body for it. Chanu is already thinking about that transition, with the primary focus being on adding the right kind of weight without sacrificing the strength that has carried her through a long career.

“We don't have to gain weight to compete in 53. We have to get the muscle ready first,” she said. “If I suddenly gain weight, my performance could go down and I could also lose strength.”

The plan, she explained, is to increase her weight while protecting her strength — more muscle, less unnecessary fat, and a carefully managed diet. “What to eat? What else do I have to change in my diet?” Chanu, who has already consulted a nutritionist, said. “If we get 53, then our strength can go. We have to control our weight with strength.”

Mirabai Chanu won an Asiad medal in her third attempt. ANI



● NEW HORIZON

Once a tool to curb mischief, soft tennis obsession earns Jay historic medal

Pritish Raj New Delhi, September 23

AS JAY Meena walked towards the podium to collect his bronze medal in Soft Tennis at the Asian Games — a first-ever for India in the sport — all he did was breathe a sigh of relief.

“More than anything, I was relieved. We had lost two medal chances in mixed doubles and men's doubles before that. So, just the thought that I'll return empty handed gave me chills the night before,” Jay tells *The Indian Express* from Japan. He lost to Japan's Takuya Kurosaka 2-3 in the semifinal but had assured the medal.

It is poetic that the child, who was admitted to Soft Tennis so that he stayed away from mischief, became the first to win a medal for his

country in the country where the sport was born.

Soft Tennis barely had any footprint in India; nor was there a sporting hero. His father put him on a softball court to curb his naughty side.

“I was a restless kid, honestly. I was rusticated for one such mischief when I was in fourth standard and wasn't getting admission anywhere,” says Jay.

“Then I got admission at the Pioneer Public school and there were two soft tennis courts. The courts always fascinated me,” he adds.

Once his father realised his energy can be channelled into the sport, he started pushing him.

“During summer breaks, my father constantly asked me to hit the court and play soft tennis. Once I started,

time flew fast. I started winning medals quickly at the national level. In no time, I am here standing on the Asian Games podium,” Jay gushes.

Inspiring his cousin

Interestingly, Jay's journey as a sportsperson inspired his youngest cousin, Dev Meena, who is the national record holder in Pole Vault. “I took up sport after looking at Jay bhaiya. He is the inspiration behind my sporting journey. Right now, I am more tense about his medal as he was very close last time,” Dev had told this masthead before leaving for Japan.

Jay says his brother's achievements fill him with pride. “What do I say about him? Whenever I see him breaking the national record, it makes me feel proud. Sadly,



Jay Meena became the first Indian to win an Asian Games medal in soft tennis. PTI

Reaching the podium was not the difficult part for Jay, who hails from Madhya Pradesh. But convincing people that soft tennis, one of Lawn Tennis's oldest spin-offs, was as serious a sport as other variations, certainly was.

I won't be there to cheer for him later during his competition as I'm leaving tomorrow, but I am confident he will come back with a medal.”

Reaching the podium was not the difficult part for Jay,

who hails from Dewas in Madhya Pradesh. But convincing people that soft tennis, one of Lawn Tennis's oldest spin-offs, was as serious a sport as other variations, certainly was.

To the uninitiated, he explains the difference between the two. “There are a few basic differences but overall the core of the game is the same,” says Jay. “Balls in soft tennis are very light and so are the racquets, which make all the difference.”

Neglected sport

It is played in straight points format like badminton rather than the usual point system of tennis. Singles is played in a best of seven format with four points being the winning point while the doubles games are best-of-nine affairs.

“The light ball plays an important role. It's unlike tennis where the power on the ball allows it to travel. In soft tennis, the athletes have to use their own power rather than relying on the opponent's shots to angle a return. Since the ball is light, it is affected by wind in the arena also. All of this makes it physically intense,” explains Jay.

Jay hopes that the medal will bring the much needed spotlight on the otherwise neglected sport.

“There is infrastructure, there is talent and there are players, all we need is investment. I had no support apart from the Sports Ministry's Target Asian Games scheme. I am still without a job, if my medal can bring more limelight to the sport, I think that will be my real victory,” he signs off.

Changes in team rocking boat, say rowers; federation says new strategy needed

Mihir Vasavda
Nagoya, September 23

A SERIES of last-minute crew changes in India's men's rowing team has triggered a controversy, with players saying a top federation official warned them that their "future would be ruined" and even told them to return to India if they didn't agree to the new teams.

Denying any "heated conversation", the Rowing Federation of India (RFI) president, Balaji Maradapa, blamed "outside forces" for the crisis.

He said they needed to change the teams as the rowing competition had been shrunk to two days.

The confrontation came on the eve of the rowing competition at the Asian Games, which began in Gifu on Wednesday.

The rowers' anger centred on the decision to break up es-

tablished crews just two days before the competition, with athletes moved between events and reserve rowers brought into first-team combinations.

For instance, the quartet of Babulal Yadav, Jaswinder Singh, Nitin Kumar and Yogesh Kumar were selected for the men's four team initially and had trained together for the past six months. However, Jaswinder and Nitin were removed, and replaced by Saurav Kumar and Vipul Ghurde.

The event has been included in seven Asian Games editions and India has won a medal in six of those, including a bronze at the Hangzhou Asian Games.

On Wednesday, the team finished fourth in its heat with a time of 6:30.47 and was eliminated.

Saying that they were speaking on behalf of the team, two

rowers said the changes had shattered team combinations that had been built over seven to eight months of preparation. Some of them discussed skipping the training session on Tuesday or going on strike, but returned to practice following talks with officials and coaches, they said.

The rowers, who did not want to be named for fear of being targeted, alleged that when they appealed against the changes to the coaches and the federation, their concerns were dismissed.

They said Maradapa told them that their refusal to race would have no impact on him and warned them about the consequences on their careers.

"We requested so much, we said please fix it. They said it can't be done," one rower said. "The RFI president shouted at us. He said, 'If you don't race,

“The team that was chosen by the selection committee has been changed completely. All of us are saddened and disappointed by what has happened at the last minute. We are in such depression that we don't know what to do.”

AN INDIAN ROWER
AT THE ASIAN GAMES

nothing will happen to me. I will enjoy life. Your future will be ruined. If you don't want to race, then book tickets and go

“I spoke to about eight fellows. I told them: ‘You look at your future. You have a long future ahead. I am talking to you like you are my children. Think what is good for you and don't get monitored by somebody who's ten thousand kilometres away.’”

BALAJI MARADAPA
PREZ, ROWING FEDERATION

back (to India).' This incident happened on Tuesday morning," the rower said. When contacted, Maradapa

said he spoke to the rowers, but "it wasn't a heated conversation". He blamed 'outside forces' for the crisis.

"I spoke to about eight fellows. I told them: 'You look at your future. You have a long future ahead. I am talking to you like you are my children. Think what is good for you and don't get monitored by somebody who's ten thousand kilometres away,'" he said.

Defending the move, Maradapa said that since the rowing programme had been compressed from four days to two days due to Typhoon Dujuan, they had to devise a fresh strategy for the Games. He said the changes were made after consultation with chief coach Anthony Patterson, and argued that athletes could not be expected to compete in multiple events in such a compressed window.

The rowers, however, said the changes ignored the demands of a sport in which combinations are built over time. "You can't just get a person sitting next to you and row with him... It takes a lot of time to have that level of coordination," said a rower.

The disruption, the rowers said, went beyond disappointment. It affected the mood and routine of the entire camp on the eve of the competition. "I was very disappointed. The morale of the team has gone down. Nobody ate, nobody felt like eating," said a rower.

Another described the atmosphere as one of despair. "The team that was chosen by the selection committee has been changed completely. All of us are saddened and disappointed by what has happened at the last minute. We are in such depression that we don't

know what to do," he said.

According to the rowers, the original combinations gave them a realistic chance of continuing India's strong record in the sport at the Asian Games. At the previous Asian Games in Hangzhou, India won five rowing medals — two silver and three bronze. This time, after the upheaval, four Indian men's boats have reached the finals. A women's crew, too, is in contention for a medal.

"We have always won medals in rowing at the Asian Games," one said.

"We had given the coaches assurance that we would continue that tradition. If our crew gets back, we will win the medal. But they refused. This is the hardest we had worked (before the Games). We did everything that was asked of us. But the changes two days before the race has impacted us a lot."

Pragg, Gukesh help India edge past English challenge

Mayank Chaudhary
New Delhi, September 23

R PRAGGNANANDHAA and D Gukesh stepped up and delivered once again as defending champions India bounced back from their painful loss to Uzbekistan, edging past England 2.5-1.5 in Round 7 of the 2026 Chess Olympiad in Samarkand on Wednesday.

The recovery came on a bitersweet afternoon for Nihal Sarin, who was dealt his second straight defeat at the Olympiad.

On Board 3 with the black pieces, Nihal took the fight to Luke McShane for the better part of the contest. But the Englishman proved unyielding. McShane weathered Nihal's sustained pressure, navigated the chaotic time scramble just before the first time control, and held his nerve in the endgame. Fending off wave after wave of attack, McShane eventually turned the tables to blunt Nihal's resistance and claim the full point. By then, however, India's victory had already been sealed.

India repeated the exact winning template from their Round 5 triumph over the Netherlands with Pragg striking on the top board and Gukesh supplying the decisive punch from Board 4.

Pragg opened India's account in style, taking down the experienced Nikita Vitiugov with the black pieces to log his second win of the tournament. Barely a minute later, Arjun Erigaisi and England's talisman Michael Adams shook hands for a peaceful 40-move draw on Board 2.

That set the stage for Gukesh. Facing Daniel Howard Fernandez, the reigning World Champion pounced on a slip on the 40th move amid the time scramble. With 30 additional minutes added to his clock, Gukesh relentlessly tightened the screws, converting the advantage into a full point to lock up the match for India.

In the women's section, Germany was tipped to test the defending champions, but a ruthless 3.5-0.5 sweep by India dismantled any hopes of an upset.

10M AIR PISTOL

India's search for shooting gold continues as Manu, team miss

Highly-rated team finishes fourth; in individual event Olympic medallist Manu Bhaker is fifth in 8-woman final

Shashank Nair
New Delhi, September 23

INDIA'S AVERAGE start to its shooting campaign at the 2026 Asian Games in Aichi-Nagoya extended into its fourth day without a gold medal in sight. While the men's and women's skeet teams won a bronze each, worryingly, it was the one event where the Indians had sent their strongest group, which failed to find its mark.

Esha Singh is currently the No.2 ranked 10m air pistol shooter in the world, and Suruchi Singh Phogat, a young phenom who took the world of shooting by storm in her debut year, winning three World Cups including a stacked Munich edition, is ranked third in the world. The duo, along with Paris Olympic double bronze medallist Manu Bhaker rounding the team off, are a formidable pistol trio that is easily among the best in the world on any given day.

But on Wednesday, the sport of shooting threw a curveball at the Indians, once again showcasing that the consistency of scores is never a given and medals scarcely a guarantee. India failed to pick up an individual honour, and even missed out on team accolades despite the star-studded lineup. Hangzhou lent itself three medals in the same event, but Aichi came up empty-handed.

"Bad day in the office," admitted coach Ronak Pandit from Aichi on Wednesday. "Manu did well both in qualification and finals, no doubt. Suruchi and Esha gave it their all honestly but unfortunately this is all that could muster today. It happens, that is sport. But of course there will be some analysing to find out if there is anything that came in the way. First emotions have to calm down

and when the mind is rational, we shall analyse and plug gaps."

Bhaker was the only bright spot in the dark skies that were B-roll for broadcasters on Wednesday as Typhoon Dujuan lashed Japan. On a day where the best that a shooter could muster in qualification was a low score of 582, Bhaker finished third with a score of 579 and with it, third in qualification. Esha hit 572 with just 12 inner tens, and Suruchi went lower, managing a poor score of 568 with twelve inner tens. Both of India's ranked, in-form shooters, handed in a seriously questionable shift at work.

Suruchi in particular faltered spectacularly in her first-ever multi-sport event. It was a crushing blow young into her career, hitting three 93s and a 94 in qualification on a day where the competition and the magnitude of the event was prime for a crowning.

On Suruchi, the Indian pistol coach said, "After scoring centuries a cricketer does get out on a duck. It is sport, it happens. Of course she put in the hard work and tried her best even today but at the end of the day she is human and there is absolutely no margin for error. Sad and unfortunate that it happened at the Games but as the coaching team we will definitely take this seriously and debrief them to understand and fix the problem because we anticipated and prepared for every eventuality and yet fell short so the entire team has to work on it, not just the athlete," he added.

After the adrenaline of the poor showing had passed, Pandit admitted, "Sometimes all they need is a pat on the back for fighting. And they did fight hard."

According to the Indian coach, nothing outward was happening that saw reduced



Double Olympic medallist Manu Bhaker was far from her best on Wednesday. PTI

“After scoring centuries a cricketer does get out on a duck. It is sport, it happens. Of course she put in the hard work and tried her best even today but at the end of the day she is human and there is absolutely no margin for error.”

RONAK PANDIT
PISTOL COACH ON
SURUCHI PHOGAT

qualification scores among the shooters. "No, conditions had no role to play, that was fine," he said.

Nerves at play

In her broadcast interview Manu Bhaker said, "The qualifications were a challenge. I was really positive, but also very nervous. For the finals as well, I was genuinely trying for every shot every time."

Bhaker was the lone shooter from India who qualified for the finals. The seasoned medallist rarely pushes domestically anymore but stirs into life at bigger events. On Wednesday, her 20 inner tens in qualification were a sign that among the

three Indians, only she was truly up for it.

But the finals painted a different story where Bhaker was finding shots in the low 10s and high 9s but never into the mid 10s that are the hallmark of a form shooter. She exited the competition in fifth position. "I feel that I've improved a lot in terms of my 10m performances — qualifications as well as finals," said Bhaker afterwards. Both she and Esha Singh have the 25m pistol event to look forward to next.

India has now won seven medals at the shooting events at the Asiad. But that elusive yellow metal continues to evade four days in.

BADMINTON

Sen, Shetty fade as China expose India's tournament fitness



Lakshya Sen lost 16-21, 18-21 to World No. 6 Shi Yuqi . REUTERS

Shivani Naik
Mumbai, September 23

THE TAKEAWAY from India's Asian Games men's team semifinal loss was something they have never traditionally been great at — maintaining fitness levels deep into a draw. After a brilliant takedown of Japan in the quarters that ensured a bronze medal, both Lakshya Sen and Ayush Shetty couldn't raise their levels against top Chinese, as India lost 3-1 to the serial title contenders.

Kidambi Srikanth in Hangzhou 2023, and Sen and Ayush this time, couldn't maintain the momentum on big medal days. Pitted against a perfectly calibrated Chinese machine, Wednesday's semifinal became a fade-out of energy less than 24 hours after the high-tempo Japan win.

Big medals require turning up dialled in on back-to-back knockout days. And Sen and Ayush simply looked spent against a higher-quality opponent with the short turnaround. With both singles lost, Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty's fantastic 21-11, 22-20 win over newly crowned world champions Liang Weikeng-Wang Chang remained that 1 point of resistance.

Running on empty

Sen has stepped up on big days before, notably beating Shi Yuqi at the 2022 Thomas Cup and 2023 Asian Games. But while the intensity of every rally was unforgiving — and Yuqi is a World No 1 of August vintage, also a Teams event beast — Sen also didn't have enough in his fuel tank to push a decider.

Sen defended well, worked the angles and produced a bunch of rousing winners. But the hard-fought points brought few returns, in the 21-16, 21-18 loss, as Yuqi was imperious in the net charge and rained down attacks more often than Sen could defend. Sen didn't play badly, but he never looked like winning either.

Facing the world champions Liang-Wang next, Satwik-Chirag smoothly put down the hesitant Chinese, with the Chirag-attack keeping the shuttle buzzing and Satwik going for body smashes that kept the dangerous Wang Chang busy on the back court and away from the net. With the scores 1-1, Ayush Shetty formed the pivot taking on Li Shifeng.

Shi Yuqi is down to World No 6, and Li Shifeng has been low-key for a while, having plunged to No 12, but they seemed primed to peak at the

Asian Games, and Shifeng got Ayush into one right tangle. Ayush played delectably at the net, and his smashes whistled, but he was left stranded at the backline as Shifeng sent high lifts and clears, testing his ability to connect the smash. Ayush fumbled, dumping them into the net, his arms appearing tired. And his chances at the net saw him linger too long and play less sharply, which meant Shifeng grew in confidence. The Indian imploded quite a bit to lose 21-19, 21-13. Ayush seemed patchy if not flat after yesterday's exertions.

Singles concern

The team campaign will leave coaches scratching their heads: none of the five singles players fielded across the men's and women's knockouts won. The only wins came from Satwik-Chirag and Treesa-Gayatri in doubles.

For the 2022 Thomas Cup-winning squad that boasted of singles depth, India might seem in trouble in 2026 after this semis loss. At any rate, the 'tournament fitness' of back-to-back matches for Sen and Ayush left a lot to be desired. A second straight medal, an Asian Games team bronze, though, will be deservedly feted.

In the last-gasp second doubles, Hariharan Amsakuran and MR Arjun played a spectacular mid-set against He Ji Ting and Liu Yi, whose coordination was quite off, as young Hari showed promise with his 'Little Satwik' style. But they were hammered in the last set, losing 17-21, 21-17, 21-9.

Doubles coach Tan Kim Her

later came out and declared

that Hari too showed dropping energy in the third. "Hari-Arjun tried their very best. First set was physically tough. But Hari's energy dropped quite a bit," he stressed.

On the tie defeat, he reiterated that the Sen match was crucial. "Everyone gave their best. But the first match was important. That point from Lakshya. If he could've gone into the rubber game (decider) against Shi Yuqi, we stood a good chance. Unfortunately, he...but he tried his best. Satwik-Chirag were very good in how we managed to control the front play (front court). Chirag played well in front. Defending was solid. For singles, we expected Ayush to get a point. But it was the same. First set - had he won, everything could've been different."

That was too many things not going right to dream of beating China at Asiad.

● TRIUMPHANT TRIO

Women who grew up around shotguns win skeet bronze

Nitin Sharma
Chandigarh, September 23

THREE GIRLS, three grandfathers, three houses with guns in them. That is where India's first women's skeet team medal at the Asian Games actually began, years before any of them picked up a shotgun of their own. Raiza Dhillon grew up between a village in Haryana — where her mother Gul Dhillon is the sarpanch — and the family home in Panchkula. She tried tennis, swimming, Bharatanatyam and Kathak first. What she kept coming back to were the guns.

"My grandfather and Raiza's great grandfather Jagirdar Gurinder Singh Dhillon owned more than 20 guns, and my father Daljit Singh Dhillon owns some shotguns," says her

father, Ravijit Singh Dhillon.

She trained at Patiala under coach Amrinder Singh Cheema, since Panchkula had no shotgun range of its own. "Her right cheek still has many black marks due to the placement of the shotgun, but she would not worry," her father says.

Parinaaz Dhalliwal's fascination began the same way, at her family's village of Thikriwala near Barnala, where her great grandfather Gurkirat Pal Singh Dhalliwal kept shotguns. She grew up hearing the elders' hunting stories from before 1971. She started with an air rifle at Mayo College in Ajmer at 14, moved to the shotgun two years later, and broke into the junior and then senior national teams soon after. Her father, Rattandeep Dhalliwal, remembers what the sport cost

her before it gave her anything back. "There were days in summers when her hands would suffer blisters with the friction of the firearm," he says.

Maheshwari Chauhan started at 12, seeing her grandfather Dhanpat Singh's guns at their village of Siana in Rajasthan. She too began on an air rifle at Mayo College before asking to switch to the shotgun, and she was small enough at the time that her equipment had to be built around her rather than the other way round. "We had to do stock modifications on her gun, and later when she was selected in junior national teams, coaches worked on her strength," says her father, Pradeep Singh.

On Tuesday, the three of them combined for a score of 331, behind only China's 357 and Ka-



(L to R): India's Raiza Dhillon, Maheshwari Chauhan and Parinaaz Dhalliwal with their bronze medals. PTI

zakhstan's 336, for team bronze. Dhillon finished eighth individually, Dhalliwal ninth, Chauhan twelfth, and none of them made the individual final. It was, on paper, a day of near-misses. The women's skeet mixed team event has existed at the Asian

Games only since 1990, and has mostly belonged to China, Korea, Kazakhstan and North Korea since. India had never stood on that podium before.

Anantjeet Singh Naruka, the Hangzhou silver medallist and Paris Olympic mixed team